

NOT A POTATO

THE SERPENT'S AGE



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Chapter 1 — Arrival: The Ridge and the Road

The van came up the last grade with the fan belt singing a note Frik had named — F-sharp, off by a quarter-tone — and the fog let go of the ridge the way a hand lets go of something it's been holding all night.

"Bridge," Frik said. Then, lower, to nobody: "Bridge. *Bridge.*" The word wanted out three times and got out three times, and that was the toll, and once it was paid he could look at the actual bridge — a little county overpass, gone behind them now — and see it for what it was, which was nothing. Concrete and rust. The tic took the word and he took the world. Fair trade. He'd explained it to people who did not need it explained and stopped explaining it to the ones who did.

Lens was in the passenger seat with the camera already up, lens cap in her teeth, shooting the fog through the windshield. She did that — shot before she knew what she was shooting, then found out later what had been in the frame. Right now it was trees, gray on gray, and the white going off the grass in long slow exhalations, and somewhere under all that the shape they'd driven nineteen hours to look at.

"You can't see it yet," she said around the cap. "I keep wanting it to be visible from the road. It isn't."

"It's a serpent on the ground," Frik said. "You're standing in it before you see it. That's the whole — that's the whole point of it, probably. Probably. Don't quote me." He cracked the window and the morning came in smelling of warm wet grass and motor oil and, under it, the green rot-and-thrive smell of a forest that had been a forest a long

time. Cicadas hadn't started. Too early. They'd start.

Daljit was in the back, laptop open on a milk crate, three windows of the same dataset arranged so the columns lined up across them, because he could not abide columns that did not line up. "Parking lot's empty," he said. "One truck. Foundation's not here at eight in the morning. Foundations sleep in." He said it flat, the way he said most things, and it was an observation and a small dry joke at once and you had to know him to know it was both.

Frik parked the van crooked across two spaces because the lines didn't make sense to him and he wasn't going to pretend they did. The engine ticked. Out the windshield: a low building, half-museum half-gift-shop, brown wood and a brown sign, GREAT SERPENT MOUND, the letters routed into a board and painted, somebody's careful hand a long time ago. Beyond it the ground did a thing the ground is not supposed to do.

It rolled wrong.

Frik felt it before he had the word for it, which was unusual, the feeling before the word, and it bothered him. The land lifted and fell in a way that wasn't hills. Hills have a logic — water cuts them, they slump downhill, they make sense if you watch the rain. This didn't. The ridge sat inside a bowl that sat inside another rise, like something had been dropped here from a great height and the earth had splashed and frozen mid-splash.

"It's the crater," Daljit said, reading his face in the mirror. "We're standing on the rim of it. Serpent Mound Cryptoexplosion Structure. Something hit here — meteorite, or a gas-charged explosion from below, the geologists still argue — three hundred million, give or take, and it shattered the bedrock in a ring about five miles wide. The rock's tilted and faulted under us. That's why it feels like that." He paused. "It's supposed to feel like that."

"I don't love how much it feels like that," Lens said. She had the cap out of her teeth now.

They got out. The doors of the van shut at three different times because the doors of the van always shut at three different times, and the sound went out across the lot and didn't come back — no echo, the trees ate it — and that was the first thing Frik noticed about the

place, that it was quiet the way a held breath is quiet, and he filed it under *will-matter-later* without knowing why.

The visitor center smelled of carpet and decades. A teenager with a lanyard waved them through. Inside, behind glass, the place explained itself with the patience of a thing that has explained itself to a million schoolkids.

Frik read the panels the way he read everything, fast and total, mouth moving.

THE GREAT SERPENT MOUND, the first one said, is the largest documented serpent effigy in the world. More than 1,300 feet long. An uncoiling snake, its body looping through seven curves, a tight spiral at the tail, and at the head an open oval — an egg, a frog, an eye, the sun being swallowed, depending on who you asked and the panel was honest enough to list a few of who-you-asked.

“It’s not a burial mound,” Frik said out loud, to Lens, who already knew, because he had to say the true thing when he saw the true thing or it sat in him like a stone. “People think it’s a burial mound. It isn’t. There’s nobody in it. The burials are over there—” he pointed through the wall, roughly, toward the conical mounds beyond the trees “—those are Adena, those have people in them. But the snake’s empty. Whatever it’s for, it’s not for the dead.” He blinked. “*Empty*. Empty. Sorry.”

“Don’t be sorry,” said Lens, who never asked him to be.

The next panel was the one they’d come for, and it was the one that did the impossible thing, which was tell the truth about not knowing.

WHO BUILT IT? WHEN?

And then, fairly, generously, two answers that could not both be right.

One column gave the Adena. The old answer, the long-standing one. Build it from the artifacts and the shape — the effigy-mound habit, the conical burial mounds right there beside it, full of Adena dead. Date it the way you’d date its neighbors: somewhere in the long window of the Adena world, eight hundred years before Christ to a century after, call the working figure around 320 BCE. Two thousand three hundred

years old. A snake older than most of the cathedrals on earth, older than the idea of most of them.

The other column gave the Fort Ancient. Newer answer, sharper teeth. In 1996 a University of Cincinnati team — Lepper and the others — went down into the mound itself, took charcoal from under the built-up earth, ran the radiocarbon, and got something that landed near 1070 CE. *Plus or minus seventy years.* A snake younger than the Domesday Book. Eleventh century. Fort Ancient people, a different culture, a thousand-odd years downstream of the Adena, building a great snake on top of a place the Adena had already loved.

Frik read both columns twice. His jaw worked.

“That’s a thousand-year argument,” he said. “That’s not — those aren’t close. That’s not ‘we think it’s roughly this.’ That’s two answers a millennium apart and both of them are on this wall under glass because the museum can’t pick either.”

“Can’t, or won’t,” said Daljit, who had drifted up beside him with his hands in his pockets.

“Can’t.” Frik’s certainty came out hard. “The charcoal under the mound dates to 1070. That’s real, that’s a real number, that’s a lab. But charcoal under a mound dates the charcoal. It dates the last time something burned there. People reused these places. Somebody could’ve burned a fire on Adena ground in 1070 and somebody else built the snake around the ash a hundred years before — or the fire’s from the builders and it’s Fort Ancient clean. The artifacts say one thing, the carbon says another, and they—” he tapped the glass, once, “—they put both up because they’re honest. I respect the wall. The wall’s not lying. The wall just doesn’t *know*.”

It came out of him like relief. The wall didn’t know, and the wall said so, and Frik loved a thing that admitted what it didn’t have.

“And here’s the part that gets me,” he went on, lower, because the part that got him was the part he half wanted to keep. “Whoever built it, whenever — they put the head on the summer solstice sunset. That’s checked. Hively and Horn, the Earlham astronomers, ’82. The head points right at where the sun goes down on the longest day. That’s not the carbon and it’s not the artifacts, that’s just—” he made a flat gesture toward the wall and the ridge beyond it. “That’s just

true, on the ground, every June, no matter who you think made it.”

Lens had the camera down at her hip, not shooting, just listening.

“So the two camps agree the sun lines up,” she said. “They just can’t agree who was standing here to watch it.”

“They can’t agree by a thousand years,” Frik said. “Yeah.”

He let it sit. The cicadas started outside, the first one, then the chorus, a wall of sound that rose and held.

They came out the back of the center onto the overlook trail and the trees opened and there it was. Not all at once — it didn’t do all-at-once, Lens had been right — but in pieces through the oaks, a long low ridge of mown grass humped above the rest of the ground, a curve, then another curve, the body of the thing turning away into the woods, and at the far end the spiral of the tail wound tight as a fern. You couldn’t see the head from here. The head was way down the ridge, pointing where it pointed.

It was just grass over earth. It had no right to do what it did to the back of Frik’s neck.

“There,” said Daljit. Not at the snake. Past it.

Down the ridge, beyond the second coil, a woman knelt over a grid of string and little flags. White flags, a coordinate grid laid out tight, and a cylinder of pale dirt in her gloved hands that she was turning to the light. A core sample. Beside her a hand-auger, a clipboard weighted with a stone, a battered ground-penetrating radar cart parked on the grass like a lawnmower from the future. She wore a sun hat and a field vest gone soft with washing, and she worked without hurry and without waste, every motion put exactly where it needed to be.

“Tallchief,” said Daljit. “Dr. Mara Tallchief. That’s her.”

Lens raised the camera. Got her in frame — and then, slowly, lowered it. She didn’t shoot. Frik saw her not shoot, and thought it was the most interesting thing she’d done all morning.

“Not yet,” Lens said. “She doesn’t know we’re here. She gets to know we’re here first.”

Frik watched the woman work. He could see, even at this distance, what the core was telling her — or telling itself, anyway — by the way she kept turning it, looking for a line in the dirt that would say *this layer, this is where they started*, and the way her thumb kept going back to the same band of color like it should mean something and wouldn't say what. He knew that motion. He'd done it over data. It was the motion of a person asking a true question of a thing that had decided, today, to be quiet.

"She's got a problem," Frik said quietly. "The core's not closing for her either."

"It hasn't closed for anybody in thirty years," Daljit said. "Why would it close for her this week."

"This week's different," Frik said, and didn't know yet how he knew that, except that the lot had been near empty and a foundation that sleeps in does not sleep in the week it buys a place.

The voice came from behind them, friendly, unhurried, the voice of a man who has never once had to raise it.

"Beautiful, isn't she? Gets everybody. First time you crest that trail."

He was younger than Frik expected and dressed the way money dresses when it wants to look like it isn't — pressed shirt, no tie, sleeves done one fold, lanyard with a logo Frik had seen on the back roads twice already that morning, on a polo, on a drone case. Clean shoes for a muddy ridge. He'd come up quiet and stood at an easy distance and held out his hand, and his smile was real, that was the thing Frik clocked first and held onto: the smile was real. This was a man who believed in something.

"Eric Sandoval. Heritage Foundation. You're the documentary folks — we got word you might come up." He shook all three hands, and got each name, and used them. "Frik. Daljit. And you must be Lens." A small nod at the camera, friendly. "I'm a fan of doing this right. Truly. There's a way to tell this story that finally does it justice, and—" he turned, took in the ridge, the woman down on the grass, the long impossible curve of the body, and his face when he looked at it was the face of a man looking at something he loved. "—and the world

doesn't know it yet. That's a crime, honestly. That this is here and most of the planet's never heard of it."

He reached into a folio under his arm and came out with a brochure, heavy stock, the cover a photograph of the head shot at golden hour with the sun going down dead on the point of it, and across the sky in clean type: THE FIRST AMERICANS' MASTERPIECE. WORLD HERITAGE EXPERIENCE. He held it out, and he held Frik's eye while he did it, warm, certain, generous.

"We're going to settle it," Eric said. "The age, the people, the meaning — all of it. Give it a story the world can hold onto. And we'd love your help." The brochure stayed out there in the warm air, between them, the sun on the snake's head shining off the paper. "Help us tell the world the truth."

Down the ridge, Dr. Tallchief set the core sample back in its tray, very carefully, and did not turn around, and the cicadas roared, and the empty serpent kept whatever it was keeping.

Chapter 2 — The Official Story: Settling the Serpent

Lens found the frame before she found the words for it: a man in a salmon-colored polo, kneeling in the grass beside the serpent's third coil, holding a tablet up to the light so it wouldn't glare. Behind him the drone hung at maybe sixty feet, motionless, a black mosquito against a sky going the color of skim milk. He wasn't looking at the mound. He was looking at the screen, where the mound was rendered in clean wireframe, every coil smoothed into a curve a printer could love.

She shot it anyway. The real serpent and its flattened twin in the same frame. Then she lowered the camera, because that was the deal she made with herself most mornings now — shoot it, look at it, decide whether it earned the keeping. This one earned it.

The cicadas were going hard. Eight in the morning and already the heat was a presence, sitting on the ridge like something with weight. The grass smelled like warm bread. Down the slope the land did the thing it did here, the thing nobody warned you about: it rolled wrong. Not hills, exactly. The ground heaved and dipped in a way that didn't match the rivers or the weather, because four hundred million years ago something had come down out of that same milk-colored sky and punched a crater into the bedrock, and the serpent was lying along the rim of the wound like a stitch.

Lens liked that nobody on the ridge seemed to feel it but her. Or maybe they all did and only she let it show on her face.

"You're the photographer." The salmon polo had stood up. Up close he was younger than the kneel had suggested, and his lanyard

said ERIC SANDOVAL, HERITAGE FOUNDATION, and under that, in smaller type, *Project Lead — World Heritage Experience*. He had the open, tired face of a man who'd flown a lot of red-eyes for a cause he genuinely believed in. "We're glad you're documenting. Honestly. The more eyes the better."

"Lens." She didn't offer the camera's history and he didn't ask.

"We're not the bad guys here." He said it lightly, like a joke he'd worn smooth. "Everybody comes up the ridge expecting bulldozers. We're not paving anything. The effigy's untouchable — it's a National Historic Landmark, it's on the *tentative* World Heritage list already, which is exactly the point." He turned the tablet so she could see. A rendering. A long, low visitor complex tucked into the trees below the overlook, glass and reclaimed timber, a theater, a spiral walkway that echoed the tail. It was, she had to admit, not ugly. "Interpretive center. Theater experience. We move the parking out of the viewshed, we put the story in front of three hundred thousand people a year instead of forty. We give them an answer they can hold onto."

"An answer."

"A narrative." He had the grace to wince at his own word. "People need a *when*. They need a *who*. You can't put 'we're not sure' on the entrance signage and expect anybody to drive three hours from Columbus."

Behind him a second surveyor was walking the spiral of the tail with a rover unit, GPS pole over her shoulder like a fishing rod, planting flags. Each flag a little orange tongue licking up out of the grass. Lens counted them without meaning to. The tail had seven coils. The flags didn't care about the coils.

"Timeline?" she asked, because Frik would ask, and Frik wasn't here yet, and somebody had to.

"Acquisition memorandum's signed by the state historical society by end of summer. Design-development through the winter. Ground-breaking's targeted for the solstice next year." He said it like the date had charm. Maybe it did. "There's a press kit. The phrase we're leading with is *Mystery, Solved*. Soft launch in the fall."

"Solved," Lens repeated.

“Resolved,” he corrected, and she watched the word cost him something, a small private toll. “We’ve commissioned a consensus statement. A panel. We’d love Dr. Tallchief’s name on it. We’d love it *first*.”

The visitor center, when she walked down to it, was a low brick building doing two jobs at once and tired of both. Half museum — dim cases, a topographic model of the mound under acrylic gone cloudy with sixty years of fingertips — half gift shop, where a rack of polished agate spun slowly and a shelf of mass-printed *Mysteries of the Serpent Mound* paperbacks sat next to a tray of arrowheads sourced, the tag admitted in small print, from elsewhere.

A docent was rehearsing. She didn’t see Lens come in, or she saw her and decided a camera was scenery. She was maybe sixty, cardigan against the building’s aggressive air conditioning, and she was talking to the empty floor in the cadence of someone laying track.

“—and so when we look at the Great Serpent Mound, the question everyone asks is *how old*.” A beat for an imaginary tour group’s nod. “For most of the twentieth century, archaeologists agreed: the Adena people, around two thousand years ago. But in 1996, a team from the University of Cincinnati took charcoal from *underneath* the mound, and radiocarbon dating told a different story—” The docent’s hand made a smoothing gesture, settling a tablecloth. “—around the year ten-seventy. The Fort Ancient culture. So the answer, ladies and gentlemen, is that science has given us a date.” A small triumphant lift. “Ten-seventy.”

Lens kept the camera at her hip. The lens cap was off. She didn’t raise it. The docent was kind, and the docent was wrong in the specific way that kind people get wrong when somebody hands them a brochure.

A second voice, from the door: “That’s the new script?”

Dr. Mara Tallchief had come in out of the heat, field vest, a core sampler in a canvas roll over one shoulder, dust to the knee of her jeans. She wasn’t unkind about it. She was looking at the docent the way you look at someone you’ve decided to be patient with on purpose.

The docent flushed. “They sent it down last week. From the foundation. They want everybody on the same—”

“I know they do.” Mara set the canvas roll on the counter, gently, and the agate rack spun on, oblivious. “Carol. The 1996 date is real. Lepper and the rest, charcoal from a basal context, calibrated to around ten-seventy plus or minus seventy. That’s a good study. It’s in the literature.” She paused. “And the older dates are also real.”

The docent waited.

“It’s all right to say both,” Mara said. “It’s all right to say we don’t know.”

“They said the signage can’t say we don’t know.”

“I know what they said.” Mara’s mouth did something that wasn’t quite a smile.

Lens lowered the camera then — not the body, the eye, the *seeing*. She’d come up the ridge ready to find the place’s wound, because that was the thing she did, the thing the war had left her good for: finding what shouldn’t be in the frame. What shouldn’t be in this frame was the laminated script on the counter, and the orange tongues of flag-tape up on the ridge, and a sentence — *Mystery, Solved* — built to fit on a wall.

What *should* be in the frame she didn’t have a word for yet. She’d know it when she found it.

They set the recorder up that afternoon on the overlook, where the trail bent and you could see the whole length of it: the spiral tail, the seven coils riding the contour of the ridge, the long neck running northwest toward where the sun would go down on the longest day, and the open oval at the mouth that everyone called the egg and nobody could prove was an egg.

Mara sat on the bench. The crew clustered. Frik was back — he’d been down in the lowlands all morning checking something against the river, and he came up the trail talking before he arrived, which was how you always knew it was Frik. Lens framed Mara, the serpent behind her shoulder going gold-green in the four o’clock light, and let it roll.

“Tell it straight,” Frik said, dropping onto the grass. “For the record. The whole boring official version. No editorializing.” His head jerked, a quick sideways tic, and he let it pass through him like weather. “I’ll do the editorializing.”

“I’m sure you will.” Mara faced the little recorder like she’d done it before, for grad students, for documentary crews, for tribal council. Her voice changed register — flatter, cleaner, the voice for the record.

“The Great Serpent Mound. Adams County, Ohio. An effigy mound — an earthwork built in the shape of a living thing — over thirteen hundred feet long if you follow the body from the coiled tail to the head. It represents a serpent, uncoiling. The tail is a tight spiral. There are seven bends in the body. At the head there’s an open oval feature, and the head’s long axis points northwest.” She let that sit. “Toward the summer-solstice sunset. That alignment has been studied — Hively and Horn in the early eighties, others since. On the longest day of the year, if you stand in the right place, the sun goes down off the serpent’s head. It’s not a coincidence anyone’s been able to argue away. It’s geometry, and it’s repeatable. You can check it yourself. People do, every June.”

“Who built it,” Frik said. Not a question. A prompt.

“That’s where the honest answer gets long.” Mara folded her hands. “The traditional attribution — for most of the last century — is the Adena culture. Early Woodland period. Adena built conical burial mounds, and there are Adena burial mounds right here, a few hundred yards from where we’re sitting. Artifacts, mound style, the general look of the thing — for a long time that put the serpent at roughly two thousand years old. Call it three hundred BCE, give or take, inside the broad Adena range.”

“And then ninety-six,” Frik said.

“And then ninety-six.” She nodded once. “A team took charcoal samples from soil layers beneath the effigy — undisturbed basal contexts, the layer the builders would’ve been standing on. Radiocarbon. The dates clustered around the year ten-seventy of the common era. Plus or minus seventy. That’s not Adena. That’s Fort Ancient — a later culture, Late Prehistoric, the people who were here around the time of, you know, the Norman Conquest, on the other side of the ocean. So one good, peer-reviewed study moved the serpent eleven hundred

years younger.” She paused. “And the field has been arguing about it ever since.”

“Because—” Frik started.

“Let me.” Mara’s voice stayed level. “Because both readings have evidence and both readings have holes. The 1070 charcoal is real and it’s from the right kind of context. But charcoal can wash in, can intrude, can be older or younger than the soil around it. The Adena attribution has the artifacts and the morphology and the neighboring burial mounds, but no clean construction date locked to the effigy itself. There were older radiocarbon results from the earlier work — from re-analyses of material connected to Putnam’s excavations in the eighteen-eighties — that look Adena. But those might be dating an earlier *use* of the ridge, not the building of the snake. People lived here, on and off, for a very long time. The ground remembers more than one visit.”

Lens held the frame. Behind Mara, far down the body, one of the foundation’s surveyors was walking the neck with the GPS pole, and the long shadow of the pole crossed the long shadow of the serpent’s head, and for one second on the screen the two shadows were the same thing.

“So the official story,” Mara said, and here her care became a visible, deliberate object, something she was holding out flat on her palm so no one could say she’d dropped it, “is this. We have a serpent. We have a solstice line you can stand on. We have a crater under our feet that the builders may or may not have known was strange. We have two cultures, two date ranges, eleven hundred years apart, both defended in print by people with credentials and good faith. And we have a mound that is not a burial — nobody’s buried *in* the serpent — so it wasn’t built to hold the dead.” She looked, briefly, at the camera, then away from it, back to the snake. “It was built to do something. The literature is honest that we do not, as a settled matter, know how old it is. That’s the official story. The honesty is the official story.”

It was a good answer. It was the answer a person gave when they’d been asked to sign their name to a wall and had decided, instead, to be exactly as certain as the evidence let them be and not one degree more. Lens could feel the foundation’s sentence — *Mystery, Solved* — trying to fit over what Mara had just said, and failing, the way a lid

fails on the wrong jar.

The recorder light glowed red. The cicadas surged and dropped.

"That's the story," Mara said, and reached to switch it off.

Frik got there first — not to the recorder, to the silence. He couldn't hold it. Lens watched it build, the little gathering in his shoulders, the way his jaw worked once, and she already had the shot before he opened his mouth, because she'd lived around him long enough to read the tell.

"The carbon doesn't close squat."

It came out of him whole, flat, true, into the warm gold air, over the ridge, over the seven coils. A field-trip group two hundred yards off looked up. The surveyor with the GPS pole paused.

"The ninety-six date." Frik's hand jerked; he rode it. "It's a real study, it's a good study, I'm not saying it isn't. I'm saying *one basal charcoal cluster from a couple of contexts* does not nail down when somebody built a thirteen-hundred-foot snake, and everybody in the room knows it, and the foundation wants Carol downstairs to tell three hundred thousand people a year that it's *settled*, and it is *not settled*, it is the opposite of settled, it's the most unsettled thing in North American archaeology that has a gift shop attached to it—" Another jerk. He took a breath. "Sorry. But it's true. The date doesn't close. It's never closed. That's not a scandal. That's just the fact."

Nobody spoke. Down the slope the GPS pole started moving again. The sun had dropped enough that the coils were throwing their own shadows now, each bend laying a dark twin of itself across the grass, the serpent doubling, the way it did at the end of every day on the ridge whether anyone was watching or not.

Mara hadn't switched off the recorder. The red light was still on. She was looking at Frik, and at the snake behind him, and her face had gone careful in a new way — not guarded. Considering. Like she'd just heard the question she actually wanted to answer, and was deciding, in the failing gold light, how much of it the ridge was hers to give.

"No," she said quietly. "It doesn't close."

She let it stay open.

Chapter 3 — The Potato: Digging for Certainty

Devi pushed the radar cart and the radar cart pushed back.

That was the first true thing about the morning: the wheels caught on root and rabbit-hole, the antenna box dragged, and the ridge under the Serpent did not want to be read in a straight line. Devi liked that. A surface that resisted was a surface telling you something. Smooth lies. Rough remembers.

They were walking the third coil from the tail, where the earthwork swelled in the grass like a held breath, and the screen on the handle threw up its hyperbolas — those little upside-down U's that mean *here is the top of a buried something, here is where the radio wave bounced and came home confused*. Devi read them the way other people read faces, which is to say better than other people read faces. A clean buried surface gave you a clean dark arc. What the ground was giving them this morning was not clean. It was a scribble. It was a child's drawing of a pond.

"Disturbed," Devi said. They said it flat, to the screen, because the screen had earned it.

Mara Tallchief crouched a few feet off the toe of the embankment, where a fresh core hole the diameter of a soup can went down into the ridge. She had a tray of soil beside her on a folded tarp, the column laid out in order like a sentence she was learning to read backwards. She didn't look up.

"Disturbed how," she said. Not a challenge. A request for specifics. Devi liked her for that already and distrusted the liking, because liking

was fast and the ground was slow.

“The bedding’s not bedded.” Devi turned the cart so the morning sun stopped glaring the screen. “Effigy mounds — you’d want a basket-fill signature. People hauling soil in loads, dumping, tamping. That gives you stacked lenses, little discrete bowls of fill, one after another, like —” they searched, found it — like scales. You can sometimes see them. I’m not seeing them. I’m seeing churn down to about forty centimeters and then a reflector that won’t hold still.”

“Slumping,” Mara said. “Ridge soil. Hundred-something years of plowing before anyone protected it. Putnam dug into it in the 1880s and put it back. People have been *fixing* this mound since before fixing it was a science.” She lifted a pinch of the core between thumb and finger, rolled it. “You’re not reading the original surface. You might be reading 1888.”

Devi filed that. It was the kind of fact that made the screen honest again: *the disturbance is real, it is just younger than you hoped*. The hole didn’t get cleaner. It got older in one direction and newer in another, and that, precisely, was the trouble with the whole place.

Here is the official story, stood up straight, because it deserves to stand.

The Great Serpent Mound is over thirteen hundred feet of earthen serpent laid along a ridge in Adams County, Ohio — head at one end pointed off across the valley, body in seven easy coils, the tail wound into a tight spiral like a watch-spring run down. At the head, an oval. Call it an egg, call it an eye, call it a mouth opened around the sunset; people have called it all three and the mound has not corrected them. There are no graves in the snake. That part is settled. The dead are in the round mounds nearby, Adena dead, with their copper and their carved pipes, sleeping the proper distance off, as if the serpent were a thing too important to bury anyone *in*.

What’s not settled — what has not been settled for a hundred and forty years and was not going to be settled by a girl with a radar cart this Tuesday — is *when*.

Two camps. Both serious, both published, both holding good cards.

Camp One says Adena. The old consensus. You read it in the artifacts and the shape and the company the mound keeps — those Adena burial mounds at its elbow, the style of the thing — and you land somewhere around three hundred years before the common era, give or take, a window wide enough to lose a century in. People built this for two thousand years, this camp says. The land was already holy when Rome was a village.

Camp Two says Fort Ancient. In 1996 a team out of the University of Cincinnati — Lepper among them — pulled charcoal from *under* the mound, from the soil the builders stood on, and ran it, and the carbon came back around 1070 of the common era, plus or minus seventy years. Which would mean the snake is younger than the cathedral at Chartres. Which would mean a different people, a thousand-odd years downstream of the Adena, came up this ridge and built a serpent on top of their ancestors' world and pointed it at the sun.

And both camps are *right about the parts they're right about*, which is the whole maddening grace of it. The charcoal under the mound is real. The Adena mounds beside it are real. Somebody dug here in the 1880s and somebody re-dug in the 1990s and somebody mixed a little of one century's spoil into another's, the way you'd track flour from a kitchen into every room of a house.

You want the snake to give up its birthday. The snake declines.

"Give me the core dates again," said Eric Sandoval.

He'd come up the trail in the pressed polo with the Foundation's discreet little logo on the breast, and he was not, Devi noted, a bad man, which was inconvenient, because a bad man would have been easier to ignore. He had a tablet and a way of holding it like a hymnal. Behind him, down by the visitor center, one of his surveyors was flying a drone in slow patient lawnmower passes, and the drone's whine threaded under the cicadas like a second, smaller summer.

"There isn't a core date," Frik said. Frik had come up behind them with two coffees, kept both, and didn't seem to notice he'd kept both. "There's a *cloud*. Word. There's a cloud of dates."

"A cloud," Sandoval repeated, gently, the way you repeat a word to a child who has used it wrong on purpose.

“Some samples cluster near 1070.” Frik’s chin jerked; he let it. “Some scatter older — Putnam-era stuff, re-runs, charcoal that might be the mound and might be somebody’s *campfire* from a thousand years before anyone hauled a basket up here. *Older occupation, not necessarily older construction.*” The last came fast, a quote surfacing whole; Frik read papers the way Devi read soil. “You can’t tell the difference between ‘they built it then’ and ‘they cooked a deer here once’ from the carbon alone. The carbon doesn’t know what the human was *doing*. Knock-knock.”

“Sorry?”

“Tic. Ignore it.” Frik finally noticed the second coffee, looked at it with mild betrayal, and handed it to Devi. “The point stands. You’ve got one strong young date under the mound and a fog of everything else, and the fog is mostly the twentieth century’s fingerprints on the nineteenth century’s hole.”

Sandoval did the thing his sort did, which was not get angry — Devi watched for it, watched the jaw, the hands; nothing — but get *patient* in a way that was its own kind of pressure, a weight you couldn’t push back against because it gave when you pushed.

“I hear you,” he said. And he probably did. “Here’s where I sit. We have a World Heritage nomination going forward. The serial nomination — the Hopewell earthworks went in 2023, you know, inscribed, the whole network. This site is the jewel and it’s *outside* that listing and the committee will ask, reasonably, the most reasonable question in the world.” He spread his hands at the snake, at the egg, at the whole long green sentence of it. “How old is it. People come up this trail, eight-year-olds come up this trail, and they ask the same thing, and right now the answer the placard gives is *we don’t know*, and *we don’t know* does not —” he hunted for the kind word, found it — *land*. It doesn’t land for a child and it doesn’t land for a committee. We need a clear date for the application.”

“You need a *defensible* date,” Mara said, from the ground, still not looking up. “Those aren’t the same animal.”

The drone changed pitch, came around for another pass.

They walked the head-end together, later, the four of them and the

cart, out to where the serpent's open jaws cradle the oval. Lens drifted behind — she always drifted behind, the camera up, the lens long, finding the angle where the egg sat against the drop of the valley with the whole impact crater rolling away below it. Because that was the other thing nobody on the placard liked to dwell on: the ground here is *wrong*. Some unthinkable old morning a rock fell out of the sky and punched the bedrock into a bruise three miles wide, and the strata under your feet are tilted and shattered and faulted in ways that no other ridge in Ohio is, and the serpent is laid out *along the rim of that wound*. Whoever built it — Adena, Fort Ancient, both, neither — chose the one spot in the county where the earth itself is a scar, and pointed the head at the sunset on the longest day of the year.

"The alignment's real," Devi said, because someone needed to say a true thing out loud, and they were good at the true things. "The head. Solstice sunset. Hively and Horn ran the survey in '82, Romain after. The azimuth's right. That's not a maybe."

"That's not a maybe," Mara agreed.

"But it doesn't date it," Frik put in. "The sun set in the same place in 320 BCE and in 1070 and it'll set there next month. An alignment tells you which *direction* they cared about. It can't tell you which *century* cared." He scratched at his sternum. "Both camps get to keep the sunset. Nobody wins the sunset."

Lens lowered the camera half an inch. "There's a school group coming up," she said, quietly, to no one. There was: a ragged line of small bright shirts toiling up the overlook trail with two heat-flushed teachers, and a girl near the front already off the path, already pointing, already asking the unanswerable thing with her whole arm.

Devi watched the soil tray instead. The column of core sat there in its honest layers — dark loam, paler clay, a thin charcoal smudge low down that could be everything or nothing, that some lab could turn into a number and the number would be true and the number would settle *nothing*. That was the part that sat oddly in Devi's chest, the part that wasn't a fact. You could measure this place to death. You could run a hundred cores and a thousand passes of radar and stack the data into a wall and the wall would still have a door in it that wouldn't shut.

The screen on the cart, parked, had gone to a still frame: that restless reflector, the one that wouldn't hold a depth. Devi looked at it the way they looked at everything — for the *pattern*, the rule underneath, the thing the system was actually doing instead of the thing it was supposed to do. And the rule here was simple and unbeautiful and Devi made themself say it.

"The data's not broken," Devi said. "We keep talking like the data's broken. It isn't. It's *consistent*. It consistently won't close. Every method lands in the same place, which is *almost*. That's not noise. That's a *result*." They breathed. "We just don't like the result, so we keep calling it a failure."

Sandoval looked at them for a long moment with something that was almost hope and almost grief.

"And what do I write on the placard," he said, "for the eight-year-old. *The result is almost.*"

Nobody answered him. The girl's voice carried up the slope — *how old IS it* — and one of the teachers said something soft and the girl was not satisfied, you could hear that she was not satisfied, eight-year-olds invented the dignity of the unsatisfied question.

Mara stood. She brushed the ridge off her knees and looked at her core, and then at the radar screen, and then down the long green spine of the serpent to the egg and the drop and the crater's far rim hazing blue, and she did not look like a woman about to sign anything.

"I have a survey to finish," she said. "Mine. Not the Foundation's. There are three more cores I want before the soil gets walked to soup." She said it level, but Devi heard the load under it — heard that the asking-her-to-sign had already started somewhere off this ridge, in an email, in a meeting, in a room with carpet, and that it would keep coming, patient as the drone, and that the only ground she fully held was the ground right here under her boots and even that was being measured for a gift shop. "You can document," she told the crew. "You can't conclude. The conclusion's not yours to reach."

"Wouldn't dream of it," Frik said, and meant it, and for him meaning it was a kind of athletic feat.

The drone went quiet. The surveyor down the hill had brought it in to swap a battery, and into the gap the cicadas poured back, and the warm-grass smell, and the hush — that specific ridge hush, the one that feels like the land has stopped chewing to listen to you.

Jakobus had been there the whole time. That was his way. He'd been near the egg, off home ground as always, a stranger to this ridge and easy about being one, turning something over in his hands that turned out to be nothing, a stone, a stick, the habit of his hands more than any object. He'd said maybe four words all morning. He set the stone down where he'd found it — he was careful about that, putting things back — and he straightened, and he looked at the screen Devi was still staring into, the frozen frame of the reflector that would not hold a depth.

"You've all told me what you *want*," he said. Mild. Almost apologetic, the way he got when he was about to be useful. He nodded at the snake, at the egg, at the crater, at the sun-place over the far rim. "Camp wants it Adena. Camp wants it Fort Ancient. He —" the chin toward Sandoval, not unkind " — wants it *settled*. The kid wants a number." A pause; the cicadas filled it. "Forget all of it for one minute."

He looked from the screen to the ground to the long deliberate body of the thing some people made, on purpose, on the rim of a wound, aimed at the longest day.

"What do you see," Jakobus said, "not what do you want?"

And then he stepped back, the way he did, ceding the ground, because the seeing was not his to do — and the cores lay open on the tarp, and the screen held its impossible un-still reflector, and down the slope the girl asked again into the hush, *how old is it, how old IS it*, and nobody up on the ridge, yet, said a word.

Chapter 4 — The Hole: What Nobody Can Close

The visitor center smelled of carpet glue and old coffee, and Frik had three open papers, one photocopy with a coffee ring on it, and a clipboard he was not using because clipboards were for people who'd already decided what mattered. He had decided nothing. That was the point. That was the whole, the entire, the actual point.

"Lepper," he said. "1996. University of Cincinnati. Charcoal from beneath the mound body. Three samples. Calibrated, they cluster around 1070 of the Common Era, give or take seventy years. That's Fort Ancient. That's the date everyone quotes because it has a number and the number has a little plus-minus and people love a little plus-minus, it looks like — *honk* — it looks like control."

Nobody had asked him. He was aware nobody had asked him. The awareness did not help.

He was sitting at one of the long tables they let researchers use, by the window that looked out at nothing in particular — a slope of mowed grass, the head of the trail, the tree line beyond going dark green in the heat. The cicadas were doing their thing out there, that pulse that came up out of the ground like the ground had a low fever. Across the table Lens had her camera in her lap, lens cap on, which meant she was looking at the room the way she looked at rooms, the edges of it, the doors.

"And the other date," she said. Not a question. She wanted him to say it where the others could hear.

The others being two of the foundation's people, who'd drifted in with

iced drinks from the gift-shop cooler and stood near the diorama like they were minding it. And Eric Sandoval, who was not standing near anything. Sandoval had pulled up a chair, turned it backward, sat down on it the way earnest men do when they want you to know they're listening with their whole body. He had a folder too. Everyone had a folder. The mound generated folders.

"The other date," Friik said. "*Okay okay.* Putnam. 1880s. Frederic Ward Putnam, who basically saved this place from being plowed flat — bought it, surveyed it, gave it to the state, the man is a hero, I will not hear a word — Putnam pulled material that, on later reanalysis, sits older. Adena older. Eight hundred BCE to a hundred CE is the Adena window. Call the headline number three-twenty BCE if you want a headline number, which you do, which everyone does." His knee was going. "And the artifacts in the conical mounds nearby — the burial mounds, not this one, *this one has no burials in it, write that down*, this one is empty — those are Adena. Adena pottery. Adena graves. Adena Adena Adena."

"So it's older," said one of the polo shirts. Helpfully. "That settles it the other way, then."

Friik turned his head. He felt the tic come up the back of his neck like a sneeze that wasn't a sneeze and he let it go, two clicks of the tongue, and the polo shirt did the thing people do, the small recalibration of the face, the *oh, is he* — and then Friik talked over the top of it because talking was the only place he was ever fully himself.

"No. *No no no.* It does not settle it. Listen. The burials are Adena. The burials are next door. The burials being Adena tells you Adena people were *here*. It does not tell you Adena people *built the snake*. You can occupy a ridge for a thousand years and build the thing on it on a Tuesday in 1070. People reuse places. People build on the old places *because* they're old places. The charcoal under the mound body — under the actual built-up serpent — that's the construction signal, that's the carbon from whatever they did to the ground when they raised it, and that carbon says eleven hundred years younger than your pots."

"Then the radiocarbon settles it," Sandoval said. Gently. He had a good gentle. "The charcoal's the construction layer. That's the modern date. That's the one we'd lead with."

“Some of the charcoal.” Frik tapped the photocopy. “Some samples from the older work go older. And the people who like the old date say the eleven-seventy charcoal is intrusive — a repair, a later party up here, a feature dug into a mound that was already old. Slumping. Erosion. People recut the coils over centuries, it’s an *earthwork*, it’s not a sealed jar, the carbon migrates, roots move it, animals move it, you cannot —” the word jammed and he hit it twice to get it out “— you cannot, cannot, *cannot* point at one charcoal flake and say this is the year. You’ve got dates that straddle a thousand years. A *thousand*. That’s not a margin of error. That’s two different stories wearing the same dirt.”

The cicadas, outside, swelled and dropped.

“And here’s the thing that nobody at either of your tables likes me to say.” He was aware he was building to it. He could feel it the way you feel the top of a hill in your legs before you see it. “The easy answer is a lie. And the hard one is a mess.”

The room did something. Not a gasp — the room wasn’t theatrical — but a shift, a small subtraction of air, the polo shirts looking at Sandoval to see how Sandoval would take it, Sandoval not yet deciding.

“That’s —” Sandoval started.

“It’s not a *slogan*,” Frik said, because he could hear it landing as a slogan and that wasn’t what it was. “I’m not being clever. I’d love to be wrong. The easy answer — *it’s Fort Ancient, 1070, here’s the plaque* — that’s a lie because the plaque pretends the dating war is over and it is not over, it is published, it is peer-reviewed, it is *ongoing*, there are credentialed people with letters after their names on both sides right now in the literature, and the plaque flattens all of that into a sentence a kid can read off the wall in four seconds. That’s the lie. And the hard answer — *well, it’s complicated, the carbon’s ambiguous, the morphology cuts the other way, the stratigraphy’s been disturbed since the eighteen-eighties* — that’s true. But it’s a mess. It doesn’t fit on a brochure. It doesn’t fit on anything. You can’t sell a mess.”

Quiet.

“You can’t put a *maybe* in a font,” he added, which was the part he hadn’t planned, and which was, he understood a half-second too late,

the part that mattered.

Lens had lifted the camera. She had not raised it to her eye. She was just holding it now, both hands, the way you hold something to feel its weight.

Sandoval put his palms flat on the back of his turned-around chair. He was not angry. Frik had wanted, a little, for him to be angry — anger was clean, anger you could read — but Sandoval was something harder to track, which was *patient*.

“I hear you,” Sandoval said. “I do. And I want you to hear me, because I don’t think we’re the cartoon you’ve maybe got in your head.” A small smile, no teeth in it. “I’ve got a World Heritage application that needs a coherent narrative. Not a fake one. A *defensible* one. UNESCO doesn’t fund vibes. Donors don’t fund a question mark. And the visitors —” he tipped his head toward the window, toward the trailhead where, at that moment, a line of kids in matching neon shirts was straggling up from a yellow bus, a teacher counting heads — “those kids deserve a story. A real one. You give a nine-year-old a mess, you know what they take home? Nothing. They take home boredom. You give them *the Fort Ancient people built a giant snake aligned to the longest day of the year* and you’ve made an archaeologist. Maybe.”

It was, Frik registered with discomfort, not a stupid thing to say. The foundation people were rarely stupid. That was the part the books always got wrong about people like this. He kept waiting for them to be villains and they kept being *reasonable*, which was so much worse.

“Or,” said a voice from the doorway, “you’ve made nine archaeologists who think they already know the answer. Which is the opposite of an archaeologist.”

Dr. Mara Tallchief came in the way she did everything Frik had so far seen — without hurry, without performance, as if she’d been in the room the whole time and the rest of them had only just become visible to her. She had a soil-streaked field vest and a travel mug and the particular stillness of a person who had spent a great deal of her life letting other people finish being wrong.

“Dr. Tallchief,” Sandoval said, and stood, and offered the chair, and

she didn't take it.

"I heard most of that from the hall," she said. To Frik, not to Sandoval. She looked at him for a moment in a way that he found he could meet, which was rare — usually eye contact was a thing he rationed, a tax he paid and resented. "You said the easy answer's a lie and the hard one's a mess."

"I did. *Sorry*. I do that."

"Don't be sorry." Something moved at the corner of her mouth. Not a smile, exactly. The relief of a person who has been carrying a heavy thing in both arms for a long time and has just watched someone else, a stranger, pick up one end of it without being asked. "I've been saying a softer version of that for eleven years and getting nodded at. You said it like you meant it, in front of the people who least want to hear it." She glanced at Sandoval, and there was no cruelty in it, which made it worse for him, Frik thought, the way Frik's own bluntness was worse when it wasn't aimed. "Sometimes the soft version is the dishonest one."

Sandoval spread his hands, a man conceding a point in a long game he hadn't lost yet. "I'm not the enemy of *honest*, Mara."

"I know you're not, Eric." She said his first name easily, the wariness of people who'd been across a lot of tables from each other. "That's the problem. If you were the enemy of honest you'd be easy."

Frik laughed — too loud, the wrong shape, a bark that became a tic that became two — and for once nobody flinched, because the laugh had been true and they could tell.

Mara set her travel mug down on the long table, among his papers, on the coffee ring like she was capping it. "Here's what I want to say about your mess, since you brought it into my building." *My building*. He noticed that. He filed it. The crew owned the telling; she owned the place, and she had just said so in two words, gently, without raising her voice. "You're right about the carbon. You're more right than the people who pay you would like." A flick of the eyes at Lens, the camera. "You can keep that, by the way. Film all of it. I don't mind being recorded saying the thing is unresolved. I mind being recorded saying it's resolved."

"I won't shoot what you don't want shot," Lens said. The first thing

she'd said in twenty minutes. It came out flat and careful, a sentence she'd had to build before she let it out, and Mara heard the care in it and nodded once.

"Good." Mara picked her mug back up. "But here's where I think you're all still wrong. Both tables. The carbon table and the brochure table. You're all standing in the same hole, arguing about *when*, and you've turned *when* into *who*, and you've turned *who* into *whose*, and the whole time —" she looked, now, out the window, past the kids, up the slope to where the ridge held the coils none of them could see from here, hidden under grass and the angle of the land — "the whole time you've never once asked the only question the thing itself can actually answer."

Frik felt his pulse pick up. He knew this shape. He had been chasing this shape his whole life, the shape of a real question.

"Which is," he said.

"Not now." She said it kindly. She drank from the mug. "Now you've got a date with the literature, and I've got a survey to finish before these gentlemen own the parking lot." A nod to Sandoval, who took it without flinching, which Frik also filed. "But the longest day's coming. Sun sets behind the ridge in a place it only sets four nights a year, more or less, and the head of the snake's been pointing at it for —" the corner of her mouth again — "for either two thousand years or a thousand, depending on which of you I'm humoring."

"You're going to watch the solstice," Frik said.

"I'm going to *measure* something at the solstice." She picked up her clipboard from where she'd set it without his noticing she'd set it down at all — she was, he registered, faster than him, faster than all of them, the way a person is fast on ground they've walked ten thousand times. "And I don't watch sunsets for the romance of it. There's no romance up there. There's mosquitoes and a lot of standing." She was at the door now. "You blurted the true thing in front of the wrong people. That buys you something. Come up the ridge with me when the sun goes. Bring your fact-machine —" a glance at Frik that he could not, for the life of him, decode, and that he would think about for a long while after — "and bring her camera. Leave the certainty in the van."

She was gone before Sandoval could say *we'd like to be there too*, though Frik could see him forming it, and Frik thought: she heard you forming it, too. She just didn't stay to be asked.

The cicadas were going hard outside now, the heat-pulse of them. The neon kids had reached the trailhead and the teacher was telling them something about a snake, and a thousand years, or two thousand, and the longest day, with all the cheerful certainty of a person reading off a wall.

Frik looked down at his papers. The straddled dates. The empty mound with the full graves beside it. The plus-minus that pretended to be control. He squared the photocopy with the coffee ring, the ring she'd capped with her mug and lifted again, leaving it open.

"What's she going to measure," Lens said, quietly, lens cap back on now, the question pointed at the window and not at him.

"I don't know," Frik said. And then, because it was true, and because for once he didn't reach past it: "I don't know, and she does."

Outside, the longest day was four days off, and the sun, indifferent, kept doing the only thing it had ever done, which was set in the same place it always set, exactly, every year, behind a ridge where a serpent of earth had been pointing — for a length of time nobody could close — at the spot where it would go down.

Chapter 5 — The Wink: Solstice in the Shadow

The light at six-forty was doing the thing Lens hated and loved in equal measure — the thing that made her hands want the camera before her brain caught up. It came in low and gold off the western treeline, raked sideways across the ridge, and turned the grass into something that looked combed. Every blade threw a shadow longer than itself. The whole serpent lifted out of the ground in relief, the seven coils suddenly legible, ridge and trough, the way a face becomes a face when you finally see it in the wallpaper.

She lowered the camera. Made herself lower it. Looked with her eyes first, the way Mara had asked, two days ago, without asking.

The crew walked the overlook trail toward the head in a loose line, single file where the boardwalk narrowed. Mara was up front. She'd been quiet since the parking lot, a surveyor's stake in one hand, a small sledge in the other, and she carried both the way some people carried a coffee — like they weighed nothing, like they were part of her arm. Frik came behind her, then the analyst, Devorah, counting something under her breath, then Lens at the back where she liked it, where the frame opened up ahead of her and nobody was watching her watch.

"Egg's at the head," Frik said. Not to anyone. He did this — read the world aloud, the literal surface of it, like a man reading road signs to a car that already knew the way. "Oval feature. Open jaws. They call it an egg, the serpent swallowing the egg, but it's not an egg, it's just an oval mound, nobody knows it's an egg. Could be the sun. Could be a frog. Could be nothing." His shoulder jumped. "*Frog.*"

"It could be the sun," Deborah said, mild.

"That's what I said."

The boardwalk took them up the spine of the ridge and the land fell away on both sides, lowland and river haze, the impact crater rolling out below in a way that the ground had no business rolling. Lens had read the geology in the van. A cryptoexplosion structure — a place where something, three hundred million years back, had punched the bedrock and left it cracked and tilted and wrong, faults running out like spokes. You couldn't see a crater. There was no crater to see, not with the eye. But the land *felt* dished, and she'd learned a long time ago to trust the feeling that came before the explanation, even when the explanation arrived to disagree with it.

Ahead, on the open ground past the serpent's jaws, the Foundation had set up.

Three tripods. A drone parked on a road case, props folded, its little operator crouched beside it tapping a tablet. A boom mic in a wind-sock the size of a small dog. Eric Sandoval stood in the middle of it in a polo the color of a swimming pool, hands clasped, talking quietly to a woman with a clipboard, and when he saw the crew coming he raised a hand — friendly, genuinely friendly, that was the maddening part — and called, "We saved you the east side. Best of both worlds."

"He means out of frame," Deborah murmured.

"He means out of frame," Lens agreed.

But it wasn't a hostile thing. That was what kept catching her. Sandoval wanted everyone to see this. He'd brought folding chairs. There were tourists — maybe forty, a field trip's worth of teenagers plus the genuine pilgrims, the solstice people in linen, an old couple in matching windbreakers who'd driven from somewhere with a thermos. A ranger was telling them to stay on the path. The cicadas were going in the trees below, that long electric sawing that rose and broke and rose again, and under it the human sound of forty people deciding to be quiet without being asked.

Lens raised the camera now. Wide. She let the head of the serpent sit in the lower third and the treeline take the top, and she waited.

Here is the part that is not in dispute. Lens had checked it herself, because Frik made everyone check everything, because Frik couldn't help it.

The serpent's head points west and a little north, to the spot on the horizon where the sun goes down on the longest day of the year. Not approximately. Hively and Horn surveyed it in 1982 with instruments and published the numbers. Romain ran it again. Lepper too. The jaws of the effigy open toward the summer solstice sunset, and the open mound — the egg, the frog, the sun, whatever it was — sits cradled in those jaws like a thing being aimed.

You can argue about who built it. You cannot argue about where the sun goes.

"Two minutes," said the drone operator.

Sandoval's videographer crouched behind the main tripod, a finger up. The boom op adjusted the windsock. Somewhere a teenager whispered *is it gonna do something* and a friend whispered back *it's a sunset, dummy, it does this every day*, and they were both right, and that was the whole thing, wasn't it. It does this every day. It only does *this* one day a year.

The sun came down the sky toward the notch in the trees.

Lens had photographed a great many things she shouldn't have been close enough to photograph. She knew what her body did when the air got tight. It was doing it now — the same alertness, the prickle at the back of the neck, the sense of the frame filling with something the lens couldn't itemize. But it was clean this time. No dread underneath it. Just the old animal attention, turned toward a sunset instead of toward a doorway she didn't want to walk through. She breathed out. Held the shot.

The disc touched the trees.

And the light went down the serpent's open jaws like it was being poured.

You couldn't have planned the shadow better. The low sun struck the egg mound and threw its shadow back into the throat of the serpent, dark filling the carved oval, and the head of the great earth-

work caught fire along its western flank, gold, and the coils behind it dropped into blue. The horizon point where the sun was sinking and the line the jaws made — Lens didn't need the survey numbers. The eye did the math. They were the same line. The serpent was looking at the sun, or eating it, or aiming it, and the sun was sliding right down the gun barrel of the head exactly where the dead people who built this had put it to slide, a thousand years ago, or two thousand, or whatever number you wanted to fight about.

The tourists clapped.

It startled her. A scatter of applause across the ridge, the linen people and the field trip and the windbreaker couple, applauding the sun for hitting its mark — applauding the dead, really, the unnamed engineers who'd surveyed this notch by some method nobody had recovered and pointed thirteen hundred feet of piled earth at it and gotten it *right*. Sandoval was beaming. The drone hummed up off its case to catch the head from above. Somebody said *wow* with their whole chest. The cicadas didn't care and kept sawing.

Lens kept shooting and felt, distantly, the small sick thing that always came when a real thing got applause: that the applause was for the spectacle, and the spectacle was the smallest true part of it.

Mara wasn't watching the sun.

Lens caught her in the edge of the frame and turned the lens off the head to find her, and there she was, eight feet off the boardwalk where the ground was allowed to be walked, kneeling. She'd driven the stake. She was sighting along it with one eye shut, the way you'd sight a rifle or a fence line, lining the top of the stake up with something Lens couldn't see, the stake and the egg and the sinking sun all on one thread. She had a phone out, low, taking her own picture of the stake against the horizon, but it wasn't a picture for anyone. It was a measurement. She tapped a note. She moved the stake an inch and sighted again.

The applause died down behind her and she didn't look up.

"What's she marking?" Lens asked. She'd drifted off the boardwalk, careful, onto the bare worn patch where the rangers let you stand.

Mara didn't answer right away. She sighted once more, satisfied this time, and sat back on her heels. The light was on her face now, that same poured gold, and it found every line in it and made them look like the lines in the ground.

"Where it actually came down," she said. "Not where the brochure says it comes down." She nodded toward the Foundation's cluster of tripods without much in her face. "They'll cut it so the disc sits dead in the jaws. It doesn't, quite. It's close. It's a thousand years close, which is the most amazing thing about it, but it isn't dead center, and the difference is the interesting part." She looked at the stake. "The horizon moves. Trees grow. The ground here isn't even level the way it reads — there's a fault running under us, the whole rim's tipped. So 'the serpent points at the solstice' is true, and it's also doing a lot of work. I want the real angle this year. Then I want it next year, and the year after, if there's a next year I'm allowed up here."

"You don't trust the survey?"

"I trust the survey. Hively and Horn did beautiful work." She stood, brushing her knees. "I just don't want anybody, mine or theirs, telling this ridge what it does. I want to watch it do it."

Frik had come up beside Lens. He'd been silent through the whole sunset — genuinely silent, which Lens had never once seen in three days, his jaw working but nothing coming out, his hands still at his sides. He was looking at the stake and the egg and the dropped throat of the serpent with an expression she didn't have a name for, the fact-puncturer with no fact in his mouth.

"The radiocarbon," he said finally, and even this came out soft. "Lepper, ninety-six. Charcoal under the mound. Ten-seventy of the common era, plus or minus seventy. Fort Ancient." His thumb tapped his thigh. "But Putnam's older samples. Adena artifacts in the conicals. Three-twenty before. Eleven hundred years apart and the wood under the dirt says one thing and the dirt itself says another and nobody —" a small tic, his head ducking — "nobody has closed it. Both sides published. Both sides peer-reviewed. As of right now nobody knows how old this is."

"No," Mara said. "Nobody does."

"That should bother people more than it does."

"It bothers me the right amount," Mara said, and there was the ghost of something dry in it.

Sandoval was wrapping. The light was off the head now, the gold gone violet, the coils all one shade of dusk. His videographer was showing him the playback and he was nodding, nodding, a man watching his brochure come true. He'd cut the lunar alignments, Mara had said earlier — the standstill stuff, Hively and Horn's later claims, the moon hitting points along the coils. *Too debated*, he'd said. *Too many asterisks. We lead with the sun. Everyone understands the sun.* And he wasn't wrong, that was the thing about Sandoval, he was never quite wrong, he just kept choosing the version with the fewest asterisks until the asterisks were the only true thing left and they were gone.

The drone came down. The tourists were filing back along the boardwalk in the blue, talking low, the field trip kids loud again now that the holy part was over. The egg mound had lost its shadow. It was just a low oval of grass in the dark, sitting in the mouth of a longer low ridge of grass, and you'd never know, you'd genuinely never know, walking past it in daylight, that anyone had aimed it at anything.

Lens lowered the camera. She'd gotten the shot. She'd gotten forty shots. None of them, she already knew, would hold what the ridge had just done, because the ridge had done it in time and a photograph had no time in it.

The cicadas had thinned. The first star was up over the treeline, west, near where the sun had gone, hanging in the wake of it.

And Frik, who'd had no fact for the sunset, no number, nothing to puncture, who'd stood for ten whole minutes with his hands at his sides like a man at a graveside — Frik tilted his head back at the dark coils and the cold first star and the long low body of the thing lying on the rim of a wound the sky had put in the ground three hundred million years before anyone climbed up here to dig, and he said it to all of them and to none of them, the way he read road signs, except his voice had gone down to almost nothing:

"But why a serpent." His shoulder jumped, once, gently, like the ridge breathing. "Why *here*."

Mara picked up her sledge.

She didn't answer. She looked at the stake she'd driven, at the line it held from the egg to the place on the horizon where the sun had actually, measurably, this-year-truly come down — not the brochure place, the real place — and then she looked out and down, west, off the rim, to where the river lowlands lay invisible in the dark and the water ran where water runs.

“Walk down with me tomorrow,” she said. “Early. Before they're up here.”

She started back along the boardwalk into the dusk, and the crew went after her, and behind them the serpent lay in the dark on the lip of its crater, aimed at a sun that had already set, waiting, the way it had waited a thousand years, or two, for somebody to ask the right question — which was not *when*.

Chapter 6 — What Is It For: Water, Stone, and Sky

The thing about Jakobus was that he never started at the head.

Everyone started at the head. The tourists, the foundation's surveyors with their drones, the schoolkids who broke from their teachers and ran the boardwalk straight to the oval mouth where the serpent seemed to be swallowing the sun. The head was the photograph. The head was the brochure. The head was where the solstice did its trick.

Jakobus started at the tail.

He came up the overlook trail before the heat broke, while the cicadas were still tuning, and he stood at the spiral end of the thing and looked at it the way he looked at everything made — a winch, a wall, a thirteen-hundred-foot snake of piled earth. Not *who*. Not *when*. He didn't care, particularly, whether the men who'd shaped it had done so when the Roman Empire was young or when William the Conqueror was middle-aged. The arguing scholars could have that. What Jakobus wanted was the question that came before all the others and got skipped anyway, every time, in the rush to be certain about a date.

What is it for.

He set his boot on the lip of the coil and felt the ground go soft.

"There." Frik was already kneeling, three feet to the left, fingers spread on the grass like a man checking a stove for warmth. "Wet. *Wet*. It's wet here and it hasn't rained since Tuesday — *hasn't rained*

— and the rest of the ridge is dry as a —” his head ticked, a quick sideways snap, ” — dry as a cracker. Why’s it wet *here*.”

“Spring,” said Lens, from above. She’d climbed the small rise of the embankment to shoot down the length of the body and she was leaning out over it, camera not quite raised, the way she held it lately — present, but lowered, asking permission of the air. “Or seep. Mara said there were seeps.”

“Seeps don’t pick a *spot*,” Frik said. “Water picks the low ground. This isn’t the low ground. This is *the coil*.”

Jakobus said nothing. He walked the spiral inward, one slow turn, watching his own boots, and the ground answered him the way ground answers a man who has spent forty years asking it questions with his feet. Firm. Firm. A give. Firm. A give. He was not measuring with instruments. He was measuring with the small animal in the sole of his foot that knew the difference between earth that drained and earth that held.

The serpent was not lying on the ridge the way a rope lies on a table.

It was lying on the ridge the way a rope lies on a *rumpled blanket* — over a swell here, dipping into a hollow there, the body riding the land’s own bones. You could stand at the head and call it a snake aimed at a sunset and you’d be right, and you’d have seen nothing.

Here is the official story, and it deserves to be told straight, because the people who tell it have spent their careers earning the right.

A culture — Adena, or Fort Ancient, the carbon won’t say and we’ll get to that — came up onto a ridge of Ohio limestone above a creek they called something we’ll never know, and they moved earth. Basket by basket. They built a serpent over a quarter-mile long, with a coiled tail and seven body bends and an oval at the mouth, and they aimed its head at the point on the horizon where the sun drops on the longest day of the year. This much is not in dispute. Hively and Horn surveyed it in 1982; Romain and Lepper added to it; you can take a compass and a calendar up the trail next June and watch the sun go down into the serpent’s jaws yourself. The alignment is real. It is the one thing in this whole contested place that will hold still and let you measure it.

And that is where the story usually stops, because that is where the photograph is.

The trouble is what the photograph leaves out. A solstice alignment tells you the builders watched the sky. It does not tell you why a serpent. It does not tell you why *seven coils* and not five. It does not tell you why this ridge, of all the ridges in Ohio, when the alignment could have been struck from a hundred high points along the creek. The sky explains the head. It explains nothing else. The body of the thing — the great rippling thirteen hundred feet of it — is just *there*, in the official story, like a tail you draw on a kite because a snake needs a tail.

Jakobus did not believe in tails you drew because a thing needed one.

Mara Tallchief came up the trail at midmorning with a cardboard tube under her arm and the patience of someone who'd watched a great many people get excited on this ridge and be wrong.

"You found the wet spots," she said. Not a question.

"Frik found them," Lens said. "Frik finds everything."

"Frik can't *not*," Frik said, and ticked, and crouched again over the soft place in the coil. "It's the *only* way I'm — it's the only setting I've got. I see the thing that doesn't match and I have to say the thing that —" a clipped throat-sound — "the thing that doesn't match. There's a spring under this coil. I'd put money on it. Money I don't have."

Mara crouched beside him, which Jakobus noticed. The foundation men did not crouch. The foundation men stood and gestured at things with open hands, presenting the land like a car. Mara crouched and put two fingers in the grass the way Frik had, and was quiet a moment.

"My grandmother," she said, "would not have called it a spring."

She didn't finish the sentence, and Jakobus liked her for that, too. He had been at this long enough to know that the most important sentences were the ones people declined to finish in front of cameras.

She unrolled the tube against the slope of the embankment, weight-

ing the corners with stones she chose without looking, and there it was — a survey map, old, the linen kind, hand-inked. Contour lines like the whorls of a thumbprint. And threaded through them in a different hand, a later hand, in faded blue: water.

Not the creek down in the lowland. That was on it too, fat and obvious. The blue Jakobus leaned in for was the *other* water — thin hairline traces that started nowhere visible and ran a little way and vanished into the limestone. Springs. Seeps. The places where the ridge, which looked from the road like one solid dry hill, was in fact riddled — leaking quietly from a hundred small mouths because the whole structure of it was cracked clean through.

“It’s the crater,” Frik said. The word came out of him three times before he could stop it, *crater crater crater*, and he pressed the heel of his hand to his mouth and breathed and got it down to once. “The crater. The whole ridge sits on the impact structure. The bedrock’s shattered. Faulted. Water comes up where the rock’s broken and it can’t down here where it isn’t — that’s — that’s *geology*, that’s not —” he stopped himself. He was about to say *that’s not magic*, and he didn’t, and Jakobus watched him not say it, and thought: the boy is learning when to keep his fist closed.

Mara let it sit. Then she touched the map, one of the blue threads, and ran her fingertip along it slowly, and her finger followed the line of a coil.

It followed the *line of a coil*.

The fish, if there is a fish, would like to break in here.

Oh, *come on*. A water map. You’re going to tell me a quarter-mile of sculpted earth, aimed at a solstice with surveyor’s precision, the most famous effigy mound on the continent, is a — what — a *plumbing diagram*? For springs that any thirsty person could find by walking around with their eyes open? Pull the other one. The skeptics are going to laugh you off the ridge.

And the skeptics would be half right to. Because here is the cold thing, measured with a cold eye: nobody has *proven* the coils trace the water. There is a map. There are wet spots. There is a fingertip that follows a curve. There is a granddaughter who won’t finish a

sentence. That is not a peer-reviewed correspondence. The seeps move; springs are not loyal; the embankment has been restored and re-restored since the 1880s, when Putnam first dug it, and you cannot fully trust that the curve under your boot is the curve the builders piled. The hole the official story never closed — the *real* one, the one in the journals as of this year — is the date, the unbudgeable Adena-or-Fort-Ancient stalemate, two thousand years in dispute by two thousand BCE. That hole is still open. Don't let anybody, including a tired old fixer with a good eye, sweet-talk you into thinking the water closes it.

But.

But Jakobus had walked the spiral with his feet, and the give of the ground had come exactly where the head of the map's blue thread came, and a man who reads made things for a living learns to trust the moment the object and the drawing agree without being told to.

"It points at water," Jakobus said. He said it quietly, to the map, not to them. It was the most he'd said all morning.

Mara looked up at him.

"It points at *the* water," she said. "And then it points at the sun."

She let go of the map and stood, and her knees popped, and she looked off down the body of the serpent toward the head and the oval and the empty bright air past it where the solstice sun would one day fall.

"You walk the ridge in late summer," she said, "and the creek's low and brown and not worth drinking, and the lowland tastes of mud. And up here, at the broken places, the water comes out of the rock cold. My grandmother knew every one. Her mother told her. She'd send us up to the third bend — she counted them from the tail, always from the tail — and we'd never come back empty." She paused. "I'm not telling you that's what it's *for*. I'm telling you that's what we used it for. Those aren't the same thing and I won't let you write them down like they are."

Frik opened his mouth.

Frik closed it.

Jakobus saw that, too, and something in his weathered face moved that was almost approval and almost grief, because the boy had just held a true thing behind his teeth for the sake of a woman's right to give or keep her own, and that cost him, you could see it cost him, the way withholding always costs the ones who are built to tell.

"The head's the calendar," Mara went on. "Anybody can have the head. The sun does it for everyone, it doesn't need us. But the body —" she walked a few steps along the embankment, trailing her hand at hip height over the long swell of it — "the body's the part you have to be *told*. You have to learn it from someone who learned it. The coils mark where the rock leaks. The bends are the count. The tail's where you start." She glanced back. "It's a map you can only read if someone reads it to you first. That's not an accident. That's the whole *design*."

Jakobus felt the answer land in his chest the way a true answer does — not a thrill, nothing so cheap, just a settling, a thing fitting into the slot it was cut for. *What is it for*. A horizon marker for the longest day, yes, the famous thing, the photograph. And a water map for the rest of the year, the unfamous thing, the thing under your boot, the thing you could starve beside if nobody loved you enough to teach you the coils. Sky and stone and water, the same earthwork doing all three at once, the way a good tool always did more than the brochure said.

He did not say any of that. It was hers. He took half a step back and let the air around Mara get bigger, the way he always did, fading toward the embankment until the camera and the question and the morning all belonged to her and to the crew she'd decided, for now, to let stay.

The thing about a ridge is that sound carries on it strangely.

None of them heard Eric Sandoval come up the boardwalk. He'd left the drone team at the visitor center and walked up alone, in the pressed polo, the lanyard, the genuine and uncynical good cheer of a man who believed he was *celebrating* something, who'd have been honestly wounded to be called a vandal. He'd been standing at the rope line longer than anyone knew, hands clasped, listening to a Native archaeologist explain her grandmother's springs to a woman with a camera and a man who couldn't stop saying *crater*.

“That,” Sandoval said, “is *exactly* it.”

They turned.

His face was lit. Not with greed — Jakobus watched for greed and didn’t find it, which was worse, somehow, than if he had. With *enthusiasm*. With the pure clean joy of a man who has just heard, in the wild, the sentence he needs.

“That’s the story,” Sandoval said, coming to the rope. “Dr. Tallchief, that’s — that’s the *heart* of it, isn’t it? The water, the land, the — the lived relationship. The almanac, the calendar, the springs, all of it together. That’s so much richer than just the date.” He had his phone out, not recording, just holding it, a tic of his own. “The whole acquisition committee, the World Heritage application, we’ve been *desperate* for this. For the human angle. For —” and he said it warmly, he said it as a gift, he had no idea, none at all — “for the indigenous perspective. For the brochure.”

The cicadas, having tuned, began.

Mara did not answer. She bent, unhurried, and lifted the stones off the corners of her grandmother’s map, one, two, three, four, and rolled the linen back into its tube, and Jakobus saw that her hands were perfectly steady and that this was the steadiest he had ever seen them.

“The brochure,” she said.

She slid the tube under her arm.

Down past the head of the serpent, past the oval mouth, the sun climbed toward the place it would not stop until June, and the long body of the thing lay over its hidden water and said nothing, the way it had said nothing for a thousand years, or two thousand, no one could close it, and waited to see who would be told.

Chapter 7 — The Push: Certainty for Sale

Devika counted the chairs before she counted the people, the way she always did. Fourteen chairs, eight people, six empty — and the empty ones were arranged wrong, scattered, two of them turned a few degrees off the line of the folding table as if someone had stood up fast and not come back. The visitor center conference room smelled of new carpet glue and old coffee. Somebody had set out a tray of pastries from the gas station down on State Route 73, and nobody had touched them, and that bothered her in a low way she couldn't name, like a dripping tap two rooms over.

She had taken the seat nearest the door. Not the head of the table. The door. She liked to know where the door was.

On the wall behind Eric Sandoval, somebody had pinned up a foam-core mockup of the *World Heritage Experience* — a render of the ridge with a glass-and-timber pavilion lowered onto it like a clean white tooth. The serpent itself, in the render, glowed faintly green from below. There were little figures on the overlook. There was a child pointing. The whole thing was bathed in a sunset that had been painted, not photographed, and the painter had made the sun fatter and oranger than any sun Devika had ever seen do that over Adams County.

“We’re so grateful you could make the time, Dr. Tallchief,” Sandoval said.

He meant it. That was the thing about Sandoval that Devika had clocked on day one and couldn't stop clocking: he wasn't lying. His shoes were good but not loud. He'd brought his own travel mug. He

used Mara's title every single time, never just *Mara*, and he leaned in when she spoke, and when she finished speaking he waited a full beat before he answered, which most people on earth cannot do. Devika respected it. Devika was also watching his hands, because the hands were doing something the face wasn't.

His hands kept squaring the edges of a printed deck. Tap, tap, against the table. Aligning paper that was already aligned.

"The committee meets in October," Sandoval went on. "World Heritage inscription is — I won't pretend — it's a once-in-a-generation thing for this site. For the region. For the descendant communities." He nodded toward Mara when he said it, a small respectful tilt. "And the file has to say something. That's all. It has to have a sentence in it. The serpent is *X* years old, built by *Y* people, oriented to *Z*. Visitors stand on a ridge and they want — they deserve — a story they can hold."

"They have one," Mara said.

Mara Tallchief sat with her hands flat on the table, not squaring anything. She'd come up from the survey trench an hour ago and hadn't changed; there was pale clay dried in a crescent along the side of her wrist, and Devika found that she trusted the clay more than the entire foam-core render.

"They have a serpent on a crater," Mara said, "that points its head at the longest sunset of the year. That's the story. It's a good one."

"It's a wonderful one." Sandoval smiled. "We'd like to be able to tell people *whose* it is."

Across the table, the woman from communications — Devika had her down as Renner, lanyard, very fast typist — slid a single sheet toward Mara. Devika read it upside down, which she was good at, because she'd spent a childhood reading rooms upside down.

PROPOSED HERITAGE NARRATIVE. And under it, in a font chosen by someone paid to choose fonts: *Built by the Adena culture approximately 2,000 years ago, the Great Serpent Mound is among the oldest and largest effigy mounds in North America, aligned to the summer solstice sunset.*

Adena. Two thousand years. Solstice. Solved.

Devika felt the pattern click into wrongness the way a wheel clicks when it's a half-turn off true. She glanced sideways at Lens, who was not shooting — camera down in her lap, lens cap on, which for Lens was its own kind of statement — and at Frik beside her, who had gone very still, which for Frik was the most alarming thing a person could do.

"That's clean," Mara said, reading it. "It's also not what the ground says."

"It's what most of the literature said for most of a century," Renner offered, gently, helpfully.

"Until 1996," Mara said.

—

Here's the part Devika had spent three nights laying out on the floor of the van in index cards, because that's how she thought, in cards she could move.

The Adena story is the old story and it is a strong one. The serpent *looks* Adena — the morphology, the building style, the conical burial mounds right there beside it stuffed with Adena dead, the artifacts the early diggers pulled. For a hundred years the textbook sentence read: Adena, give or take, somewhere in the long window between eight hundred years before Christ and a hundred years after. Call it two thousand years. That was the sentence on Renner's sheet, and credentialed people had defended it in print, and they still did.

Then in 1996 a team out of the University of Cincinnati pulled charcoal from *under* the mound and ran it. The radiocarbon came back around 1070 of the common era. Not Adena. Fort Ancient — a culture a *thousand years younger*. Lepper and the others published it. Suddenly the serpent wasn't a grandfather, it was a grandchild, raised right around the time the Normans were sizing up England.

And the case did not close. That was the thing Devika could not get her cards to do — close. Because the older digs, going back to Putnam in the 1880s, had turned up material consistent with Adena being *all over* this ridge. So maybe the Adena were *here*. Maybe they were here and the serpent came later, on top of where they'd been, and the old charcoal was old fires and old living, not old building. Or maybe the under-mound charcoal was younger contaminating.

tion, washed down, slipped in, and the real builders were the old people after all.

Two strong stories. Both with credentials. Both with a hole you could put your fist through. As of right now, this minute, in the actual peer-reviewed literature: *unsettled*. Not “leaning Fort Ancient.” Not “probably Adena.” Open.

You cannot put *open* on a foam-core sign with a glowing serpent and a pointing child.

—

“With respect, Dr. Tallchief,” Sandoval said, and the respect was real, that was the maddening thing, “the dating debate is exactly what we want to honor. We’re not asking you to lie. We’re asking you to give us your *best professional judgment* on a date. The committee understands that science evolves. The signage can say ‘approximately.’ It can say ‘current scholarship suggests.’”

“Whose current scholarship,” Mara said.

“Yours.”

And there it was. Devika watched it travel across the table — the soft, generous, perfectly reasonable trap. *Yours*. Sign your name to the sentence, Dr. Tallchief, and the sentence becomes the heritage of the world, and the pavilion gets its story, and the child gets to point, and you get to be the Native archaeologist whose judgment carried the day. Your name on it. Your authority. We’re *centering* you.

Tap, tap, went Sandoval’s hands on the edge of the squared deck.

“And if I won’t?” Mara asked. She wasn’t angry. Devika would have understood angry. Mara sounded the way she sounded down in the trench, troweling: patient, attentive to where the soil changed color.

The pause this time was Renner’s. Renner looked at Sandoval. Sandoval did the full-beat wait, the one Devika had admired, except now it didn’t read as listening. It read as a man choosing which true thing to say.

“Then the file gets written by the committee’s own consulting historians,” Sandoval said. “Who are excellent. Who are not from here.

Who will reach a date because the file requires a date. And the interpretive plan goes forward, because the acquisition closes in three weeks whether or not you sign anything. We would *vastly* prefer your name and your voice. That's not a threat, Dr. Tallchief. That's me telling you the only thing I actually have the power to offer you, which is the chance to be in the room."

Devika's wheel clicked again. *That's not a threat.* People only say *that's not a threat* about a thing that is functioning, in every measurable way, exactly like a threat.

—

Under the table, Lens's hand found Devika's knee and squeezed once. *Steady.* Lens had her own counting; Devika had watched her do it through a hundred small bad moments, the slow blink, the breath held to four. Lens's camera stayed capped. Whatever was about to happen in this room, Lens had decided it was not hers to frame, and that decision was its own kind of held breath.

Devika ran the room. Eight people. Six empty chairs. Mara on one side with clay on her wrist and the whole weight of a thing she had not yet said behind her eyes — and Devika was sure, *certain*, watching her, that Mara knew something about this mound that wasn't on any of the index cards, something the survey trench and the water and the ridge had told her and that she was holding the way you hold a bird, deciding whether the room deserved to see it open its wings. Mara was not losing this meeting. Mara was *out-reading* every clipboard in it, and the clipboards didn't know.

And then Frik moved.

Devika felt it before she saw it — the way his stillness broke, a hitch in his shoulder, the small involuntary throat-sound he made when a fact had reached critical pressure and the lid was coming off no matter what anyone wanted. She had ten seconds to decide whether to kick him under the table. She'd done it before. He forgave her every time and it never worked.

She didn't kick him.

She would spend a while afterward trying to understand why. Partly it was the clay on Mara's wrist. Partly it was the painted sun. Partly it was that the wheel had been clicking wrong for an hour and Frik was

the only person in the building who couldn't lie even to be polite, and there are rooms that need exactly one of those.

"You can't close the case," Frik said. Loud. Flat. To the foam-core. To Sandoval. To the squared deck. "And you *know* it."

Renner stopped typing.

"The under-mound charcoal Lepper's team ran in '96 came back about ten-seventy." The words came fast now, no brakes, the verbal tic snagging on *team, team*, before it cleared. "That's Fort Ancient. That's a thousand years younger than your sign. Putnam's material from the eighteen-eighties says Adena was all over this ridge, so either the Adena built it and your sample's old fire, or Fort Ancient built it on Adena ground and *your sign is wrong by a thousand years*. Nobody's resolved which. Not in the literature. Not in 2024. Not you. The morphology says Adena. The radiocarbon says Fort Ancient. *Both have published people. Both have a hole*. You wrote 'approximately two thousand years' on a sheet of paper and the honest version of that sentence is *we don't know*, and 'approximately' is you spending the word that means *we don't know* on the date you can sell."

He stopped. His hand had come up off the table at some point and now it set back down.

The room held.

Renner looked at the proposed-narrative sheet as though it might have changed. Sandoval's hands had gone flat. Not squaring anything. Flat.

Devika watched the foam-core child point at the painted sun, and she watched Mara Tallchief, who had not flinched, who had not needed Frik to say it because Frik had said it for the file, for the upside-down readers, for the record — and who was now, slowly, sitting forward, the clay on her wrist catching the conference-room light.

"He's right," Mara said. "Which is inconvenient for everyone, including me." She let that sit. "But he's only got half of it. You're all arguing about *when*. I've been up on that ridge since six this morning, and I'll tell you what nobody at this table has asked me once."

She didn't say it yet.

Outside the window, the ridge was going gold. Somewhere up there the head of the serpent was pointed, the way it had been pointed for a number of years no one in this room could agree on, at the place where the longest day would end.

Sandoval looked at her. To his great and genuine credit — Devika filed it, fairly — he did not reach for his deck.

“Then ask me,” he said.

Chapter 8 — The Split: Community Voices

The Pancake House on Route 73 had a vinyl booth that exhaled when you sat in it, and Lens was on her third coffee before anyone said the word *mound*.

She'd come down off the ridge for this — the lowlands, the river bottoms, the part of Adams County the brochure would never photograph. The crew had split up. Frik was up top with Mara, doing things with cores. Lens had the camera and a list of names that Mara had written out in a careful hand, with a note clipped to the top: *Ask. Don't aim. If they say no, that's the picture.*

So she'd left the camera in the bag.

Across from her sat a man named Dell Hartzell, sixty-some, soybean farmer, three generations on the same bottomland. He'd agreed to talk because his wife told him to be neighborly, and now he didn't know what to do with his hands.

"My granddad plowed within sight of it his whole life," Dell said. "Never went up. Said it wasn't for plowing folks."

"You believe that?"

"I believe a man's got chores." He turned his mug a quarter-turn. "But I'll tell you what gets me. This foundation. They sent a girl in a blazer to my door with a folder. Glossy. Said the World Heritage thing'd bring four hundred thousand visitors a year. Four hundred thousand." He said the number the way you'd say a flood crest. "You know what four hundred thousand cars does to County Road 1? There's one gas station. One."

“So you don’t want it.”

“I didn’t say that.” He looked, briefly, miserable. “My nephew can’t get work. You build a visitor complex, that’s jobs. Restaurant jobs, parking jobs. Hotel out by Peebles, maybe. The whole county’s been dying since the quarry closed.” A pause. “I want it and I don’t want it. Put that in your movie.”

Here is the official story, the one the blazer-girl’s folder told straight, and it is a good story, and it deserves to be told straight.

There is a serpent on a ridge in southern Ohio. It is more than 1,300 feet long, coiled tail to gaping mouth, and at the mouth there is an oval — an egg, some say, a sun, a thing the serpent is about to swallow. It was built by people who carried the earth in baskets, who shaped a creature so large you cannot see it whole from the ground, only from above, only from the air they would never fly in. And when the sun sets on the longest day of the year, the head of the serpent points at it. Not approximately. At it. Archaeoastronomers have stood on that ridge with their instruments — Hively and Horn back in 1982, Romain, Lepper — and watched the sun go down exactly where the builders said it would, a thousand years ago, or two thousand, depending on whom you ask, and that’s the rub, and we’ll get to the rub.

It is one of the wonders of the ancient Americas. The foundation wants the world to come and feel that. That is not an evil wish. Hold onto that.

The elementary school in West Union let Lens sit in on a fourth-grade class that had visited the mound the week before. The teacher, Ms. Okafor, had them draw it from memory.

The drawings were better than any survey.

One kid had drawn it as a roller coaster. One had drawn the egg as a literal egg, cracked, with a tiny dinosaur emerging, which Lens privately considered the most defensible interpretation she’d heard all week. A girl named Brynn had drawn the serpent eating the sun, the sun with a frowning face.

“Why’s the sun sad?” Lens asked.

“Cause it’s getting eaten.”

“Does the snake eat it every day?”

Brynn gave her the look fourth-graders reserve for slow adults. “Just the long day. My grandpa told me. The snake catches it once and then it lets go and the days get short again.”

Lens didn’t say anything. She’d learned that from Mara without Mara saying it — that when someone hands you something whole, you don’t take it apart in front of them to see how it works.

Ms. Okafor walked her out. “Half these kids have family that wants the foundation money,” she said quietly at the door. “Half have family that thinks it’s a sin to sell the view.” She watched the buses idle. “I just teach them it’s old and it’s theirs. Whoever built it, it’s the county’s now. That’s the part nobody fights about.”

“You sure about that?”

Ms. Okafor laughed, not happily. “No.”

The potato is this: nobody knows how old it is.

Not “we have a rough idea.” Not “the experts lean one way.” *Nobody knows*, and the not-knowing is the diamond-hard kind that survives every test you throw at it.

In 1996 a team from the University of Cincinnati — Lepper among them — pulled charcoal from beneath the mound and ran it. The carbon came back around 1070 CE. That’s Fort Ancient culture. Medieval, by European reckoning. Five hundred years after the Adena had stopped building anything at all.

Except the Adena built effigy mounds. Fort Ancient mostly didn’t. For a century before that charcoal, the consensus was Adena — built somewhere around 320 BCE, maybe earlier, on the strength of the mound’s shape and the artifacts and the burial mounds beside it, which *are* Adena, which *do* hold Adena dead.

So you have a serpent that looks Adena, sits beside Adena graves, in the Adena style — built, the carbon says, by people who weren’t Adena, who’d shown up a thousand years too late to be Adena, who didn’t usually build serpents.

And the older excavations — Putnam, back in the 1880s, and the re-analyses after — those turned up dates that fit the Adena story fine. Which could mean the Adena built it. Or could mean the Adena *used* the spot, lived there, left their charcoal, and somebody else came along a millennium later and raised the serpent over the ashes of their fires.

Both camps are credentialed. Both are published. Both are, as of right now, this year, unbeaten. The literature has not closed.

Frik, up on the ridge, had put it less gently. “*The carbon’s from under the mound. Under. You date the fire, not the snake. Could be a picnic. You’re carbon-dating somebody’s picnic and calling it the builders.*” Mara had not disagreed. That was the thing about Frik — he was usually saying the part everyone knew and nobody would write down.

The foundation’s stakeholder forum was in the Methodist fellowship hall, folding chairs and a sheet cake and Eric Sandoval in a quarter-zip the exact color of trust.

Lens stood at the back with the camera down. There were maybe sixty people. Dell Hartzell was there, arms crossed. Ms. Okafor. Surveyors in their polos along one wall like a chorus. And Mara, in the second row, not at the front, which Lens noted, because the foundation had clearly wanted her at the front.

Sandoval was good. That was the unsettling thing. He wasn’t slick in the way you could dismiss. He had photographs of crumbling visitor centers in other counties, real ones, places that had let their treasures rot for lack of a turnstile. He talked about *narrative cohesion* and *interpretive clarity* and he meant, underneath the words, something a person could want: *Let’s stop being confused. Let’s give the world one clear thing to love.*

“We’ve been advised,” Sandoval said, “and we want to be transparent — that the current scientific *best estimate* places construction in the Fort Ancient period, around 1070 of the Common Era. Now. The visitor experience would foreground that finding while *honoring* the broader story —”

“Whose best estimate?” Frik. He’d come down off the ridge. He was standing by the cake, and he had a plate, and he had said it through

a mouthful of frosting with the specific volume of a man who does not modulate. A tic snapped his shoulder. “The carbon’s from a fire pit *under* the construction. It dates a fire. Not the basket-carrying. Hively and Horn never dated it at all, they measured the *angle* — that’s geometry, not a birthday. You’ve got one good radiocarbon study and a hundred years of morphology saying the opposite and you’re putting the year on a *plaque*.”

The room did the thing rooms do.

Sandoval, to his credit, didn’t flinch. “We’re aware the literature is — nuanced.”

“It’s not nuanced. It’s *open*.” Frik’s hand jumped. “Nuanced is when you know and it’s complicated. Open is when you *don’t know*. You’re selling nuanced. It’s open.”

And here is where it could have become the crew’s scene, the clever outsiders cracking the room. It didn’t, because Mara stood up.

She didn’t raise her voice. She didn’t have to. People had been waiting for her to, all night, and the waiting itself had built a silence she could step into.

“Mr. Sandoval asked me to confirm a date tonight,” Mara said. “I’m not going to.”

A murmur.

“Not because I’m being difficult. Because I can’t. And because” — she turned, slightly, taking the room in, the farmers and the teacher and the surveyors and the empty back rows where the elders weren’t — “even if I could, I’d be speaking for more people than have agreed to let me speak for them.”

“Dr. Tallchief,” Sandoval said gently, “you’re the cultural authority here. The county recognizes —”

“The county recognizes me. Not everyone in this room recognizes the county.” She let that land soft. “There are families on the reservation edge who think a sign that says *built by Fort Ancient in 1070* is a lie. There are families who think a sign that says *Adena* is a lie. There are people who think the whole question of *who* is the wrong question, and they’re not wrong to think it. I can read this site. I can’t make sixty histories into one brochure. Nobody can. The honest thing —

the *only* honest thing — is to say it's contested, and say it out loud, and let the people who come stand in front of it not knowing." A beat. "Not knowing is allowed."

Sandoval wrote something down. Lens would have given a year of her life to read it.

"That's a difficult experience to market," he said, finally, and it wasn't a sneer. It was just true, and he knew it was true, and you could see it cost him.

"Yes," Mara said. "It is."

Afterward, in the parking lot, the cicadas had taken over from the air-conditioning and the night smelled of cut grass and warm asphalt.

Dell Hartzell found Lens by the van. "She's right and it's gonna sink the money," he said, not angry, just weighing it. "Can't sell *we don't know*. People drive three hours, they want a fact. They want to point." He looked toward the ridge, invisible in the dark, but you could feel it up there the way you feel a held breath. "Maybe that's the whole sickness of it. Everybody wants to point."

He got in his truck. He didn't say which way he'd come down, in the end. Lens suspected he didn't know either.

The elder Lens had been told about all week — the one whose name Mara wrote last on the list, with no instruction beside it, only a small careful dash — did not come to the forum. He never came up the ridge. He lived in a low house near the edge of the rez with a dog that did not bark and a porch that faced east.

Mara went to him after, and Lens drove her, and waited in the van with the windows down, and did not bring the camera, because Mara had not asked her to, and because the dog watched her like it was keeping score.

She couldn't hear most of it. The porch light was off. There was the low back-and-forth of two people who had known each other a long time, the dog's tail thumping once on the boards, a long quiet.

Then the old man's voice, clear, the way old voices carry when they've decided to.

"You did right tonight," he said. "You held the line." A pause. The screen door creaked. "But listen to me, daughter. You're so busy keeping it open for them. So they can't close it. Good. That's good work." Another pause, longer. "But some of it isn't supposed to be open *or* closed. Some of it isn't theirs to wonder at."

Lens stopped breathing.

"The carbon, the angles, the sun on the long day — let them have all that. Let them argue till they die. That's the outside of it." The thump of a cane, or a hand, on wood. "Not everything is for the world to know, Mara. You can guard the question. But you don't owe anybody the part that was never a question to us."

The dog stood, stretched, lay back down.

Mara said something Lens couldn't hear. It was short. It might have been *I know*. It might have been *yes*.

When she came back to the van she didn't speak for a mile. The headlights swung over the river bottoms, the soybean rows running silver, the ridge a deeper black ahead of them with the serpent on it, holding whatever it held.

"You get it?" Mara asked finally. Not unkind. Just checking.

"No," Lens said. "Camera was in the bag."

Mara nodded slowly, looking out at the dark. "Good," she said. And then, almost to herself, the way you set something down that you mean to carry a long way: "Keep it there a while."

The cicadas went on and on, all the way back up the hill, saying nothing the world could use.

Chapter 9 — The Evidence: Bones, Charcoal, and Absence

The folding table in the field tent had a wobble, and somebody had jammed a flattened pop can under the short leg, and the can said MOUNTAIN DEW in letters worn down to ghost-print, and Frik kept looking at it because the table still wobbled anyway. That was the thing about the fix. It didn't fix it. It just moved the wobble to a place you couldn't see.

"You're staring at the table," said Mara, not looking up.

"The can doesn't work," Frik said. "It's a millimeter off. You should use a folded business card. Three folds."

"Noted." She slid the first tray toward him under the work lamp. "Don't touch those without gloves."

He pulled the nitrile on, two snaps, and bent over the tray.

Charcoal. That was the headline, and the headline lied, the way headlines do. What was actually in front of him was a row of glassine envelopes laid on foam, each one a little coffin with a number, and inside each one a fleck of something that had once been on fire. Some of it was wood. Some of it was probably wood. One envelope held a smear of black the size of a dried lentil, and on its label somebody had written, in pencil, beneath the catalog number, the single most honest word in archaeology: *prob.*

Probably.

"This is the 1996 horizon," Mara said. "Or near it. The Cincinnati team pulled charcoal from soil under the mound body and ran it. Three samples, give or take, came back clustering around the eleventh century. Call it 1070, plus or minus seventy."

"Fort Ancient," Frik said.

"That's the inference. Charcoal under the mound dates the building of the mound, because you don't get a fire *under* an earthwork after the earthwork's already there." She let that sit. "Clean logic. Good chronology. Lepper and the others published it, it's peer-reviewed, it's real."

"So it's solved."

Mara smiled the way you smile at a child who's just confidently told you how a magnet works.

She slid the second tray over.

This one was older. The foam was yellowed and the labels were typed on an actual typewriter, the kind that punched the o clean through the card. PUTNAM, one read. 1880s. Inside: a bone fragment the color of weak tea, no bigger than a thumbnail, and beside it a chip of fired clay with a scratch of decoration on its lip, and the decoration was a row of little fingernail impressions, somebody pressing their thumbnail into wet clay nine hundred or two thousand or some-number years ago while thinking about lunch or grief or absolutely nothing.

"Putnam dug here in the eighteen-eighties," Mara said. "Saved the mound from being plowed flat, basically. Bought the land with Boston money and gave it to the state. He pulled artifacts. Later people reran what they could. Some of those readings come back *old*. Adena-old. Eight hundred BCE to the start of the common era, that whole window."

"So it's both."

"It's neither, cleanly." She set a third envelope down between the two trays, deliberately, like a referee placing a ball. "Here's your problem, and it's a good one. The land was *used* before it was *built on*. People were up here for a very long time. So if you find old charcoal—" she touched the Putnam tray, "—does it date the serpent, or does it

date the campfire of somebody who sat here a thousand years before anyone moved the first basket of dirt?"

Frik's leg started going under the table, heel drumming, and he let it. "You can't tell the difference," he said. "Old fire and old fire look the same. The dirt doesn't write *I was a mound-builder* on the carbon."

"No."

"And the new charcoal—" he gestured at the 1996 tray, "—that's *under* the mound, so it's a floor, so it's the building. But only if the building went up right after the fire. Could've been a fire, then the spot sat bare for three centuries, then they built." His mouth ran ahead of him, the way it did, the words coming out faster than the polite version could catch them. "Could've been they cleared the brush by burning, then *waited*. Charcoal doesn't have a clock for *how long it sat there cold*."

"There it is," Mara said quietly. "That's the whole war, in one breath."

The fish, on the bottom of the page, declines to be impressed:

Two dates. One mound. A thousand years apart. Both peer-reviewed. Both right. Somewhere a textbook is sweating.

The thing nobody tells you about a dating controversy is how *boring* it looks. There's no skull in a velvet case. There's a tray. There's a pencil notation that says *prob*. There's a man with two credentialed camps who each have data and each have a hole and each can explain the other guy's data and neither can make the other guy's data disappear. It is the least cinematic war on Earth and it has been going for forty years.

Frik loved it. Frik loved it the way other people loved a clean room. Here was a place where nobody had decided yet, where the comfortable lie hadn't sealed over the top of things, where you were *allowed* to say *I don't know* without anyone treating it as a moral failing.

He worked the trays for an hour. Mara handed him the records and he read them out flat, no smoothing, because smoothing was a thing

other people did and he had given up apologizing for being unable to.

“Sample beta dash four-four-one,” he read. “Wood charcoal. Calibrated, two-sigma, ten-twenty to eleven-sixty CE. Footnote says possible old-wood effect not excluded.”

“Old-wood effect,” Mara said for the benefit of the crew member filming over her shoulder. “If you burn a log that was already five hundred years old when you burned it, the charcoal reads five hundred years too early. The carbon’s counting the tree’s death, not the fire.”

“So even the *new* date could be older than it looks,” Friik said. “And the *old* dates could be earlier campfires.” He set the card down. “Everybody’s right. Everybody’s standing on a different rock and the rocks are all real and the water’s between them.”

“You should write the brochure,” said a voice from the tent flap.

His name was Sandoval and he had walked the back roads of America in pressed polos until the dust had given up trying. He held a tablet against his chest like a hymnal, and he was, Friik had to give him this, not a villain. Friik had met villains. Villains didn’t bring you coffee. Sandoval had brought coffee, three of them, balanced in a cardboard tray, and he set them down on the wobbling table and the table wobbled and the coffee did not spill and that, somehow, annoyed Friik more than anything.

“Dr. Tallchief,” Sandoval said. “The board meets Thursday. The World Heritage dossier needs a construction date in the lead paragraph. Not a range. A date. The nominators have asked, the interpretive designers have asked, frankly the *donors* have asked, because a date is a story and a range is a footnote, and nobody flies to Ohio for a footnote.”

“The footnote is the truth,” Friik said.

Sandoval turned to him with the patience of a man who has been told this before. “The truth can have a hero version. Eleven seventy. Fort Ancient. There’s good peer-reviewed science behind it. We cite it, we put it on the wall, we put a little asterisk for the academics, and the public gets a *story*. They can stand at the overlook and know

they're looking at something a thousand years old, built by a named people, on a date. That's a gift. That's *clarity*."

"It's a coin flip painted gold," Frik said.

Lens, by the tent wall, had her camera up. She wasn't filming Sandoval. She was filming the trays, the foam, the typewriter labels, the word *prob.* in pencil. She'd learned a while ago that the picture was never the man talking; it was the thing on the table he was talking over.

"Eric," Mara said, and she said it kindly, which was worse for him than if she'd snapped. "If I put a date in the lead paragraph and it's wrong, I don't get to take it back. You'll have laminated it. There will be a six-foot graphic. Children will recite it. And in fifteen years, when somebody re-runs the cores with a method we don't have yet, the graphic will still be there, and it'll be a *lie*, and it'll be a lie with *my* name under it."

"It won't be a lie. It'll be the best available—"

"It'll be the best available answer presented as the *only* answer," she said. "Those aren't the same sentence."

Sandoval breathed out through his nose. "The public can't hold two dates."

"The public," Mara said, "holds two dates about the *origin of the universe* and goes to church about it on Sundays. They can hold two dates about a snake."

That was when she did the thing the crew had come to watch her do, which was to walk them away from the carbon entirely.

She put the trays back in their crate and she carried it herself, waving off Frik's hands, and she led them out of the tent into the late gold of the afternoon, and the cicadas came up around them in that wall of sound that wasn't sound after a while, just the texture of the air. The mound lay along the ridge below the overlook trail, coil after coil, the spiral tail wound tight, the long body undulating toward the oval at the head, and the grass on it was mowed and ordinary and the whole thing was a quarter of a mile of dirt that someone had loved into the shape of an animal.

"You want to know what I keep coming back to," Mara said, and she wasn't asking. "It's not in the trays. It's what isn't."

Frik's leg had stopped. He'd gone quiet, which for him was a kind of listening so total it looked like absence.

"Adena built burial mounds," Mara said. "Conical. Stacked their dead in them, generation on generation, with grave goods—copper, pipes, the works. There are conical mounds *right over there*." She nodded down the ridge. "Adena burials. Real ones. Bones, goods, the whole funerary grammar."

"And the serpent?" said the crew's systems analyst, who had been counting the coils under her breath because she counted things, all of them, the way other people breathed.

"Nothing," Mara said. "No burial in the effigy. No grave goods in the body of the snake. No bones in the egg. Putnam went looking. People since have looked. The mound is a quarter mile of deliberate, *enormous* labor, and there is no one buried in it and nothing buried with them."

She let that land the way she let everything land, by saying it once and then shutting up.

"It's not a tomb," Frik said.

"It's not a tomb," Mara agreed. "Whatever it's for, the dead aren't in it. So whatever the answer is, it isn't *who's buried here*. It was never going to be in the bones. It can't be. There aren't any."

The fish, from the lowlands:

Forty years arguing over a date for a grave with nobody in it. Maybe ask what it's the date OF.

Jakobus had been somewhere else the whole afternoon, the way he was always somewhere else right up until the second he wasn't. He'd been down at the river lowlands, then up the trail, then sitting on the overlook with his hat off, and now he came back with a stick of charcoal—real charcoal, a burned twig, which Frik found unreason-

ably funny given the day—and a brown paper sack he'd flattened into a sheet.

He didn't talk much. He never talked much. He crouched at the edge of the overlook and put the flattened sack on the boards and started drawing, and the crew gathered the way people gather around a man working with his hands.

He drew the ridge first. The lay of it, the way the land humped and rolled because the crater under it had broken the bedrock half a billion years ago and nothing up here sat the way ground was supposed to sit. Then he drew the coils, fast, not pretty, the seven turns of the body and the tight spiral of the tail and the open oval at the head. Then—and this was the part where Frik stopped breathing—he drew the *water*. The springs Mara had walked them past. The places the ground went soft. The lines where, in a wet year, the water ran off the ridge and found the low ground and went down to the river.

He held the sack up. The serpent lay along the high ground, and the water lay in the low ground, and the body of the snake followed the spine of the ridge exactly the way the ridge separated which way the water would fall.

He looked at Mara first. Not at the crew. At Mara. He held the drawing out toward her, offering it, the question in the offer: *Is this yours to say, or mine to shut up about?*

She looked at it a long time.

"Go on," she said.

Jakobus turned the sack so the crew could see, and he put one weathered finger on the head, where the oval opened toward the place on the horizon they'd come back at the solstice to watch the sun fall into.

"It's not a grave," he said.

The cicadas filled the gap where someone else would have rushed to finish the sentence.

"It's a map."

And then he set the sack down on the boards, and put a pebble on each corner so the wind wouldn't take it, and stepped back—out of the frame, off to the side, the way he always did the second the thing

was said—and left the four of them standing over a drawing of a snake that followed the water, with the head pointed at a sunset they hadn't yet watched, and nobody, not even Frik, said another word, because the question hanging over the paper was so much bigger and so much better than the date, and tomorrow at dusk the horizon would tell them whether the old man had read it right.

Chapter 10 — The Adversary: The Cost of Closure

The donors came up the ridge at golden hour, which was, Lens decided, no accident. Nobody schedules a fundraiser for noon. Noon flattens everything; the coils go to nothing under a high sun, just a low green ridge with a fence around it. But at six in the evening the serpent throws shadow, the seven bends of its body lift off the ground like a long muscle tensing, and people who have driven four hours from Columbus in rented SUVs stop talking and put their phones away for almost a full second.

She framed it without raising the camera. Old habit. You learn to see the shot before you commit to it, and you learn — she was still learning — not to take every shot you see.

Eric Sandoval stood at the head of the effigy, near the oval, the egg, the thing in the serpent's open mouth. He'd chosen his spot the way a preacher chooses a pulpit. Behind him the head pointed west-northwest toward the tree line, toward the notch where, in three nights, the longest sunset of the year would drop exactly where the builders had aimed it. He wore a charcoal quarter-zip with the Heritage Foundation crest stitched small over the heart. No clipboard tonight. The clipboards were back in the trailer with the drones.

"Two thousand years ago," Eric said, and let it hang.

Lens watched a woman in linen mouth the words back to herself. *Two*

thousand years.

“Two thousand years ago,” Eric went on, warmer now, “someone stood where I’m standing. And they looked at this ridge — this strange, broken ground — and they decided to make a serpent a quarter of a mile long, and to point its head at the exact place the sun dies on the longest day of the year. And it’s still here. It survived the plow. It survived the looters. It survived us.” A small laugh from the linen woman. “Our job — your job, if you choose it — is to make sure it survives the next two thousand.”

It was good. That was the trouble. Lens had spent eleven years photographing men who lied for a living and she could usually feel the lie come off them like heat off asphalt. There was none of that here. Eric Sandoval believed every word. He loved this place. He had the slightly raw look of a man who’d been up since four reading about Adena ceramics so he could love it more accurately.

Frik was twenty feet down the trail, on the public side of the rope, pretending to read the interpretive sign. Lens could see his jaw working, the small private storm of it. He had a fact in his mouth and he was holding it like a man holds a coal.

The sign, she knew, said *approximately 1070 CE*. It said Fort Ancient culture. It said it with the calm authority of state-printed aluminum.

“Now,” Eric said, and the *now* was a salesman’s *now*, the turn toward the ask. “What we’re building isn’t a museum. Museums are where wonder goes to get a label.” Appreciative murmur. “What we’re building is an *experience*. You’ll arrive at dusk. You’ll walk the serpent as the shadows come up. And you’ll understand — not read, *understand* — who made this, and when, and most of all, *why*.”

Lens felt Frik move before she heard him.

He didn’t cross the rope. Give him that. He stood on his side of it and said, to the sign, but loud enough, “We don’t know when.”

A few heads turned. Eric’s didn’t. Eric had clearly been briefed that there were independent documentarians on site and that one of them was — the word in the briefing had probably been *colorful*.

“There’s a lot we’re still learning,” Eric said smoothly, to his donors, not to Frik. “That’s part of the adventure.”

"No, but we genuinely don't know when," Frik said. His shoulder jumped. The tic took the end of the sentence and threw it sideways. "The carbon under the mound says 1070. *Fffft*. Eleven hundred years. But the artifacts that came out of here in the 1880s, the Adena stuff, that's two thousand-plus, that's a *different culture*, that's a thousand-year gap, and nobody — *sit* — nobody has closed it. It's open. It's been open since 1996. It's open right now while you're telling them it's closed."

Silence on the ridge. A cicada wound up somewhere down in the lowlands and ran its long mechanical scream.

Lens raised the camera. Just to the chest. She got Eric's face — and the thing she got was not anger. It was a flicker of something more honest and more dangerous than anger. It was *the wish that the man would stop*. The look of someone holding a beautiful smooth stone who has just been told there's a crack in it, and would very much prefer not to turn it over.

"We have a wonderful conversation planned for tomorrow with the lead archaeologist," Eric said, recovering, "who can speak to all of that far better than I can." A graceful hand toward the trailers. "Wine's down at the center. Watch your footing on the slope — the ground here is older than the mound. There's a meteorite crater under all of us. How's *that* for a foundation."

The donors laughed, relieved, and began to drift downslope toward the lit windows of the visitor center, and Eric let out a breath Lens caught in profile. Then he walked, deliberately, over to the rope.

"You're right," he said to Frik. Quietly. Just the three of them now. "About the dating. You're completely right."

Frik blinked. He was braced for a fight and the fight had handed him a chair.

"It's unresolved," Eric said. "Lepper's '96 carbon, the Adena artifacts, the morphology argument — I've read all of it. I could give your speech. I could give it better, no offense." A tired smile. "But I'm going to tell you something, and I'd like you to hear it the way I mean it, not the way it sounds." He looked back up the spine of the serpent, the coils gone soft and long in the low light. "Those people are going to give the foundation four million dollars over the next

two years. And that money is the difference between this place being protected and this place being a parking lot for an outlet mall in fifteen years. That's not a metaphor. There's a development corridor proposed nine miles from here. You can look it up."

Lens believed that too. That was the second trouble.

"You can't fundraise on a question mark," Eric said. "You can preserve a *story*. You can't preserve a debate. A debate doesn't have a gift shop. A debate doesn't get a UNESCO designation, and the designation is the only thing that makes the land legally untouchable forever. So yes. I'm going to give them a date. And in a hundred years when somebody finally settles it, they'll change the sign, and the mound will still be here for them to change it. That's the trade." He spread his hands, clean, open. "Tell me the version where the question mark wins."

Frik's mouth opened. Closed. His head ducked, twice, the tic riding the silence.

Lens lowered the camera. She had learned, this past year, the specific weight of the moment when you should stop shooting — when the lens stops being a witness and starts being a thing the subject performs for. She'd learned it the hard way, in places she didn't photograph anymore. Eric was not performing. He had just told the truth as he understood it, which was its own kind of terrible.

"That's the cost," she heard herself say.

Eric looked at her.

"Of the answer," she said. "Somebody pays it. You're just deciding it's worth it."

"I am," he said simply, and she liked him slightly more for not pretending otherwise. "Aren't you? You're here to publish *something*. You're going to point your camera at this and people are going to look at the picture and decide they know what it is. The frame's a choice too." He nodded at the camera in her hands. "What's the difference between your frame and my sign?"

It landed where he'd aimed it. Lens kept her face still and felt the hit go through anyway.

The difference, she thought later, walking the dark trail back, was that

her frame was supposed to leave the edges in. The whole discipline of it — the thing she'd nearly lost and was clawing back — was the discipline of *what shouldn't be in frame and is*. The body the official caption left out. The crack in the smooth stone. A good photograph didn't settle a thing. It refused to.

But she hadn't said it. She'd let him have the last word, and the question was still sitting in her chest like a swallowed stone.

They found Mara at the conical mounds, away from the wine and the windows, sitting on a low stone with her field notebook closed in her lap. She wasn't writing. She was watching the egg-shape at the serpent's mouth go from gold to grey, the way the coils ahead of it bent through the dark, and the way the head still found the notch in the western trees even now, even with no sun in it, pointing at the place the sun would be.

"He pitch the donors yet?" she said, without turning.

"Two thousand years ago," Lens said.

"Mm." A short breath through the nose. "Last week it was a thousand. He'll settle on whichever number tests better." Not bitter. Worn smooth, like the stone she sat on. "They came to me again today. Eric's project lead. Very gentle about it. They want a sentence. One sentence with a culture and a century in it, for the application. 'Constructed circa,' culture comma, the end. They have a deadline, the donors have a tax year, the year has a quarter, the quarter has a *Tuesday*." She turned the notebook over in her hands. "I can give them the sentence. Or I can not give them the sentence and they find someone with letters after their name who will, and then it's their sign, not anyone's I'd trust, and I'm a woman who walked away from the only table where the land had a seat."

Frik had been quiet the whole walk — Lens had clocked it, the way you clock a clock that's stopped. Now he crouched a few feet from Mara, on his heels, and Lens watched him not speak. Watched him hold it.

He had the fact. He'd been holding it all evening. The 1996 charcoal under the mound. The Adena artifacts and the thousand-year hole between them and the carbon. The lunar-standstill alignments that

Hively and Horn argued and others didn't buy. He had all of it loaded and true and he could have laid it at Mara's feet like a hunting dog, *here, here is the inconvenient thing, here is why you can't sign*, and it would have been correct and it would have been *for him* — for the relief of the saying, the coal out of his mouth.

He didn't.

"What do you want," he said instead. Just that. Three words, the tic taking none of them, his eyes on the dark coils and not on her face, which Lens had come to understand was how Frik gave a person room.

Mara looked at him for a long moment.

"You're asking me," she said. Like she was testing the shape of it.

"You know when it was built better than the sign does," Frik said. "You know it doesn't say. Everybody up here's been telling you what it means since 1880. Putnam dug it. The carbon people. The Adena people. The giant-skeleton people, the cosmic-message people." His shoulder twitched. "Eric. Us." He glanced at Lens. "Us too. So I'm not gonna tell you. *Fffk*. I'm asking. What do *you* want to do."

And Lens, standing back with the camera dark at her side, understood that this was the thing Frik had been learning all year and had just, on a stone in the dark by the burial mounds, finally done. Not the puncture. The withholding. He had a true and devastating fact and he had set it down unthrown, because the one person on this ridge who got to decide what it was *for* was not him.

Mara opened the notebook. There was just enough light from the visitor center, far down the slope, to see her hand move.

"There's a thing the carbon and the artifacts both miss," she said slowly. "They're both arguing about a *when*. When's a colonizer's question, mostly. When did *they* make it, so we can pin it, file it, own the pin." She tapped the notebook. "I walked the water again this morning. Before your radar people were up. The coils don't follow the high ground. You'd think they would — you build a thing this size, you want the dry spine of the ridge. They don't. The body dips. Three of the bends sit right over where the ground goes soft, where it weeps after rain, where the springs come up off the crater rock." She looked up at last, at both of them. "I'm not going to tell you what

that is yet. Tomorrow I'll show you, in light, and you can decide for your film whether you believe me. But I'll tell you what it isn't. It isn't a date. It was never a date." A small, hard smile. "Eric wants to sell a *when*. I think the mound was built to answer a *where*."

Frik's jaw worked. The fact rose in him — Lens watched it rise, the carbon, the contradiction, the *but actually the dating* — and she watched him swallow it whole, and keep it.

"Okay," he said.

"Okay?" Mara raised an eyebrow. "No correction? No *well, actually, Dr. Tallchief?*"

"I have like four of those," Frik said. "*Fffk*. They can wait."

Mara laughed, surprised, the first real one Lens had heard from her. Down the slope a door opened and a wedge of light fell out across the grass, and a figure stood in it — Eric, probably, looking up the dark ridge for the archaeologist he needed to produce in the morning, needing his sentence, needing his beautiful uncracked stone.

Mara stood. Closed the notebook. Looked west, where the head still pointed at the notch, patient, at nothing, at the place the sun would be on Saturday and had been for either a thousand or two thousand years, depending on who you let hold the pen.

"He's going to make me choose tomorrow," she said. "The table or the door."

"Which one," Lens asked.

Mara started down toward the light, unhurried, the long shadow of the serpent at her back.

"Ask me tomorrow," she said. "After I've shown you the water."

Lens raised the camera then — and lowered it. The shot was there. The woman walking down into the light, the coiled dark behind her, the question still open in the air like the held note of a cicada that won't quite stop.

She let the edges stay in. She let it go un-taken.

It wasn't hers to frame.

Chapter 11 — The Test:

Measuring the Impossible

Priya Okafor liked the world best at 5:14 a.m., when it hadn't decided yet what it was going to be.

The cicadas were still asleep. The ridge held a wet grey light that made the coils look less like a thing built and more like a thing surfaced, the way a whale's back breaks water for a second before you're sure you saw it. She stood at the survey baseline they'd flagged the evening before — pink ribbon, GPS waypoint, a number in her notebook she'd checked four times because checking was the only way she trusted anything. Below the rim the river lowlands were a held breath of fog. Above, the sky did the thing the sky did here, the thing nobody warned you about: it leaned. The horizon bent up at the edges like the inside of a bowl, because the whole landscape sat in the lip of a crater three hundred million years old, and your eye knew it before your brain caught up.

She set the GPR cart at the baseline and powered it on. The screen woke green.

"You talking to it yet?" Frik came up the trail behind her, two coffees, handing one over without looking, which she appreciated. Eye contact before caffeine was a tax she resented.

"It's warming up." She watched the antenna trace settle. "I want a clean pass on the second coil before the foundation's people are awake. Their drones jam my GPS uplink if they're flying."

"They're not allowed to fly before eight."

"Sandoval's allowed to do a lot of things he says he's allowed to do."

Frik snorted. He had a tic going this morning, a small click of the tongue every few seconds, metronomic, and she'd learned a year ago not to mention it, because mentioning it was like mentioning a tightrope walker's feet. He stood at the edge of the effigy with his coffee, looking down the serpent's length toward the head, where the open jaws gaped around the oval. The egg, the books called it. Or the eye. Or the sun the serpent was about to swallow. Pick a brochure.

"Run it," he said.

Here is the thing they were trying to do, said plainly, the way you'd say it to a stranger at a gas station who asked what the trucks were for.

They were trying to measure a fact that has refused, for a hundred and forty years, to be measured.

In 1883, Frederic Putnam, of Harvard's Peabody Museum, came up this ridge, fell in love, and dug. He cut into the coils, he sifted the conical mounds nearby, he pulled Adena material out of the ground — and Adena meant old, meant two thousand years and more, meant the serpent was a deep ancestor of a thing. For a century that was the answer, and it was a good answer, supported by artifacts and by the shape of the work itself, the way a building's bones tell you the decade.

Then in 1991 and 1996 a team from the University of Cincinnati — Lepper and colleagues — took charcoal from beneath the mound and ran it through a radiocarbon lab, and the lab said: 1070 CE, give or take seventy years. Which is not Adena. That's Fort Ancient. That's a thousand years younger. That's a different people, a different century, a different everything, built — if the carbon is right — about the time a comet hung over the medieval sky and a supernova lit up in the constellation we'd later call the Crab.

Two answers. A millennium apart. Both with credentialed defenders, peer-reviewed, still arguing in the journals as of this year, neither willing to fold.

Priya loved this problem the way other people loved a partner who was bad for them. It refused to resolve, and the refusal was *patterned*.

That was what kept her up. A messy answer is just noise. This wasn't noise. This was two strong signals that wouldn't average.

The GPR pass came back wrong.

Not wrong-broken. Wrong-interesting, which was worse. She ran the second coil end to end, the antenna humming over the grass, and the radargram built itself in horizontal bands down her screen — the layered story of the dirt, basket-load by basket-load, the way the builders had carried it up and tamped it down. Clay here. A darker stratum there, a buried soil, an old ground surface the mound had been raised on top of.

"You've got your charcoal layer," Frik said, reading over her shoulder. Click. "That dark band. That's where they pulled the 1070 sample."

"That's where *somebody's* sample came from." She zoomed. "But look at the base. The pre-mound soil's intact under part of the coil and disturbed under another part. Like there was something here before the something."

"Adena occupation. Putnam's stuff."

"Maybe. Or it's bioturbation. Tree roots. Burrowing. A thousand years of groundhogs." She hated that she had to say it. The honest answer always had a groundhog in it somewhere. "I can't date a soil with radar, Frik. I can see the layers. I can't read their birthday off a screen."

The fish — there's always a fish, the heckler in the corner of every museum, the one who reads the placard and says *yeah, but* — the fish would point out here that this is the whole tragedy of the place in one radargram. You can see the layers perfectly. Crisply. Beautifully. You can see *that* something was built. You simply cannot see *when*. The mound is generous with everything except the one number everyone wants.

By seven the foundation's tent was up at the trailhead and Eric Sandoval was walking the overlook in a polo the colour of a swimming pool, tablet in the crook of his arm, polite as Sunday.

“Morning, Priya.” He always learned everyone’s name fast. It was one of the genuinely nice things about him and also the most frightening. “How’s it looking?”

“It’s looking like ground-penetrating radar,” she said.

He smiled like that was a joke they were sharing. “Mara around?”

“She’s coring the egg.”

“The oval feature.” A tiny correction, gentle, and she watched him file *egg* away as folksy, off-brand, the kind of word the exhibit copy would smooth out. He came and stood at her shoulder, uninvited, and looked at the radargram. To his credit he looked at it properly. “So this tells us the date?”

“No.”

“What does it tell us?”

“That dirt is complicated.”

His jaw did a small patient thing. He was not a stupid man and that was the problem; he understood exactly what she’d said and exactly what it cost him. “Priya. The World Heritage nomination needs a construction date. Singular. The reviewing body needs a culture of attribution. The visitor center needs a sentence — one sentence — that a fourth-grader on a field trip can carry home in his head.” He gestured down the coils, fond, almost helpless. “People come up here and they ask *how old is it*, and right now we hand them a shrug. You can’t sell a shrug.”

“Nineteen-ninety-six gave you a date,” Frik said. Click. “Ten-seventy. Use that one.”

“You think I haven’t wanted to? The radiocarbon’s published, it’s defensible—”

“It’s contested,” Priya said.

“It’s a *number*. I can build an experience on a number.” He turned, took in the head, the jaws, the bent horizon beyond. “We are going to *celebrate* this place. We’re going to put it in front of the world. And the only thing standing between this ridge and forty million people who’ll fall in love with it is a footnote war between two professors who’ll both be dead before they admit the other one was right.” He

wasn't angry. He was *grieving*, almost, a project manager mourning a deadline. "Help me close it. That's all I want. Close it kindly."

They tried. God, they tried. Priya would say later it was the most thorough day of bad luck she'd ever logged.

They re-shot the solstice sightline first, while the morning was clean. Frik ran the laser from the head of the serpent down the centerline of the jaws and out to the notch in the northwest hills where, in 1982, Hively and Horn — two physicists, not archaeologists, which is its own delicious wrinkle — had measured the head pointing dead at the setting sun of the longest day. It still pointed there. It was uncanny and undeniable and Priya felt it in her sternum the way she always did, the pure pleasure of a thing that *worked*. The head aimed at the solstice sunset. That was real. You could check it tonight. You could check it in ten thousand years.

But.

"Doesn't date it," Frik said, lowering the laser. Click. "Solstice is solstice. The sun sets there for Adena. Sets there for Fort Ancient. Sets there for you and me. It's been setting there since before anybody built anything. You can't carbon-date a sunset."

"And the alignment doesn't pick a culture," Priya added, because someone had to say the whole ugly shape of it out loud. "Both peoples knew the sky. Lots of mound-builders watched the solstice. It tells us the head was *aimed*. On purpose. By someone who cared which way the sun went. It does not tell us their century."

The lunar alignments, the more exotic ones some researchers proposed for the coils — she checked those too, and they were the kind of thing that made her uneasy, because the more curves you've got the easier it is to find a sky-event near one of them, and the human eye will fit a pattern to noise the way water fits a glass. She wrote *suggestive, not exclusive* in her notebook and underlined it once, not twice. Twice would have been a feeling.

Then the soil cores came up from Mara's team near the egg, and the lab tech read the field notes, and the two stratigraphies — Priya's radar and the physical core — agreed on the layers and disagreed on everything that mattered. The buried surface was old. The mound

was — could be — younger. Or the old surface was old and the mound was built straight onto it long ago and the young charcoal was a camp-fire from a hunting party a thousand years after, a single bad ember dropped into the historical record like a typo into a Bible.

That was the whole museum in a thumb of dirt. Strong evidence, glaring gap, repeat. The potato peeled and peeled and was somehow bigger underneath.

By four in the afternoon, Sandoval had stopped coming to look at screens.

Mara Tallchief found Priya at the egg as the light went long and gold and the cicadas finally woke up all at once, a wall of sound that arrived like weather.

She was crouched at the oval, not measuring it, just resting a hand flat on the grass over it, and Priya understood without being told that this was a different kind of reading than hers, and didn't interrupt it. Mara had been up here since before dawn three days running. The foundation's clock was almost out; the survey window closed at week's end whether the dirt confessed or not. She had the particular stillness of a person who had stopped expecting the instruments to save her.

"Your radar's good," Mara said at last, not turning. "Cleanest base-layer reads I've seen up here. Better than ninety-six." A pause. "And it can't tell me the year."

"No." Priya sat on her heels in the grass. "I'm sorry. I keep getting two answers that won't be one answer. I've been doing this fifteen years and the mound's making me feel like I learned it yesterday."

Something moved at the corner of Mara's mouth — not a smile, a near one. "He told you to close it kindly."

"He did."

"He's not wrong to want it. That's the part that's hard." Mara looked down the long spine of the serpent toward the head and the notch where, in two and a half hours, the sun would do its trick. "People drive a long way to ask how old. They want to be handed a number

so they can stop wondering and start feeling. I understand it. The wondering is *work*. Not everybody's got the room for it."

The fog had crept back into the lowlands while they spoke. The crater rim caught the gold and held it. From up here you could see how the land *moved* — how it wasn't flat country with a snake on it but a great rolling disturbance, the bones of an ancient catastrophe, and the serpent laid along the highest ridge of it like a thought somebody'd had about the shape of the ground itself.

Priya found she was looking at it differently than her screen had taught her. The screen showed her *down*, into the layers, into the failed clock of the carbon. Up here the thing pointed *out*, along the ridge, at the springs the dowers swore by, at the water that ran underground through the broken crater rock, at the sun, at the notch, at the bent edge of the visible world.

"I had every method out today," Priya said quietly, almost to herself. "Radiocarbon's a war. Radar shows layers and no dates. The cores contradict the cores. The solstice is real and proves nothing about *when*. GPS gets me a centimeter on the surface and tells me nothing about the soul of it." Click — from Frik, drifting up behind them, listening the way he listened, which was completely. "I measured everything I know how to measure. And the thing I came to find isn't in any of it."

Mara stood. She dusted the grass off her knees, unhurried, a woman who had all the time in the world and almost none of it, and she looked at the three of them — the pattern-spotter, the truth-blurter, and somewhere down the trail the camera that was always asking to be lowered.

"That's the right place to be standing," she said. "Most people get there years later. Some never do." She turned her face to the head of the serpent, to the jaws and the egg and the notch beyond, where the light was beginning its slow fall toward the hills.

"So let me ask you the only question worth asking up here." A breath. The cicadas roared and went quiet, the way they do, a tide. "How do you measure what you can't see?"

She didn't wait for an answer. She started walking toward the head, toward the sunset, and after a moment, not knowing yet what they

were following, they followed.

Chapter 12 — The Debate: Who Owns the Story?

The van smelled of warm vinyl and someone's gas-station coffee gone cold in the cupholder. Outside, the ridge had gone violet, the cicadas winding down into the long machine-drone they made at dusk, and the serpent lay out there in the dark doing what it had done for either a thousand years or two thousand, depending on which credentialed person you cornered.

Frik had the laptop open on his knees, the GPR profiles stacked in a window, and he was bouncing his heel against the floor mat in a rhythm that wasn't a choice.

"We have it," he said. "We have it on three transects. The coils sit over the shallow flow. The egg sits over where two flows braid. That's — that's not nothing, that's a *map*, the thing is a map of where the water is —"

"We have a correlation," said Devi from the back, not looking up from her own screen. Devi was the systems analyst, autistic, and she said things the way other people set down glassware. "Three transects on the south slope. We have no transects on the north coils because Sandoval's people had the grid roped. We have a thing that is consistent with a hypothesis. We do not have a thing."

"It's consistent with the *only* hypothesis that explains the *placement* —"

"It's consistent with one hypothesis." Devi turned the screen so the line traces faced him, as if the data should arbitrate. "There. Look. The variance on transect two could be the 1880s spoil. Putnam

dug here. Romain restored. You're reading water under somebody's wheelbarrow."

Frik's jaw worked. "*Wheelbarrow*," he said, and it came out twice, the tic riding the word — "wheelbarrow, wheelbarrow — okay, but the slope's *wrong* for the spoil, the spoil sits proud, this dips —"

"Lower," said Lens, from the passenger seat, quietly, and for a second nobody knew if she meant her voice or the camera.

She had it up against the glass. She'd had it up for an hour. Through the windshield the ridge was just a darker shape on a dark sky now, the overlook trail a pale thread, the conical mounds off to the left where the actual dead were — the Adena dead, the ones with the artifacts, the ones whose burial goods had let a hundred years of men say *Adena built the serpent* with the confidence of people who had never once watched a sun set over it.

"There's nobody in it," Lens said. "The serpent. You know that? People assume there's somebody buried in the serpent. There isn't. They dug. It's hollow of us. The bodies are next door in the little cones, and the big one — the big one's just dirt in a shape." She lowered the camera. "I keep wanting somebody to be in it. To frame it as a grave. It photographs like a grave."

"It's not a grave," Frik said. "It's a — it's an instrument. Devi, tell her it's —"

"It is a thing of unsettled function," Devi said, "made by an unsettled culture, at an unsettled date. That is the entire inventory of what it is."

Here is the official story, and you should hear it straight, because the people who hold each end of it are not fools, and several of them have spent their whole lives on this ridge in the cold and the chiggers, and they have earned it.

In 1996 a team from the University of Cincinnati — Lepper and others — pulled charcoal from beneath the mound itself, from the body of the thing, and ran it, and the radiocarbon came back around 1070 of the common era, give or take seventy years. That is Fort Ancient time. That is a thousand years after the Adena had laid down their

dead in the little cones next door. The charcoal was *under* the dirt of the serpent. It is hard to argue with charcoal that is under the thing you are dating. So a great many serious people said, gently and with footnotes: the serpent is Fort Ancient. Roughly a millennium old. Built by farmers who knew the sky.

And a great many other serious people said, equally gently, with their own footnotes: look at the *artifacts*. Look at the morphology, the shape-grammar of the mound, the company it keeps with the Adena cones. Look at the older carbon dates that came up in the earlier work, the Putnam-era stuff and the re-analyses, the ones that land in Adena country, eight hundred years before the common era to a hundred after. Maybe the charcoal under the mound is from a fire on a hill someone used long before they ever piled the serpent on it. Maybe you dated the campsite, not the cathedral.

As of right now — and you can check this, it is in the peer-reviewed literature, it has not gone away — nobody has closed it. Both camps publish. Both camps are credentialed. Both camps are, in the technical sense, *unbeaten*. You can put your money on a number and you will be betting against living scholars who know more than you do.

That is the potato. The easy version — *we radiocarbon things now, we have machines, surely the age of a dirt snake in Ohio is a solved problem* — that version dies the moment you read two papers.

The fish would like to point out that the entire discipline of archaeology has just spent thirty years failing to date a single large object that does not move, is not on fire, and has stayed in one place. We have landed instruments on comets. We cannot agree on the birthday of a hill.

“So we publish,” Frik said. “We put the water map up. We don’t touch the date. We say nothing about the date. We just say: here’s a function nobody mapped, here’s the GPR, here’s the springs, you decide. That’s *clean*. That’s the most honest thing in the whole —”

“It’s not ours to publish,” Lens said.

“It’s *data*. Data isn’t owned, data is —”

“Frik.” Devi closed her laptop. The click was very loud. “Whose grid

did we run on?”

A silence with a heel-bounce in it.

“Mara’s permit,” Devi said. “Mara’s land relationship. Mara’s relationships with the elders who don’t come up the ridge but who told her things they have not told us and will not tell us. We ran our boxes over her permit. If we publish, we publish her access, her standing, her last survey before the foundation closes — and we hand the foundation a number to argue *against*, which means we hand them a reason to put her name on a sign she doesn’t want her name on.”

“I’m not — that’s not what I —”

“I know it’s not what you mean.” Devi’s voice didn’t soften, but it slowed, which from Devi was the same thing. “You read the ground. You do it better than anyone in this van and it isn’t close. But the ground isn’t the only thing in the room, and you keep forgetting there’s a room.”

Frik went very still, the way he did when a true thing arrived that he couldn’t blurt his way out of, and his hands found the edge of the laptop and held it like a rail.

The side door rolled open.

Jakobus didn’t get in. He never quite got in. He crouched in the gap with one boot on the running board and the dark ridge behind him, and he had the smell of the outside on him, cut grass and cold metal — he’d been down at the surveyors’ staging by the gate, where the foundation kept its drones in foam cases and its flags rolled in a quiver like arrows.

He didn’t ask what they’d been arguing about. He’d heard it through the panel. He looked at the laptop in Frik’s hands the way he looked at any made thing — for the function, for the *what is it for* — and then he looked at Frik.

“You found where the water goes,” he said. It wasn’t a question.

“Under the coils. The egg’s over the braid. It’s a —” Frik stopped himself. *It’s a map* sat behind his teeth. “It does something. With water. Maybe.”

Jakobus nodded slowly, like a man confirming the gauge of a wire. “Good.” Then: “Not yours to say what.”

“I know.”

“You know,” Jakobus agreed, mild. “You keep knowing it and then talking past it. That’s the part you’re working on.” He let that sit, no edge on it, the way you’d point out a man’s lace was undone. “We can read the thing. Reading’s our work — the telling, the *what’s-it-for*. But there’s a difference between reading a made thing and *closing* it. We don’t close. We’ve never closed. We find the hole and we hold the door for somebody and we leave.” He shifted his weight on the running board. “The hole here isn’t the water. The water’s an answer. The hole’s the date, and the date’s not ours, and it’s not the foundation’s either, and it sure as hell isn’t going to be solved by a brochure. Whoever closes that door”— he tipped his chin at the dark where the serpent lay —“better have more standing on this ground than a man who flew in with foam cases.”

“Mara,” said Lens.

“Mara,” Jakobus said, and that was the whole of his opinion, and he stepped back down onto the grass and was gone toward the conical mounds, where he liked to stand and not say anything, and the door rolled shut on its own weight.

The email came to Mara’s phone at 9:14, and she read it standing in her kitchen on the reservation edge with the screen door open and the moths working the porch light, and she read it three times before she set the phone face-down on the counter.

It was, the crew would learn later, very polite. The Heritage Foundation wrote polite the way some men wrote big checks — fluently, and with the expectation of being thanked.

It was a formal request for her endorsement.

Not a demand. Sandoval would have been wounded at *demand*. It was an invitation to be the *Lead Cultural Advisor* on the World Heritage Experience interpretive plan, with a stipend that was not small, and a paragraph about the importance of “an authentic Indigenous voice at the center of the narrative,” and then, three paragraphs down,

where the invitations always kept it, the condition. The interpretive plan required “a settled construction context to support the visitor experience and the nomination dossier.” Her endorsement of “the Foundation’s preferred dating framework” would “anchor the story for the world.”

They had already chosen the date. They wanted her name under it.

It was an honor extended on a leash. Her authority was real — they wouldn’t have asked otherwise, would not have flown a man across the country to court a woman who could be ignored. They respected her. They needed her. And they would respect and need her precisely up until the moment she said *maybe*, at which point the leash would go taut, because *maybe* does not fit on a sign and *maybe* does not anchor a dossier and *maybe* cannot be photographed at the entrance to a forty-million-dollar experience.

She thought about the elders who would not come up the ridge. She thought about the ones who would, and what they’d want, and how they didn’t agree, and how that disagreement was its own kind of inheritance, hers to carry and not to resolve. She thought about her own carbon dates, the ones in her own notebook, the ones that didn’t close it either, the ones she had not shown the crew or the foundation or anyone, because she did not yet know what they were *for*, and a thing you cannot read is a thing you do not hand to people who collect.

She thought: *I could sign it. I could be the authentic voice at the center. I could be the reason the sign is generous instead of cruel. That is a real good and you do not get to pretend it isn’t.*

She thought: *And then the door is closed, and I closed it, and I’m the one whose face is on it.*

She picked the phone back up.

In the morning the crew found her at the head of the trail, up by the egg, where the oval feature opened from the serpent’s jaws toward the place on the horizon where the longest day’s sun went down — that alignment being one of the few things at this whole site nobody seriously disputed, the head pointing at the solstice sunset, clean as a sightline, year after year, as physical and checkable as anything in

Ohio. You can stand there in June and watch it. The mound does not care which century built it. It points anyway.

She had her notebook closed under her arm and her coat zipped against the morning, and below them, at the gate, Sandoval's polos were already unloading the foam cases.

"I read their letter," she said, before anyone could ask. The cicadas hadn't started. The ridge was very quiet.

Frik opened his mouth. Devi looked at him. Frik closed his mouth. Lens, for once, did not raise the camera; she let it hang.

"They want me to say a number," Mara went on. "They've picked the number that sells the building. They'd let me decorate it." She looked out along the body of the serpent, the seven coils rolling down the ridge toward the spiral tail, the whole great shape sitting on the rim of a crater the earth made when something fell out of the sky longer ago than any of these arguments. "And the other side would let me decorate a different number. Everybody on this ridge for a hundred years has wanted me to decorate their number. None of them ever once asked me what the thing *does*."

She turned around. She looked at them — at Frik bouncing on his heels with three transects in his chest he was visibly not saying, at Devi standing square, at Lens with the lens down.

"I'm not signing it," she said. "And I'm not handing it to you to publish, either, before you ask — you ran my permit, that data lives where my permit lives." She said it without heat, the way you state a property line. "But I'm not letting them close it in a press release either. So." She tucked the notebook tighter under her arm. "I'm going to present it. The whole thing. The water, the sightline, what I think it's *for* — to both rooms at once. The foundation and the Nations. My terms. My ground. I'll show them the function and I will not give them the date, because the date isn't mine to give and it isn't theirs to buy."

Down at the gate a drone wound up, a high mosquito note, and lifted over the treeline toward the head of the serpent, toward the egg, toward the place where the sun would set on the longest day whether anyone signed for it or not.

Mara watched it climb. "Tell Jakobus," she said. "He'll want to be in

the back where I can't see him."

Chapter 13 — The Reading: The Land's Voice

The folding chairs were a mistake, and everybody knew it.

Sandoval's team had set them up at the head of the trail, near the overlook, two neat arcs facing a podium nobody asked for, and by six in the evening the wind off the ridge had tipped four of them onto their faces. A foundation intern kept righting them. A foundation intern kept watching them fall. There is a kind of person who will keep setting up chairs at a place that does not want chairs, and that person had a clipboard.

Mara hadn't sat in any of them. She stood at the edge of the egg-shaped feature at the serpent's mouth, where the grass was kept short and the earthwork rose maybe four feet above the mown lawn, an unimpressive swell of dirt that had been refusing to give up its secret for three thousand or one thousand years, depending on whose lab you trusted. She had a thermos. She had a USGS topographic quad folded to a square. She had, Lens noticed through the viewfinder, the patience of someone who had done this before, the explaining, and had decided in advance how much of it she would do.

"She's not going to use the podium," Lens said.

"No," Frik agreed. He was vibrating slightly, a low hum he made when there were too many people standing too close to a thing he cared about. His left hand tapped his thigh in fours. "Podium's facing the wrong way. Sun sets *there*." He pointed past the serpent's head, west-northwest, where the light was already going thick and gold over the trees. "You'd have your back to the only argument that matters."

Sandoval had come in good faith. That was the part that kept catching in Lens's chest, the part the camera kept wanting to file under *complication*. He wore a sport coat to a hilltop. He'd brought bottled water and a printed agenda — 6:00 *Welcome*, 6:15 *Findings Summary*, 6:30 *Q&A* — and he had emailed it to everyone, including two tribal liaisons who had emailed back nothing, and including Mara, who had read it and said, in a voice with no edge on it at all, *I'll talk when the light's right*.

So now there was an agenda, and there was the sun, and the sun was winning.

Here is the official story, and the foundation's brochure had it dead right, which was the trouble.

The Great Serpent Mound is over thirteen hundred feet of earthwork laid along a ridge in Adams County, a snake uncoiling toward the northwest, seven graceful bends in its body, the tail curled into a tight spiral at one end and the open oval at the other, the thing the brochures call the egg, or the eye, or the frog the serpent's about to swallow, depending on which expert with a badge you ask. It sits on the rim of an ancient crater, a place where the bedrock got punched and folded by something — a meteorite strike or a gas explosion deep in the rock, the geologists have their own gentle war about that too — six hundred million years before anyone thought to make a snake out of it. The ground here doesn't lie flat. It rolls and bucks. You feel it in your knees on the trail.

And on the longest day of the year, the serpent's head points exactly at the place on the horizon where the sun goes down.

That last one isn't folklore. Hively and Horn surveyed it in '82; Romain ran the numbers; Lepper confirmed it. You can stand on that ridge on the solstice with a compass and a clear sky and watch it happen, and people do, hundreds of them, every June. The head finds the sun. Nobody disputes the head finds the sun.

What nobody can do is tell you who built it, or when.

Sandoval, to his enormous credit, opened with the trouble instead of hiding it. He stood beside the unused podium and read from his phone, and he read it straight: that the 1996 Cincinnati cores, the

charcoal under the mound, came back around 1070 of the common era, which would make it Fort Ancient. That the older consensus, the artifacts, the shape of the thing, the company it keeps with the conical burial mounds down the slope, all said Adena, eight hundred years before Christ to a hundred after. That both camps were credentialed. Both published. Both, as of this exact evening, unresolved.

"Which is *why*," Sandoval said, and Lens watched him reach the pivot he'd clearly rehearsed in the rental car, "we believe the World Heritage Experience can finally give visitors a single, clear—"

"You can't," Frik said.

The chairs that were still upright held forty people. Schoolteachers from the county. Two farmers Mara knew by name. A woman from the visitor center gift shop who'd worked the register eleven years. The two tribal liaisons, who had not, in the end, declined; they'd just arrived without saying so, and stood at the back with their arms folded in a way that was not hostile and was not warm. And every one of them turned to look at the man who'd said the word *can't* into the wind.

"You can't give them a single clear date," Frik went on, because the engine was running now and the brake was a thing he was still learning where to find. "Cincinnati got 1070 off charcoal *under* the embankment. Good clean sample, good lab. But charcoal under a mound dates the *fire*, not the mound. Somebody could've built this on top of a campsite a thousand years old. Putnam's people pulled older stuff in the 1880s. Adena artifacts all over the slope. So the honest sentence is —" he stopped, recalibrated, said it slower — "the honest sentence is *we don't know*. You can't sell *we don't know*. I checked the brochure mockup. There's no *we don't know* in it."

Sandoval's jaw worked. He was not a bad man. He'd printed an agenda and brought water up a hill.

"That's precisely what the science is for," he said. "To close the gap."

"It hasn't, though," Frik said, helpless and exact. "That's the thing about the gap. It's still—"

"Frik." Mara hadn't raised her voice. She'd only said his name, once, the way you'd touch someone's wrist. He stopped. His hand went on tapping fours against his leg, but the words shut off.

The sun touched the treeline.

"It's the right light now," Mara said. "Come walk."

She didn't go to the head. She went the wrong way — back along the body, toward the tail, the tight seven-loop spiral coiled at the far end, and the forty people made a ragged line behind her on the trail, and Lens fell to the rear because that was where the camera lived, at the edge, watching the backs of people watching.

Mara stopped at the second coil from the head. She crouched. She put her hand flat on the grass on the *inside* of the bend, where the earthwork curled, and she looked up at the people standing over her, and she let the silence sit until it stopped being comfortable.

"You all want to know how old it is," she said. "I understand why. The age is the brochure. The age is the heritage application. The age tells you which dead people to thank." A pause. "I'm not going to give it to you. Not because I'm hiding it. Because I don't have it, and the people who tell you they have it are selling something, and I won't sell my grandmother's country by the pound."

The liaisons at the back did not move. But something in the set of their shoulders changed.

"So let me tell you what I *do* have." She tapped the topo quad against her knee. "Look at where the bends are. Don't look at the snake. Look at the *ground under* the snake."

Frik went still in a different way. Lens knew that stillness. It was the stillness of him being handed a pattern.

"The ridge here runs along a drainage," Mara said. "Springs come out of this hillside. They've always come out of this hillside; the limestone leaks. Water finds the low ground and it cuts the low ground deeper, and over time the ridge gets shaped by where the water goes." She drew with her finger on the map, not lifting her eyes to it. "Now. Every place this earthwork *bends* — every coil — sits above a place where the water turns. The body doesn't wander. It traces the drainage line along the spine of the ridge. The spiral tail sits over the head of the spring system, where it all gathers. The head points downhill to where the water *leaves*."

A farmer near the front — older, sun-cured, a man who'd clearly walked this slope his whole life — made a small sound in his throat.

"You feel it," Mara said to him, not unkindly. "You've dug for water on this ground."

"My granddad witched a well off the low side," the man said. "Right about—" he pointed, vaguely, downslope, west. "—there."

"Right about there," Mara agreed.

It was Jakobus who said the next thing, and he said it from the back, half-turned away, the way he said everything, like he wasn't sure he had standing and would rather hand it back the moment he could.

"It's a tool," he said. "Isn't it. Not a picture of a thing. A picture *for* a thing."

Mara looked at him. Of everyone on that ridge she gave him the longest look, the look you give someone who's read a made thing the way you read it, and found the same grain in the wood.

"Say more," she said. "But know I'll take it back from you in a minute."

"You build a thing this big, you don't build it to be looked at," Jakobus said, slow, choosing. "Thirteen hundred feet. You can't even see the whole shape from the ground. You can't see it without going up — and there *was* no up, no airplane, in 1070 or 800 BCE either way. So it's not a picture for eyes. It's a picture for *feet*. You walk it. You walk the coils, you're walking the water. You walk the head, you're facing where the sun dies on the longest day, which is the same direction the water leaves. Somebody could learn this whole ridge — every spring, every season, the longest day — just by being made to walk a snake as a child." He stopped. Found the edge of himself. "That's as far as I go. I don't know what they *called* it. That's not mine to know."

"No," Mara said. "It isn't."

She stood up. Her knees cracked and she didn't pretend they hadn't.

"He's close," she told the crowd. "He's a builder, he reads it like a builder, and builders see true. But he stops where he should stop, and that's the part I want you to take home." She turned the map

over in her hands. "It's a map of water, yes. It's an almanac, the head finds the solstice, yes, you can check that yourself in June with your own two eyes and you should. It teaches the land to anyone who walks it. All of that is *function*, and function I'll give you, because function is checkable and the land is generous with it."

She let that land. Then her voice changed — not louder, lower.

"But it is also a *being*, on a wound in the earth, where the rock was broken open before anything alive crawled here. My people, some of my people, the ones who'll talk to me and the ones who won't come up this hill at all, they don't think you put a serpent on a scar by accident. That part isn't function. That part isn't yours, and it isn't the brochure's, and you can apply for World Heritage every year until the sun burns out and you still won't be able to print it on a sign." She folded the map closed. "I'll tell you what it *does*. I will not tell you what it *means*. The day I let someone pay me for what it means is the day this stops being country and starts being merchandise."

The sun went down behind the serpent's head while she was talking, and nobody had planned it, and it shut everyone up the way it was probably built to.

For a moment the coils threw long shadows across the mown grass, the body of the thing suddenly dimensional, rising out of the flat, and Lens lifted the camera and then — slowly, deliberately, the way she was learning to — lowered it again. There were some frames you didn't take. There were some frames that belonged to the people standing in them, and to the spring under their feet, and to whoever had decided three thousand or one thousand years ago that the longest day deserved a snake's head pointed at it.

Frik had his phone out. He was recording the water claim, the bends, the alignment, GPS-tagging the coils against the drainage on the quad — documenting, which was theirs to do, getting the checkable thing checkable. He was not interpreting. For once in his life the words that wanted out were *but the age, but the carbon, but the Cincinnati cores* and he held them in his teeth, because Mara had already said the only true sentence about the age, which was that nobody had one, and saying it again would only be saying it to hear himself.

It cost him. You could see it cost him.

Sandoval stood by his upended chairs in the blue dusk and you could watch the certainty go out of him, not all at once, the way you'd watch air leave a man, leave room behind it for something he hadn't budgeted for.

"The application," he said, finally, quietly, to Mara, not to the crowd. "It requires a statement of — significance. A narrative."

"It requires the *truth*," Mara said. "The truth has a hole in it. You can write the hole. You can write *the age is genuinely unresolved, here are both peer-reviewed cases, here is what you can verify with your own compass on the solstice, and here is the function the custodian is willing to share*. You can put my name on what's mine and you can leave the rest *open*." She almost smiled. "People will come further for a real question than a fake answer. I've never once met a person who got on a plane to see a thing that was solved."

Sandoval was quiet a long time.

"I'd need that in writing," he said. "The — open part. So it survives the committee."

"You'll have it in writing," Mara said. "In my words. Frik will fact-check the citations, because he can't help it, and the man's never been wrong about a footnote in his life." Frik made a noise that was almost a laugh and almost a tic. "And the *meaning* stays where it's always been. Up here. With the water. With the people who don't come up the hill."

The interns started folding the chairs. The farmers drifted down the trail in twos. One of the liaisons at the back caught Mara's eye and gave her one short nod, and that nod was worth more than the agenda, the podium, the bottled water, and the entire heritage application stacked end to end, and everyone who saw it knew it.

The serpent lay in the dark, holding its longest-day secret and its scar and its hidden water, telling the people who walked it exactly what it did and not one word about what it was for.

Which, of course, is the next thing.

Chapter 14 — The Standoff: Authority and Ambiguity

Lens had photographed three ceasefires and a hostage release, and she knew the particular stillness of a room where everyone has agreed, for now, not to do the violent thing they came to do. The visitor center conference room had it. Folding tables pushed into a rectangle. A whiteboard scarred by previous meetings. The hum of a soda machine through the wall, and beyond that, faint, the cicadas working the ridge like a saw that never finished its cut.

She kept the camera at her hip. Lowered. She had promised herself that, here. But her thumb found the wake button on its own, the way a smoker's hand finds a pocket.

Sandoval sat at the head of the table with a laptop and a printed deck, and he was, she had to give him this, not a cartoon. He had taken his polo's collar between two fingers and worried it soft. The deck's cover slide said THE SERPENT'S STORY: A WORLD HERITAGE EXPERIENCE in a font chosen to feel ancient and to cost nothing in licensing.

"I want to be careful here," Sandoval said, "because I respect Dr. Tallchief enormously."

Across the table, Mara Tallchief did not move. She had a way of being still that wasn't waiting. Lens had clocked it the first day — the stillness of someone who had already done the looking and was now simply present for whatever you needed to catch up on. Her field bag sat at her feet, the core-sample log poking from the top flap, dog-eared to the page where the numbers refused to agree.

“The application reviewers,” Sandoval went on, “they’re not unsympathetic to nuance. But UNESCO wants a nomination dossier with a *statement of value*. A clear one. And the donor committee — they’ve seen the dossier. They’ve seen the line that says, and I’m quoting our own draft, *the construction date remains a subject of active scholarly debate*.” He let that sit. “Two of them asked me, very kindly, what exactly we’re asking the public to come and feel.”

“Wonder,” said the woman to his left. Petersen, from Development. Linen blazer, reading glasses pushed up into her hair. “They’d come to feel wonder. I keep saying it.”

“Wonder doesn’t anchor a forty-minute orientation film, Diane.”

“It’s anchored the place for two thousand years.”

“Or for nine hundred and fifty.” Sandoval almost smiled. “Which is the entire problem.”

That was the moment Lens lifted the camera. Just to the rib. Just to look through it, the old reflex of finding the frame to understand the room. Through the viewfinder the table flattened, and she could see it clean: two factions inside one polo-shirted body of people, and the seam between them running right down the middle of the rectangle.

On Sandoval’s side, the certainty people. They wanted the dossier to say something. They had a visitor experience to fill, a gift shop to stock, a film to score. You cannot put a maybe on a brochure. A maybe does not anchor a forty-minute orientation film.

On Petersen’s side, fewer of them, the ones who’d come up the ridge at dusk and felt the thing the ridge did at dusk.

Frik sat against the wall, not at the table, which was where he preferred to be in rooms like this — out of the throw of it, where he could see all the faces at once. His knee was going. His jaw worked. Lens had learned to read the build in him the way you read weather, the pressure dropping before it broke. He had a notebook open on his knee and he was, with great effort, writing instead of speaking. The pen pressed hard enough to gloss the paper.

“Let me lay out where we are,” Sandoval said, and clicked to a slide that was just a number line. “Best science. 1996, University of Cincinnati. Lepper and colleagues pull charcoal from beneath the effigy

itself — from *under* the built-up earth, which is the part that matters, because charcoal under the mound has to predate the mound.” He looked around to be sure they followed. “Radiocarbon comes back circa 1070 of the Common Era. Plus or minus seventy years. That’s Fort Ancient. That’s a culture we can name, place, narrate. That’s a date with a face.”

“It’s one set of samples,” said Mara.

“It’s the best-controlled set.”

“It’s the best-controlled set from one excavation.” She hadn’t raised her voice. She never did. “There are older dates in the record. Putnam’s people in the eighteen-eighties, and the re-analyses since. Materials from the site consistent with Adena. Eight hundred before the Common Era to a hundred after. That’s not a footnote, Eric. That’s a thousand-year argument with credentialed, published people standing on both ends of it, and not one of them is a crank.”

“And the older material could be earlier *use* of the site. Earlier occupation. Not the mound.”

“Could be,” Mara agreed, and Lens watched Sandoval’s face do something complicated, because Mara had just conceded his point and somehow taken ground doing it. “Could be that people lived here, used this ridge, long before anyone heaped the serpent. Could be the serpent’s a Fort Ancient idea built on an Adena floor. Could be the charcoal under the mound is from a fire someone lit a thousand years before anyone thought of a snake.” She let it breathe. “That’s what *could be* looks like when you’re honest about it. It looks like more than one thing.”

Petersen had stopped taking notes.

Sandoval pinched the bridge of his nose. “Mara. I am on your side. I want you to know that. I have fought for your name on the interpretive board. I want your reading in the orientation film. But I cannot walk into the donor review and present them a forty-million-dollar capital campaign whose central artifact has no agreed-upon age and no agreed-upon builder.”

“Then don’t agree on one.”

The soda machine cycled. Somewhere down the hall a school group

laughed, the bright ragged sound of nine-year-olds let loose near a gift shop.

“What does that even mean,” said the man at the far end. Lens didn’t have his name. Acquisitions, probably. Younger, hungrier, no dust on his boots. “We’re going to build a world-class facility and the main exhibit is going to *shrug?*”

“The main exhibit,” Mara said, “is on the ridge. You don’t get to build that one. It’s thirteen hundred feet long and it’s been there longer than anyone in this room can prove. The facility is just the part with the bathrooms.”

Frik made a sound. Not a word. A short, sharp exhalation through the nose, the kind that escaped him when something true landed and the rest of the body wanted to applaud and couldn’t. He pressed the pen harder.

Lens watched him through the camera and willed him, the way she sometimes willed soldiers not to move, *not yet, not yet, stay down, hold.*

“Here’s the operational question,” said the younger man, turning a pen end over end. “We have a survey window. We have ground-penetrating radar runs scheduled. We have the Tallchief team and —” a glance at Lens and Frik, the documentary nobodies, the van people — “their associates, on site under a temporary access agreement that the Foundation administers. If the science is going to be *open-ended*” — he said it like a flavor he didn’t care for — “then I have to ask what we’re paying access for. We could close the window. Reset. Bring in a team that’ll give us a clean read and a date we can write down.”

There it was. Lens had been waiting for the room to say it and the room had finally said it. *We could close the window.* They could bar them. The access agreement was a piece of paper and the paper was theirs.

“A clean read,” Mara said.

“A defensible one.”

“You’ll get a clean read.” Mara reached down to her bag and drew out the core log and set it on the table without opening it, just laid

her hand flat on the cover. “Same as I got. The radar will give you returns and the returns will be real and they’ll show you the layering, the disturbance, the prior excavations cut back through everything. The carbon will give you numbers and the numbers will be real. And you’ll stand in front of your donors and you’ll have to decide which real thing to write on the wall, because the real things don’t all say the same year. That’s not me being difficult. That’s the *site*.” Her voice didn’t rise even here. “I didn’t make the mound refuse you. I’m just the one telling you it’s refusing.”

Lens lowered the camera and looked at it plainly, with her own eyes, the way she was learning to: Mara’s hand on the log. The numbers under the hand. The thousand-year argument folded shut inside a manila cover, and a Native archaeologist keeping her palm on it like a lid, like a thing that would get up and walk the room if she let it.

This was the part nobody filmed because there was nothing to film. A still hand on a closed folder. And it was the whole story.

“There’s a version,” Petersen said carefully, “where the not-knowing is the draw.”

Sandoval looked at her.

“Hear me out. People don’t drive two hours into Adams County for a date. They drive for the *feeling*. They walk the overlook trail at dusk and the coils throw shadow and the whole ridge does the thing it does, and the horizon bends, and they feel watched. By the *land*. You can’t manufacture that. We’ve spent careers trying to manufacture that. And here it is, free, on a crater, and the wildest part of it is that the smartest people in the country have looked at it for a hundred and forty years and can’t agree how old it is.” She spread her hands. “What if the wall doesn’t say a date? What if the wall says: *here is the argument. Here are both sides. Both have evidence. Both have gaps. Stand on the ridge at solstice and decide what you believe.* What if we sell the maybe?”

The younger man laughed, not unkindly. “Donors don’t fund maybes.”

“Donors fund what people line up for. And people line up for mysteries that are still warm.”

Sandoval was very quiet. Lens watched the seam in him. He was, she thought, a man who had gotten into this work because of a feeling

on a ridge somewhere a long time ago, and had spent twenty years learning to convert feelings into dossiers, and had perhaps forgotten which direction the conversion was supposed to run.

“I want to be honest with the room,” he said at last. “If we present this as unresolved, the nomination gets harder. Reviewers like resolved. The campaign gets harder. Donors like resolved.” He turned the printed deck face down, a small private surrender. “But I’m not sure resolved is *true*. And I find I mind that more than I expected to.”

“Then the question on the table,” the younger man said, sharpening, “is whether the Foundation proceeds with acquisition under a custodial agreement that lets Dr. Tallchief decline to fix a date. Whether we let the central interpretive authority sit with someone who has told us, on the record, that she won’t settle it.” He spread his hands at Sandoval. “That’s a real risk. We hand her the keys and she keeps the door open forever. The story never closes. There’s no Day One narrative. We’re asking the board to fund a mystery and put a woman in charge of *keeping* it one.”

He wasn’t wrong. That was the worst of it, Lens thought. He wasn’t a villain and he wasn’t wrong. From inside a forty-million-dollar capital campaign, a woman who will not let you write the year on the wall is, precisely, a risk.

And from up on the ridge, at dusk, with the head of the serpent pointed at the exact place on the horizon where the longest day’s sun goes down — confirmed, measured, you could check it yourself, Hively and Horn had stood up there in ’eighty-two and run the numbers — that same woman was the only person in the building telling the truth about what they didn’t know.

Frik’s pen had stopped.

Lens felt it before she saw it, the pressure breaking, the room about to get the fact it had been circling. She knew exactly what he had. He had the thing about the charcoal — that even the good 1070 date told you when something *burned* under the mound, not when the serpent was *built*, that a date under a mound is a floor and not a clock, that the cleanest number in the whole fight was itself a kind of maybe wearing a lab coat. It was true and it was load-bearing and it would land in this room like a chair through a window. It would prove the younger man’s worst point — see, *even your friends say it can’t be*

closed — or it would prove Petersen's best one. There was no telling which.

His jaw worked. His knee stilled. Everyone at the table had felt the change in the wall-sitter and turned, the way you turn toward a kettle.

"Mr. —" Sandoval started, half-rising to the obligation of a courtesy. "Did you want to — your team must have a view —"

And Lens, who had spent a career trusting that the next frame would explain the last one, watched Frik open his mouth.

And close it.

He looked at Mara. At her hand, flat on the folder. At the lid she was keeping on the thing that wanted to walk the room. And whatever he had — the chair, the window — he set it down. He shook his head, once, a small motion, almost gentle. He looked back down at his notebook and pressed the pen to it.

The silence held. It was Mara's silence. He had handed it to her, whole.

Lens did not raise the camera. There was nothing in the frame and everything in the room, and for once she let the difference be the picture. The soda machine cycled. Down the hall the school group's laughter rose and faded toward the doors, toward the trail, toward the ridge where the coils were already starting, in the long afternoon light, to throw the first faint shadow of the evening that would line them all up with the sun.

Sandoval looked at the overturned deck. He looked at his hands.

"Let's recess," he said. "Twenty minutes. I need to make a call."

Nobody moved to gather their things. The risk and the wonder sat on the table between them, the same shape, the same weight, and nobody yet could tell which one they were holding.

Chapter 15 — The Compromise: Shared Stewardship

The trailer the foundation had hauled up onto the gravel lot smelled of new carpet and machine-cooled air, which was its own kind of trespass against a ridge that smelled of warm grass and cicada husks. Jakobus stood in the doorway because the doorway was where a man could see both rooms — the conference table inside, the parking lot outside, the green shoulder of the mound beyond the visitor center where the coils held their shape against the light. He had learned long ago that the best place to read a negotiation was the seam between the people doing it and the thing they were arguing about. You watched the table. Then you watched the object. The object never lied, which was more than you could say for the table.

Eric Sandoval had laid out a printed deck. He had laid out, beside it, a tray of pastries from a chain bakery in West Union, which Jakobus respected as a gesture and distrusted as a tactic, the way he distrusted any pastry that traveled. Sandoval wore the polo. He always wore the polo. Today it was the navy one, the one with the foundation's logo small over the heart — a stylized spiral that some designer in an office had decided was the serpent, flattened into a brand mark you could embroider. Jakobus had noticed the logo on day one and said nothing. Frik had noticed it on day one and said, loudly, that it looked like a fern, and nobody had corrected him because nobody could.

Mara Tallchief sat across from Sandoval with a legal pad and a travel

mug and the particular stillness of someone who had been in this kind of room before and had not enjoyed it then either. She had come from the survey. There was crater clay drying pale on the cuff of her jeans. She had not changed for the meeting. Jakobus filed that away too: a person who does not dress for a negotiation has decided in advance how much the negotiation is allowed to move her.

“I want to be clear that we’re not here to flatten anything,” Sandoval said. He said it the way you say a thing you have been advised to say. “The board’s concern — and it’s a legitimate concern — is the visitor experience. People drive four hours. They walk the trail. They get to the overlook, and they want to know what they’re looking at. And right now the panels can’t tell them.”

“The panels tell them it’s a serpent thirteen hundred feet long on the rim of a meteorite crater,” Mara said. “That seems like a lot to be going on with.”

“They want a date, Mara.”

“I know what they want.”

Sandoval pulled up a slide. It was, Jakobus would have to admit, an honest slide. Two columns. ADENA, it said on the left. FORT ANCIENT on the right. Under Adena: the artifact assemblage, the mound morphology, the older charcoal, the 320 BCE figure with its long polite tail of error bars. Under Fort Ancient: the 1996 cores from beneath the mound, Lepper and the Cincinnati team, the charcoal that came back at roughly 1070 of the common era, give or take seventy years. Two columns. Two careers’ worth of careful people on each side of a line that would not hold still.

“This is what we’d have to put on a panel,” Sandoval said. “Two answers. A visitor reads that and feels like nobody did their job.”

“A visitor reads that,” Mara said, “and learns something true about how knowledge works.”

Frik was over by the window, not sitting, because chairs in trailers were a thing his body declined. He had a survey printout rolled in one fist and he was rolling it tighter, and Jakobus watched the tic come up through him the way you watch a fish break the surface — you see it coming a half-second before, a tightening, a gather.

“The charcoal’s under the mound,” Frik said. The words came out fast and flat and slightly too loud for the room, which is how all of Frik’s true things came out. “Beneath. Lepper’s samples. So either somebody built the serpent in eleven hundred — *eleven hundred*, sorry — over a fire that somebody else lit a thousand years before, or they built it in eleven hundred and the charcoal dates the build. And the older stuff from Putnam’s dig might be people *using* the place before anyone piled up the snake. Both true. Both *real*. That’s the whole problem. Nobody’s lying. The hole’s still open. Hole’s *open*.” He breathed. “Sorry.”

Nobody told him not to be sorry, because by now everyone in the chase had learned that the sorry was just punctuation, not penance, and that the sentence in front of it was usually the truest thing said all day.

Sandoval rubbed the bridge of his nose. He was not a bad man. Jakobus had decided this in the first week and had seen nothing to revise it. He was a man who had been handed a problem — celebrate a place, preserve a place, fund the preservation by celebrating it — and who could not see that the two halves of his job were pulling against each other like the two columns on his slide.

“If I take ‘we don’t know’ to the board,” Sandoval said, “I lose the World Heritage timeline. You understand that. The dossier wants a coherent significance statement. ‘It might be one of two cultures separated by a thousand years’ does not read as coherent.”

“It reads as honest.” Mara set down her mug. “Eric. Listen to me. The dating isn’t the significance. You’ve had it backwards the whole time, and I don’t blame you for it, because the brochure people always have it backwards. You think the wonder is the answer. The wonder is the *question that’s good enough to still be open after a hundred and forty years of smart people digging*.”

Jakobus, in the doorway, kept his face the way he kept it: a closed gate with the latch oiled. But something moved in him at that, the small private satisfaction of a man watching the right person take hold of the right end of the rope. He had read the mound himself, three nights ago, on his knees in the wet grass with Lens’s headlamp and a roll of butcher paper, tracing how the coils came down the ridge. He had read it the only way he knew how to read a made thing

— *what is it for* — and he had found his answer in the way the bends of the serpent shadowed the way the water went, the springs and the seeps the band had walked, the seven coils riding the high ground above the wet ground like a hand laid along the back of the land's own drainage. He had been fairly sure of it. He was a man who got fairly sure and then shut his mouth, because the function was a thing you could check, and the meaning was not his to hold.

He had told the crew. He had not told Mara, because Mara already knew, and had known before any of them came up the road in the van, and the thing Jakobus had learned across a working life of reading other people's ground was that the deepest courtesy you could pay a custodian was to arrive at her answer a half-step behind her and let her see you arrive.

She knew the water. She'd grown up forty minutes from this ridge. She had walked these seeps as a child with an auntie who called the low ground by names that weren't on any USGS quad. When Frik had blurted, two days back, *the coils track the high ground over the springs, that's a map, that's a water map* — when he'd blurted it standing on the overlook with his arms going — Mara had only nodded, slow, and said, yes, and then said nothing else, and Frik for once in his life had not filled the silence. That was the moment the chapter had actually turned, Jakobus thought. Not this trailer. The overlook. The yes. Everything in here now was just the paperwork catching up to the land.

"Here's what I can offer," Mara said, and slid her legal pad around so Sandoval could read her block capitals upside down. "And it's the only thing I'll sign."

Jakobus watched Sandoval read.

"The panels foreground the not-knowing," Mara said as he read it. "Not as a footnote. As the *headline*. 'How old is the Serpent Mound? Two of the best-supported answers are a thousand years apart, and the dispute is still alive.' You put the two columns up. You put up the solstice — the *real* one, the head pointing dead at where the sun goes down on the longest day, the alignment Hively and Horn measured, the one a person can stand at this overlook on the twenty-first of June and watch happen with their own two eyes. You put up that the lunar claims are debated and you say *debated*. And the interpretive

authority — the final word on what goes on the panels about whose place this is and what it means to the Nations — that's mine. Or whoever holds my seat after me. In writing. Not advisory. *Authority.*"

"The board will want—"

"The board can want." She let it sit. "You came here to settle the story, Eric. I'm offering you a story that can't be settled and telling you that's the better one. People don't drive four hours for an answer they could've Googled in the parking lot. They drive four hours to stand somewhere the answer hasn't arrived yet. You've got one of maybe a dozen places on the continent that can still do that to a person. Don't pave it."

Outside, a school group was coming up the overlook trail in the heat, a teacher counting heads, a kid trailing the line with his eyes already up at the coils, not listening to the count. Jakobus watched the kid stop at the rail. He watched the kid go still the way kids go still when a thing is bigger than the words they have for it.

Lens was out there too, twenty feet from the trailer, camera down at her hip the way she carried it now, after everything, lowered, the lens looking at nobody. She had not raised it in this meeting. She had asked Mara, the first morning, whether she could shoot inside, and Mara had said *the survey, yes, the negotiation, no*, and Lens had nodded like a woman handed a gift she hadn't dared ask for — the gift of not having to be the one who sees everything. She stood now in the parking lot looking at the school group looking at the snake, and her camera stayed down, and that was its own kind of finished documentation, Jakobus thought. The proof that someone had learned to let the frame belong to the person inside it.

Sandoval was quiet a long time. To his credit — and Jakobus gave him the credit, fully, the way you give a man his due when he earns it slow — he was not stalling. He was thinking. You could see the two columns in his head finally stop fighting and start standing side by side.

"The legal team will hate the word *authority*," he said.

"Good," said Mara. "Then they'll write it carefully."

"And the crew?" Sandoval looked over at the doorway, at Jakobus, at Frik gone quiet by the window. "Your people. The documentary. The

book.”

“They finish their work,” Mara said. “They’ve got till the end of the week on the ground. They photograph the survey. They write what I clear and not a line more.” She glanced at Frik when she said it, and there was something almost like fondness in it, the fondness you develop for a thing that won’t stop telling you the truth even when the truth costs everybody. “I trust them to know the difference between telling and taking. They’ve learned it. Some of them learned it the hard way.”

Frik’s mouth opened. Jakobus saw the fact rise in him — could see it, almost, the shape of it, the *but actually the 1070 date specifically refers to* something, the compulsion to correct the record one more time in a room that had finally stopped needing it corrected. He saw Frik’s jaw work. He saw the printout crush smaller in his fist.

And then he saw Frik shut his mouth.

It was the smallest thing. It was the largest thing. The fact went back down. Frik let it go down. He looked out the window at the kid at the rail instead, and the tic moved through his shoulder and dispersed into nothing, spent on no one. Jakobus had been on a great many jobs with a great many clever people and he could count on the fingers of one scarred hand the number of times he had watched someone choose silence and have it be the truest thing they said all day. He added Frik to the count.

They shook on it. Sandoval first, reaching, and Mara took the hand and held it firm and brief, and the two columns on the screen went dark when the laptop slept, which Jakobus felt was about right — the answer going dark, the question still lit by the window.

The meeting broke. Sandoval went to call his board. Frik went out to find Lens and tell her, no doubt at volume, what had just happened, his hands already going. The school group filed back down the trail and the parking lot emptied of the count of children and the place got quiet again the way it got quiet around five o’clock, the cicadas taking over the work the people had set down.

Jakobus did not follow the crew. He had a thing to do that did not require an audience, which is how he did most things.

He went out and crossed the gravel to where Mara stood at the edge

of the lot looking up at the head of the serpent, at the oval the old reports called the egg, at the long throw of the body unwinding back into the trees. He had his field notebook in his jacket pocket — the small one, the waterproof one, the one with the butcher-paper tracing folded into the back and three nights of pencil in it, the spring locations, the seep lines, the way the coils held the high ground over the wet. The water map, if that was what it was. The thing he was fairly sure of and would not say.

He did not say it now. He took the notebook out and held it a moment in his weathered hand, feeling the give of the worn cover, the way you feel a tool before you set it down for the last time.

Then he held it out to her.

“For your archive,” Jakobus said. “If you want them.”

Mara looked at the notebook. She did not take it right away. She looked at him, and Jakobus let her look, let her read him the way she read the land — for function, for what a thing was for — and he kept his face the oiled gate and let her decide.

She took it. She turned it once in her hands and did not open it, because the opening was hers to do later, alone, on her own ground, in her own time, which was the only place the reading would mean anything.

“You walked the seeps,” she said. Not a question.

“I walked them.”

“And you didn’t say.”

“Wasn’t mine to say.” He looked up at the coils. The light was going long and amber and the shadow had started its slow business of pooling in the bends of the serpent the way it did every evening, the way it had done every evening for a thousand years, or two thousand, or however many — the count nobody had closed and now, by signed agreement, nobody would. “It’s yours. Always was.”

She nodded once. She put the notebook in her jacket, against her own heart, where the foundation’s little fern of a logo would have sat if she’d ever in her life worn the polo.

Jakobus turned to go find the road, the way he always found the road,

before anybody could thank him properly. Behind him the head of the serpent held its old appointment with the western horizon, waiting on the longest day, which was coming, and which a person could stand right here and watch — and the question of what it was for stayed open in the cooling air like a door somebody had been kind enough to leave unlatched.

Chapter 16 — The Departure: Leaving the Ridge

The van had a way of telling you it wasn't ready. It idled in the gravel lot below the overlook with a hitch in its breathing, a little catch every fourth or fifth rotation that Frik had learned not to mention because nobody could do anything about it and saying so just made Lens grip the wheel harder. So he didn't say it. He stood with the side door open and a milk crate of cable in his arms and counted the catches anyway. Four. Then five. Then four again. The cicadas were louder than the engine. They always were, up here, a wall of sound that started in the trees and got into your back teeth.

"That's the last of the GPR rig," Frik said, because that one was safe. "Battery's dead. The spare's dead. Everything we own is dead."

"Welcome to fieldwork." Lens didn't look up from the camera in her lap. She was cleaning the sensor with a little blower bulb, a thing she did with a tenderness she'd never once shown a human being, and Frik had stopped finding that strange. The camera had been to more wars than most armies. It earned the gentleness.

He set the crate inside, on top of the core boxes they were not, in the end, taking with them. Those belonged to Mara. Half-meter cylinders of compressed time, banded light and dark, charcoal flecks suspended like punctuation in a sentence nobody could agree how to read. He'd held one up to the window light two days ago and announced — to a tent full of people who did not want to hear it — that the dark band three centimeters down could be 320 BCE and could

be 1070 CE and the only honest thing to write on the label was yes. Somebody from the foundation had laughed, the wrong kind of laugh, the kind that wanted him to be joking.

He had not been joking. He was almost never joking. That was the problem with him, people said, though they said it more politely.

Up on the ridge the light was going gold and then the gold was going long, and Mara Tallchief was walking the spine of the serpent alone.

You weren't supposed to walk on it. There were signs. There was a fence of low cable, knee-height, the kind that meant *please* rather than *no*. She stepped over it where the path of the head ran out toward the bluff, and nobody from the visitor center said anything, because she was the one person on this entire ridge who had the standing to step over that cable, and everybody knew it, and the foundation people knew it most of all.

Frik watched her from the lot. He had good distance vision — too good, his mother used to say, like it was a flaw, like the world was something you were supposed to politely blur. Mara stood at the oval at the head, the egg, the thing the serpent held in its open jaws, and she looked west.

The official story, which Frik had now heard recited approximately forty times in eleven days, in tones ranging from awe to brochure-copy, went like this: the head points to where the sun sets on the longest day of the year. Not approximately. Not *roughly aligned, as many ancient monuments are said to be*. Hively and Horn surveyed it in 1982. Romain ran the numbers in '91. The summer-solstice sun drops down onto that horizon point and the serpent's open mouth holds it. You could go check. People did. They came up the ridge on the twentieth of June with folding chairs and their phones held up and the whole thing happened on schedule the way it had happened for somewhere between nine hundred and twenty-three hundred years, depending on whose charcoal you believed.

That was the part you could close. That was the part that behaved.

Everything else was a potato.

“They’re packing the drones,” said Devi.

Devi was the third of them this trip — systems analyst, autistic, the steadiest hands and the worst small talk Frik had ever been grateful for. She was sitting on the van’s rear bumper with her tablet, watching the foundation’s tents come down across the lot, narrating it the way she narrated everything, flat and complete.

“Two surveyors. One folding the big tent, one with the drone cases. Sandoval’s on the phone again.” She tilted her head. “He’s been on the phone for forty minutes. Same posture the whole time. He hasn’t moved his feet.”

Eric Sandoval stood at the edge of his dwindling camp in a polo the color of a clear sky, one hand pressing the phone to his ear and the other on his hip, and even from here you could see he was being reasonable at someone. He was always being reasonable. That was the thing about him Frik had not expected and could not file. He’d come up here ready to hate a man, and instead he’d gotten a man who shook everyone’s hand and remembered everyone’s name and genuinely, demonstrably, loved this place — loved it the way you love a thing you want to *give* to people, which is real love, even when it’s the kind that paves a parking lot over the giving.

He had wanted one date. One culture. One sentence the visitor could read on the placard and carry home: *Built by the [blank] people in [blank], the Great Serpent Mound is—*

And the mound would not give him the blank.

Lepper’s team pulled charcoal from under it in ’96 and got 1070, plus or minus seventy, and that put it with the Fort Ancient people, and that was good science, careful science, published science. And the artifacts and the shape and a century of consensus said Adena, said 300 BCE, said something a thousand years older. And the older radiocarbon from the old digs muddied even that, because charcoal under a mound could be the mound or could be a campfire somebody made on that ridge before the mound was a thought in anyone’s head.

Two camps. Both credentialed. Both published. Both holding their best cards. And the ridge, the actual ridge, the actual coiled body of packed earth fourteen hundred feet long under the actual going light, said nothing, because it had no obligation to say anything, because

it had been built to *do* something and not to *tell* you something, and those are different jobs.

That was the part nobody up here said out loud except Frik, who said it constantly, who had said it to Sandoval's face on day six.

You want it to talk. It doesn't talk. It works.

He went up.

Not onto the mound — he stayed below the cable, on the overlook path, his hands jammed in his pockets so they'd stop doing the thing they did. The fish in his head, the one he'd named years ago because naming it helped, was quiet for once, just a slow flick at the edge of him. He came up the path until he was near enough to talk to Mara without raising his voice, and then he stopped, because she had not invited him, and the difference between near enough and too close was a thing he'd spent his whole life getting wrong and was finally, slowly, sometimes, getting right.

She didn't turn around. She knew it was him. Everybody knew his footsteps; he walked like a man counting them.

"Going?" she said.

"Van's dead. We're going anyway. Lens'll push it down the hill if she has to." He looked past her, out at the coils running away to the south, seven of them, the body folding back on itself in great smooth curves and then tightening into the spiral of the tail, all of it catching the low light along one edge so the whole serpent looked, for a moment, like it was lifting. The shadow of the western trees was crawling across the eastern half of the body. You could watch it move. The thing seemed to flex.

"You found your water," he said.

Because that was what she'd shown them, in the end, on the last morning — shown, not told, taken them off the ridge and down into the lowlands and made them walk the springs. The coils, she'd said, when they were standing in cold mud with the river loud below. Where they swing. Where they tighten. She'd put their hands on the ground over a seep none of them had known was there until she pointed, and the water had been there, exactly there, where the body of the

serpent turned above them on the bluff like a finger laid along a line. Not every coil. She'd been careful about that, careful as a surgeon, never claiming the whole thing, never letting Frik's hunger for a clean answer drag her past what the ground would actually hold.

Some of these, she'd said. Some of these read the water. I'm not going to tell you all of them do. I'm not going to tell you that's all it is.

A map you could walk on. A horizon marker that held the sun. A thing that *did* jobs, that maybe did more jobs than the two she'd let them see, and she had let them see two, and kept the rest, and that keeping was hers to do.

"I found some water," Mara said now, correcting him, the way she'd corrected him gently for eleven days, never once making him feel stupid for needing the correction. "You keep wanting me to say I found *the answer*. There's water under part of it. There's a sun in its mouth one day a year. Those are two true things. You can write those down."

"And the rest."

"The rest is mine."

She said it without heat. She said it the way you'd state the weather. The rest is mine, and the way she said it closed a door so quietly you almost didn't hear the latch, and Frik, who had kicked down more doors than he could count, who had built an entire reputation on never letting a closed door stand, felt the latch go and let it.

Below them the foundation's last tent folded down with a sound like a sail giving up. Sandoval had gotten off the phone. He stood looking up at the ridge — at Mara, specifically, a small distant figure on the head of the serpent with the dying light behind her — and even at this distance Frik could read the change in him. He had come to settle the story. He was leaving with a stewardship agreement and an open question and a placard that would now have to say, against every instinct of every brochure ever printed, the word *unresolved*.

It would say: *the age of the mound remains the subject of ongoing scientific debate*. It would have to. Mara had made it have to. That

was a kind of winning Frikk had not known existed before this ridge — not beating a man, but leaving him changed, leaving him standing in a cleared field looking up at a thing he'd wanted to own and now only got to keep.

"He's not so bad," Frikk said, surprising himself.

"No." Mara watched the tent come down too. "He's not. That's the dangerous kind." But she said it kindly, almost fondly, the way you'd say it about weather you respected.

There was a thing Frikk knew.

He'd found it the night before, late, alone with the core boxes and the GPR returns and a calculator and the particular kind of focus that came down on him sometimes like a hood over a falcon, narrowing the whole world to one bright bead. A correspondence. Between two of the coils she had *not* shown them — the third and the fifth — and two seeps he'd marked on the GPR from the bluff face, deep ones, faint ones, the kind you'd never find by walking because they never reached the surface. The curve of the third coil. The angle of the fifth. They sat over the water the way the ones she'd shown them sat over theirs. The same hand. The same reading. More of the map than she'd given them.

It was a real thing. He'd checked it twice and then a third time because checking was how his hands stayed still. It would have closed a little more of the question. It would have been, in the literal sense, *the truth*, and the truth was the one thing in his life he had never once been able to keep behind his teeth. It came out of him like blood from a cut. It had cost him jobs, friends, two relationships, an entire family Christmas. *Compulsive*, the doctors wrote. He didn't lie. He couldn't. The fish would not let him.

Mara was watching the light go down on the body of the serpent she had spent her life and her name and her standing keeping whole. The rest is mine. She didn't know what he'd found. She didn't need to know he'd found it. The placard would say *unresolved* and the mound would keep its third and fifth coils to itself, would keep doing its jobs in the ground the way it had done them for whatever number of centuries it pleased, and the not-knowing would stay where she

had decided to keep it, which was on her side of the latch.

Frik opened his mouth.

The cicadas filled it. The fish flicked, hard, the truth right there, the two coils and the two seeps and the same hand, *say it, say it, you always say it.*

“It’s a good ridge,” is what he said.

Mara turned and looked at him then, the first time since he’d come up. Something moved across her face that he didn’t have a name for and didn’t try to caption, because he’d learned that too, finally, up here — that some things you let stand without saying what they mean.

“Yeah,” she said. “It is.”

He went back down the path counting his steps, and the third coil and the fifth coil stayed buried in him, the first fact in his whole life he had ever swallowed whole, sitting heavy and good in his chest like a stone you keep because someone you respect put it in your hand.

The van caught on the fourth try. Lens swung them out onto the back road with the ridge going dark in the mirror, the serpent’s head still faintly bright where it held its piece of the falling sun, and nobody said anything for a long mile, which was, for them, a kind of grace.

What’s it for, Jakobus would have asked, if Jakobus were still here, which he wasn’t — he’d handed it off days ago and gone wherever the road took him next. A water map. A sun-catcher. A thing that worked, that worked still, in the ground under a fence that said *please*.

And the rest of it — how old, by whose hands, for whom, and what those two unshown coils were reading down there in the dark — the rest of it was hers.

They drove down off the crater rim into the river lowlands, and the not-knowing came with them, and the door stayed open behind, exactly as wide as she had decided to leave it.

Chapter 17 — The Maybe: The Dignity of Not Knowing

The fog came up off the river lowlands like the crater was exhaling.

Lens had been on the ridge since four, before the gate, before the foundation's surveyors with their thermoses and their lanyards, before even the cicadas had decided whether they meant it today. She had climbed the overlook trail in the dark with the camera against her sternum, the way she'd carried it across three borders that didn't exist anymore, and now she crouched at the rim of the egg — the oval mound the serpent holds in its open jaws — and waited for the sun to do the thing the literature said it would do.

The literature was very confident about this. She'd read it on the drive in, the printouts crackling in her lap while Frik narrated road signs nobody asked about. Hively and Horn, 1982. Romain, 1991. Lepper, 1998. The serpent's head points to the horizon where the sun sets on the longest day of the year, and the alignment is not a vibe, it is a measurement, surveyed and re-surveyed by men with transits and a healthy suspicion of their own enthusiasm. You can stand here on the solstice and watch the disc drop into the exact notch the head is aimed at, and it will not be an accident, because accidents do not survive that many decimal places.

That was last night. The solstice was done. The crew had watched it from the coils and Mara had watched it from somewhere she didn't tell them, and the sun had gone down precisely where the dead said it would, and nobody had said much afterward.

This morning the light came the other way.

Click.

Lens didn't think about the shutter. The shutter thought about itself; her finger was just the place it lived. What she thought about was the horizon, which was doing something the printouts had no column for. The crater rim out east bent the dawn — not metaphor, not exhaustion, the literal geology of a place where a rock the size of a town hit the Earth three hundred million years ago and shoved the limestone up into folds it had no business making. The cryptoexplosion structure. She loved that they'd called it that, the geologists, before anyone could stop them. *Cryptoexplosion*. A hidden bang. The whole ridge sat on the scar of a violence so old it had become scenery.

The sun rose into folded ground and the folded ground threw the light back wrong, soft and doubled at the edge, the way heat lies over a road. The serpent lay in it without commenting.

Click.

She had photographed it empty on purpose. No tourists, no schoolkids in the loud shirts, no Eric Sandoval pacing the parking lot rehearsing the word *experience* until it stopped meaning anything. Thirteen hundred feet of earth shaped into a thing that moves and does not move. Seven coils of body. The spiral tail wound so tight at the end it looked like the whole creature was screwing itself down into the rock to hold on. From the ground you couldn't read it. That was the part the brochure would never solve. You had to get above it — a tower, a drone, a hundred and thirty years of people climbing things to look down — and even from above your eye did the work the builders left for it, kept sliding the curves into a shape your animal brain insisted was *alive*.

Somebody built that so a sky-creature would see it. Or built it so a person standing in the egg at sundown on one day a year would know exactly where they were in the turning of the world. Or both. Or neither. The honest answer was the one the camera kept refusing to take a side on.

The fish wants the record to show it has read the literature and the literature is a swamp.

Two thousand years old or one thousand. Adena or Fort Ancient.

Take your pick, place your bet, the house always wins because the house is a charcoal sample under a serpent's belly and it will not stop disagreeing with itself.

Frik came up the trail around five-thirty making the small throat-sound he made when he was thinking, the one that wasn't words yet, the one he'd stopped apologizing for somewhere around chapter nine.

"You're up here taking the same picture Putnam took in 1886," he said. Not a hello. Frik didn't do the runway, he just landed the plane. "Different camera. Same problem. He couldn't read it from the ground either."

"Sit down, Frik."

He sat. He had the core-sample log on his tablet, the screen dimmed against the dawn, and he scrolled it like a man worrying a loose tooth. "Lepper's team, '96. University of Cincinnati. Charcoal from below the mound fill." He said it the way other people said a prayer they'd stopped believing but still found soothing. "Calibrates to about 1070 of the Common Era, plus or minus seventy. That's Fort Ancient. That's the headline. That's the one Sandoval's putting on the wall in twelve-point gold."

"And the other one."

"Putnam's stuff. The morphology. The artifacts. The whole twentieth century thinking this was Adena, three hundred BCE give or take, because it *looks* Adena, because the conical mounds right over there *are* Adena and they've got the burials to prove it." He flicked the screen. "And then somebody re-runs old samples and gets dates that smell Adena again, and maybe those are construction and maybe those are just somebody having a fire on a nice ridge a thousand years before anyone moved a basket of dirt." The throat-sound. "Both right. Both citable. Both peer-reviewed. As of right now, today, this morning, the literature does *not* close it." A pause she had learned to wait inside. "It can't close it. The thing won't give up its birthday."

He said it like an accusation and an apology at once, which was Frik's whole register, the only one he had. He could not make the data nicer than it was. It was the most honest thing about him and the

most expensive, and Lens had watched it cost him with Sandoval three days ago, watched him stand in the visitor center and tell the foundation's earnest project manager to his earnest face that *settling the date* was not a thing the science could currently do, that you could pick the answer that fit the brochure but you could not pick the answer that fit the carbon, because the carbon refused to be picked.

Sandoval hadn't gotten angry. That was the worst of it. He'd nodded, and written it down, and said *we'll find language for that*, and Lens had understood then what they were racing. Not a villain. A man with a budget and a deadline and a sincere desire to give the world a clean story it would pay to hear. The cleanest stories cost the most to tell, and somebody always paid in the truth.

"You going to put it in your dailies?" she asked.

"Already did." He turned the tablet face-down on the grass, which from Frik was a kind of tenderness, the way another man might close a door softly. "I'm not going to say it again, though. To her."

Lens looked at him.

"She knows," Frik said. "Mara knows the date doesn't close better than I do. I keep telling her the carbon's a mess like I'm bringing her news." The sound. "It's not news to her. It's her — it's *hers*. I'm reading the dossier at her about her own ground." He scratched at his wrist, hard, the tell. "So I'm going to shut up about it. That's — that's me. Shutting up. Write that down, it won't happen twice."

Lens almost laughed and didn't, because the light was doing the thing again, doubling at the rim, and she had the camera up before she decided to.

Click.

Mara Tallchief came up at six with two paper cups of gas-station coffee and gave one to Lens without being asked, which was its own sentence.

She stood at the rim of the egg and looked east into the bent light and did not photograph it, did not measure it, did not narrate it. She just looked, the way you look at a relative's face. The crew had spent a week up here with radar and core logs and a transit, mapping the

way the coils tracked the low ground, the way each curve of the body sat just so against the hidden water — the springs, the seeps, the underground runs the limestone hid, the whole drainage of a wounded crater written in earth a person could stand on. Jakobus had walked it with her and the willow rod and said almost nothing, and what he said was a question: *what does a thing this shape, in this exact place, let a person do.*

A function. Not a meaning. Where the wet ground was. Where the year turned. A map you stood inside. A clock you walked. The kind of answer that didn't close the wonder, it opened a door in it.

But the function was hers to give. They'd all watched her decide how much to hand the camera and how much to keep, and they'd watched Sandoval's team learn — slowly, expensively — that the *what is it for* was not a fact lying in the dirt for the best-funded reader to lift out. It was a thing a custodian held, and chose, and granted on terms.

"Eric came to the house last night," Mara said.

Frik went very still.

"The foundation will keep the application open-ended." She turned the coffee in her hands. "The date stays unsettled on the panel. Both readings. Both citations. They wanted a number on the wall. They're getting a debate on the wall instead." A small dry sound that wasn't quite a laugh. "He called it *a unique opportunity to model scientific humility for visitors*. I let him have the sentence. It's a good sentence. He earned it."

"You let him," Frik said.

"I kept interpretive authority." She said it flat, no flag on it. "Written in. The function's described the way I describe it or it isn't described. The age stays open because it *is* open, and I'm not signing a thing shut so a man can sell it cleaner." She looked at the serpent. "They wanted me to settle it. I told them the dignity of the place is that it isn't settled. That a person can stand here and not know, and that not-knowing is not a failure of the science. It's the size of the thing."

Lens kept the camera down. Some sentences you do not photograph. You let them go into the air and stay there.

"You could have told them the carbon's a mess," Frik said. "Made

them—”

“You already told them the carbon’s a mess, Frik.” Mara’s mouth moved, almost fond. “Loudly. To everyone. Three times.” The almost-laugh again. “I didn’t need the carbon to be a mess. I needed it to be *mine* to call open. There’s a difference.”

There was. Frik sat with the difference. Lens watched him sit with it, watched him not say the next true thing, watched him do the hardest thing his wiring asked of him, which was to leave a silence standing because someone else’s silence belonged in it.

The sun cleared the bent rim and the doubling stopped. The horizon stiffened into an ordinary line. For one held second the whole ridge had been an optical instrument — crater and effigy and the trick of the dawn light all aimed at the same impossible-to-prove intention — and then it was just a beautiful hill again, grass going gold, a serpent that wouldn’t tell you when it was born or who lay awake making it or whether the sky-creature it was built for had ever once looked down.

Below them the parking lot ticked with arriving cars. Schoolkids, by the sound. The loud shirts. A drone whirred up somewhere off the tree line — the foundation, getting its footage while the light was good, and they were welcome to it, the footage was free, the footage had never been the thing.

Mara finished her coffee. “I’m going down to meet the eight o’clock group.” She handed Lens the empty cup, an absurd small trust. “There’s a kid in there going to ask me how old it is. There always is.” She started for the trail, then stopped, not turning all the way around. “You know what I tell them?”

“What,” said Frik, who never could not answer a question.

“I tell them: we don’t know. And then I watch their faces.” A beat. “Some of them, it ruins their whole morning. Some of them, you can see it — the door opens. You can see them find out you’re *allowed*.” She went down the trail into the brightening day. “I do it for the ones the door opens for.”

Lens stayed.

Frik stayed a while and then didn't, drifting down after Mara because the eight o'clock group would have questions and Frik had not yet met a question he could leave on the floor, though he was learning, he was learning, you could see the effort on him like weather.

She raised the camera one more time. The serpent, empty, in clean morning light. The egg at the jaws. The seven coils. The tight tail screwing down into three hundred million years of healed-over violence. A made thing on a wounded ground, aimed at a sunset it had not missed in a thousand years, or two thousand, the dead declining to specify.

She had the frame. It was a good frame. It would print well; it would say *ancient* and *unknowable* and *go book a flight*; it would be on a wall by autumn with a caption that, thanks to the woman walking down the hill, would not lie.

She thought about Sandoval, who'd wanted a number and got a debate, and who would survive it, and might even — she gave him this — come to like the debate better. She thought about the door Mara watched for, the one that opened in a kid when they found out *I don't know* was a thing a grown person was allowed to stand on.

The shutter was up. The frame was held. The light was perfect.

Lens lowered the camera.

Not because she had it. Because the picture wasn't hers to keep taking. The serpent had been read this week by the only person whose reading could close it, and she had declined to close it, on purpose, as a gift, and the least the camera could do was stop trying to do her job from above.

She stood in the egg with the lens pointed at the grass and let the place be what it was: unphotographed, unsettled, two thousand years old or one, a water map or a clock or a prayer the size of a hill, watched by nobody, watching back.

The cicadas started up, deciding at last that they meant it.

And the door stayed open, the way she'd been given to leave it.

Chapter 18 — The Gazette: Real, Debated, and Invented

Here's where we pull the curtain back and show you the wires. Not because the trick was a lie — but because you deserve to know which parts you can go check with your own two feet, and which parts we built to carry you there.

This is the Gazette. It runs at the back of every file. Three columns: **Real, Debated, Invented**. The fish insisted. He says it's the only honest thing we do, and he says it with his mouth full.

So. Let's sort the catch.

REAL — The Stuff You Can Stand On

Start with the dirt, because the dirt is real and it does not care about your brochure.

The Great Serpent Mound is in Adams County, Ohio. It is over 1,300 feet long — call it four hundred meters of earthwork uncoiling along a ridge above Brush Creek. Seven coils, a spiral tail wound tight as a watch spring, and at the head an oval feature, egg-shaped, open-mouthed. You can walk the trail around it right now, today, if you've got gas money and a free Tuesday. The visitor center is real. The cicadas are real. The way the heat sits on the grass at four in the afternoon and the whole ridge seems to hold its breath — that's real

too, though we'll grant you it doesn't show up in any peer-reviewed paper.

The crater is real. The mound sits on the rim of what geologists call the Serpent Mound Cryptoexplosion Structure — a meteorite impact site, the bedrock beneath the serpent shattered and shoved by something that hit Ohio a very long time before anyone thought to pile dirt into a snake. You don't have to take our word for it. The geology's mapped. The rocks are folded in ways that flat Ohio rocks have no business being folded.

Now the part that broke everyone's heart in the field, and we mean that with love: **the date is genuinely unsettled.** This is not us being coy. This is not a Why Files wink dressed up as a fact. The academic literature, as of 2024, has not closed it.

Here's the honest mess, both sides, full due:

In 1996, a team out of the University of Cincinnati — Bradley Lepper among them — pulled charcoal from beneath the mound and ran radiocarbon on it. The numbers came back around **1070 CE, give or take seventy years.** That lands the construction squarely in the Fort Ancient culture, and it's a strong, published, defensible result. Charcoal under the dirt is exactly where you'd want to find the campfire of the people who hauled the dirt.

But the older consensus — the one that held for most of a century — put the mound with the **Adena** people, roughly **320 BCE**, inside the broad Adena window of 800 BCE to 100 CE. That consensus was built on artifacts, on the morphology of the thing, on how Adena sites tend to look and where they tend to sit. It is not a guess pulled from a hat. Frederic Ward Putnam dug here in the 1880s and read it Adena, and people far smarter than your authors have stood on his shoulders since.

And then — this is the part the fish loves — some radiocarbon samples from the earlier work, and from later re-analyses, came back **older**, consistent with Adena activity on the site. Which proves the Adena were here. Which does *not* prove the Adena built the serpent, because people can use a ridge for a thousand years before anyone decides to make it look like a snake. A campfire under the tail might be the builders' supper. It might be somebody's great-great-great-grandmother's supper, eaten on the same ground long before the

first basket of clay went down.

So you've got two credentialed camps, both published, both armed with real data, and a hole in the middle that nobody has been able to fill. That is not a narrative device. That is the literature. Go read it. We've cited it at the bottom and we mean for you to.

The solstice alignment is **real**. This one you can verify with a calendar and a clear evening. The serpent's head points to the spot on the horizon where the sun sets on the summer solstice — the longest day. This isn't fringe. Archaeoastronomers have measured it: Ray Hively and Robert Horn took instruments to the ridge in the early 1980s; William Romain mapped it in 1991; Lepper wrote on it in 1998. The head looks at the longest sunset of the year, and it has been doing so, patient as a stone, while empires rose and fell and the gift shop changed its t-shirt designs.

Further alignments — to the lunar standstills, to other solstitial events out along the coils — have been *proposed*. Those are more debated, less settled, and we've put them in the next column where they belong.

One more real thing, because it surprises people: **no one is buried in the serpent**. It's not a tomb. The nearby conical mounds hold Adena burials, yes — but the effigy itself is empty of the dead. Whatever it's for, it isn't for keeping bones.

DEBATED — Where Honest People Disagree

Ownership is debated, and we want to be careful here, because this is not our argument to win.

Some Indigenous oral traditions hold the mound as a place of power. That is real and it is respected. But the *direct, continuous line* between any present-day Nation and the original builders — Adena or Fort Ancient — is debated among scholars and among Tribal historians themselves. We are not going to pretend that line is clean when the people who'd know best say it's tangled. Pretending would be a kind of theft, and we've done enough of that in this country's history.

Function is debated, and this is the heart of it.

What is the serpent *for*? You'll hear: ceremonial. Astronomical. A territorial marker. A cosmological diagram. A calendar in clay. All of these have advocates. None of them has won.

In the file, our character Jakobus reads the made thing the way he always does — not *who*, not *when*, but *what is it for* — and the answer that comes up the ridge is a function rooted in land and water: the coils tracing the way water moves on the ground, the placement chosen for the horizon it commands, the serpent as a working tool more than a sacred picture.

We need to be straight with you about that. The water-mapping reading, as we dramatized it, **belongs to a character, Dr. Mara Tallchief, and she is invented.** The *physical facts she reads* are real — the topography, the springs, the way a ridge in karst-influenced country channels water, the solstice sightline you can check yourself. But the synthesis, the reading offered “on her terms,” is a thing we built to honor a real principle: that the custodian out-reads the visitor, and the meaning is hers to give or withhold.

We did not invent a water map and slap “SCIENCE” on it. We dramatized a *way of looking* — function over myth — and we are telling you plainly in this column that the specific function remains, in the real world, an open question. The fish would like it noted that “open question” is his favorite kind of question, because nobody can make him stop asking it.

INVENTED — The Wires

The chase is invented. There is no Heritage Foundation Acquisition Team prepping a “World Heritage Experience” complex to bulldoze the visitor center. We made Eric Sandoval up. We gave him pressed polos and drones and earnest, marketable certainty because that’s the adversary this story needed — not a cabal, not a villain twirling anything, just the very human hunger to *settle a thing and sell it*. If you met Eric you’d probably like him. That was the point. The cost of certainty doesn’t wear a black hat.

The crew is invented. Frik, with his Tourette's and his compulsion to blurt the inconvenient true thing — invented, and built with care. We will say this once, plainly: his wiring is not a wound. It's how he sees. He reads the data and not the room, and on a ridge where two camps are both cherry-picking, the man who can't *help* saying "the radiocarbon doesn't close it" is worth his weight in cores. We did not write him to be cured. We wrote him to be right at the wrong moments, which is its own kind of gift.

Lens — the photographer, the camera always hovering at the edge, always being asked to lower — invented. The other crew, invented.

And Dr. Mara Tallchief, the local custodian who out-reads everyone and owns the answer: invented. We want to underline this because it matters more than the others. We made up a Native archaeologist so that we could dramatize a real ethic — *the local owns the reading* — without putting words in any actual living person's mouth. The temptation in a story like this is the white-savior beat: clever outsiders crack the natives' mystery. We built Mara specifically so that beat could not happen. The crew never solve the place. They are guests. They leave changed, holding less of the camera than she does, and that is the architecture, not an accident.

If any of that reads as us speaking *for* anyone — we didn't mean it to, and you should weight the invented column heavily when you decide what to carry away.

THE SOURCES (Go Check Us)

For the Fort Ancient date — the ~1070 CE radiocarbon result: Lepper, B.T., and colleagues, work coming out of the University of Cincinnati excavations of the mid-1990s. Look for the 1996 fieldwork and Lepper's subsequent publications.

For the Adena attribution and the older morphological consensus: start with the long record going back to Putnam's 1880s excavations, and follow the citations forward; the Adena case is built across decades of artifact and mound-form analysis.

For the solstice alignment: Hively, R., and Horn, R. (early 1980s ar-

chaeoastromical survey of the region); Romain, W.F. (1991); Lepper, B.T. (1998). The head-to-summer-solstice-sunset alignment is the well-supported one. The lunar and additional solstitial claims are the debated ones — read those with the cooler eye.

For the impact crater: the geological literature on the Serpent Mound Cryptoexplosion Structure. It's well-documented; you don't need us.

For the “no burials in the effigy” fact: the standard site descriptions and the contrast with the nearby conical Adena mounds.

We've kept this honest. Where we couldn't source a thing, we put it in the Invented column and told you so. The whole game falls apart if we cheat here, and we'd rather lose the game than cheat.

THE TURN

Here's the thing about the date.

We could've picked a side. It would've been *cleaner*. Cleaner sells. Eric Sandoval — the man we invented — wanted clean so badly he could taste the brochure copy. *Built 1070 CE by the Fort Ancient people. Or: Two thousand years old, raised by the Adena.* Either one fits on a plaque. Either one fits on a mug.

But the literature won't give you the plaque. As of 2024 the two camps are still standing on the ridge with their data, and the data won't break for either of them. The charcoal says one thing. The artifacts say another. The campfire under the tail could be the builders' or it could be a thousand years of suppers, and nobody — *nobody* — has closed the gap.

That's not a failure. We want you to sit with that. The unclosed gap is the most honest object on the whole ridge. It's the one thing up there that refuses to be sold.

The sun still sets where the head is looking. You can stand on the overlook on the longest day of the year and watch it do exactly what it's done since before the word “Ohio” existed, and you will not need a single one of our paragraphs to feel it. The water still moves on that

ground the way water moves. The coils are still wound tight, holding whatever they hold.

So we're not going to tell you who built it, because we don't know and neither does anyone with a badge. We're not going to tell you what it's for, because that answer — if it's anyone's — belongs to the people who never stopped knowing the ridge, and they get to give it or keep it.

What we'll tell you is this:

Go see. Drive the back roads, pay your few dollars, walk the trail clockwise around the tail and up to the head. Stand there at dusk. Bring a compass if you're the type. Measure the sightline for yourself on the right night and watch the sun drop into the notch the serpent's been staring at for centuries.

And then — this is the only instruction the fish ever fully endorsed — **leave room for maybe.**

Not the lazy maybe. Not the maybe that means "aliens, probably." The cold, generous, grown-up maybe. The one that says: *the smartest people who ever measured this still don't agree, and I am allowed to stand in that draught and not need it closed.*

The mound has been waiting a very long time. It can wait a little longer for you to make up your own mind — or, better, to decide you don't have to.

Door's open. Mind the cicadas.

— *filed*

Chapter 19 — How to Check: The Solstice and the Springs

The fish wants you to know, before we begin, that he has never once climbed a ridge, never sweated through a polo, never carried a tripod up a hill in July with the cicadas screaming like a kettle that won't quit. He floats. He heckles. He has opinions about your hiking boots. Take everything that follows in that spirit: this is the part where we hand you the map and step back, because the whole point of this book is that you don't have to take our word for any of it.

You can go. You can check.

So here is how.

STEP ONE: GO IN JUNE, AND GO EARLY

The Great Serpent Mound is in Adams County, Ohio, off State Route 73, and it is open most of the year, but the day you want — the day the thing was apparently *built for* — is the summer solstice. June 20 or 21, depending on the year. The longest day. The site sometimes stays open late for it; the Ohio History Connection and the local stewards have, in recent years, hosted evening hours. Call ahead. Confirm. Don't drive eight hours on a fish's say-so and find a locked gate.

Get there before sunset. Hours before, if you can. Because the first thing the place does — and it does it whether you came for the sun

or not — is unsettle the ground under your feet. You are standing on the rim of the **Serpent Mound Cryptoexplosion Structure**, a real, mapped, geologically bewildering scar. Most archaeologists and geologists read it as an ancient meteorite impact site: a place where the bedrock is shattered, folded, shoved upward in ways that have no business happening in the flat sediment of southern Ohio. The land rolls and buckles. You can feel it in the trail. The horizon does something to your inner ear.

Whoever built the serpent built it *here*. On the strangest ground for miles.

File that away. We'll come back to it, and so will you, about three times an hour, involuntarily.

STEP TWO: WALK THE WHOLE ANIMAL FIRST

There is a trail. Take it. The mound is over **1,300 feet long** — about a quarter mile of coiled earth — and the worst thing you can do is stand at one spot and decide you've seen it. You have not. From the ground, the serpent is a low green ridge, knee-to-waist high, and your eye keeps losing the line of it in the grass. There's an overlook tower, a metal thing, unromantic, and from the top the whole figure resolves at once: the **spiral tail**, the **seven coils** rippling along the ridge, the long neck, and at the head an **oval feature** — the "egg," the "eye," the open mouth, depending who's describing it.

Stand up there long enough and a tour guide will tell you the official story, straight, and it is worth hearing straight, because it is genuinely good.

The serpent is an *effigy mound* — a sculpture in earth, not a grave. And here's a thing people get wrong all day: **there are no burials inside the snake**. The conical mounds nearby hold Adena burials, yes. The serpent itself holds none that anyone has found. It was not built to keep the dead. It was built to *be looked at*, or to *look*, or to *point* — and the question of which is the question that this whole book has been failing, gloriously, to answer.

As for who built it and when: hold onto your hat, because that is Step

Three, and Step Three is a swamp.

STEP THREE: KNOW THAT NOBODY KNOWS HOW OLD IT IS

We are not going to relitigate the whole dating war here — that's the back appendix, with the footnotes, where the fish can't reach. But you need the shape of it before you stand on the ridge, because it changes what you're looking at.

Two camps. Both credentialed. Both published. Both, as of this writing, unresolved.

Camp Adena says the mound is roughly two thousand years old or more — the Adena culture, which built conical burial mounds all over this part of Ohio between roughly 800 BCE and 100 CE. The old consensus, built on artifacts and the *shape* of the thing and the Adena mounds sitting right next door, put construction somewhere around 320 BCE.

Camp Fort Ancient says no. In 1996, a team from the University of Cincinnati (Lepper and colleagues) pulled charcoal from *beneath* the mound and radiocarbon-dated it to about **1070 CE**, give or take seventy years — which would make it the Fort Ancient culture, a thousand-plus years younger than the old story.

And here is the potato, the thing that makes this site such a beautiful headache: **both readings have real evidence, and neither has closed the case.** Older samples from older digs (going back to Putnam in the 1880s) have produced dates consistent with Adena — but those might date *earlier use of the site*, not the building of the mound. The charcoal under the mound might date the construction — or it might date a campfire someone lit during a later repair. The dirt does not come with a receipt.

You will read confident articles. You will see confident plaques. Both numbers — the BCE one and the CE one — are sitting in the peer-reviewed literature *right now*, unreconciled, defended by serious people who are not fools.

So when you stand on that tower, you are standing over a mystery with **two correct-sounding answers and no settled one**. That is not a failure of science. That is the front edge of it. Enjoy the vertigo. You earned it on the drive.

STEP FOUR: WATCH THE HEAD AT SUNSET (THE PART YOU CAME FOR)

Now the sun.

The thing you can verify with your own two eyes, no carbon, no controversy, is this: **the serpent's head points at the place on the horizon where the sun sets on the summer solstice**.

This isn't fringe. This is the careful, conservative, peer-reviewed finding — Hively and Horn looked at it in the early 1980s; Romain and Lepper worked the alignments through the 1990s. The head and the oval at the mouth orient to the summer-solstice sunset point on the northwest horizon. On the longest evening of the year, if the sky co-operates, the sun goes down *right where the serpent is looking*.

Here is how to actually watch it, so you don't blow the one shot:

- **Get into position an hour early.** Find the overlook and find the line of the head. You want the long axis of the neck and the egg leading your eye out to the northwest tree line.
- **Bring something to sight with.** A compass is fine. A phone with a decent sky app is better, because you can pre-load where the sun *should* set and confirm you're standing in the right relationship to the figure.
- **Watch the tree line, not the sun.** The drama isn't a laser beam. It's slower and stranger than that. The light reddens, the coils throw long shadows down the ridge, and the sun lowers into the exact notch the snake's mouth is aimed at. People go quiet. The cicadas don't.

Now — the fish insists we say this, and he's right — **an alignment is not a proof of intent the way a brochure wants it to be**. Lots of things point northwest. The summer-solstice sunset is one of the most natural targets in the world to build toward, because it's the

turn of the year, the high-water mark of light. So the alignment being *real* (it is, you can check it) does not by itself tell you *why* — and it does not, by itself, settle whether Adena or Fort Ancient hands shaped the mouth. (There are also *proposed* lunar-standstill alignments here. Those are more debated, less agreed-upon, and you should treat anyone selling them as certainty with the same friendly skepticism you'd bring to a guy selling you a watch out of a coat.)

What you can say, standing there, is small and solid and enough: *the head is aimed at the longest sunset of the year, and on the longest day, that is where the sun goes*. That's checkable. That's yours.

STEP FIVE: NOW LOOK DOWN — FIND THE WATER

This is the step the brochures skip, and it is the step that nearly broke us open.

The serpent does not just sit *on* the ridge. It rides the spine of it. And a ridge in this shattered crater-country is a watershed — a divide. Walk the figure with that in your head and something starts to itch. The coils don't flow randomly. They run with the high ground. The land on either side of the snake drains *away* from it, downslope, toward the lowlands and the Brush Creek below.

So here is what you do, and you do it on foot, slowly, after the sun is down and the crowd thins:

- **Notice where the ground gets soft.** Where the grass goes greener and ranker. Where, after rain, the trail holds water.
- **Trace where the water *wants* to go** off the ridge — the little gullies, the seeps, the places a spring would surface.
- **Lay that, in your mind, against the coils.** Ask whether the body of the serpent is following the line that water *can't* cross.

We are not going to tell you what you'll conclude. That's not ours to hand you, and you'll see why in a moment. But we'll tell you what happened to us: Jakobus, who reads made things the way other people read faces, walked the whole length of it twice without saying a word, and on the second pass he stopped at the third coil, crouched, put

his palm flat on the slope below the mound, and looked at our local — at Dr. Tallchief — and asked the only question he ever asks.

What's it for.

And he didn't answer it. He waited. Because the answer wasn't his.

STEP SIX: LISTEN TO THE PERSON WHOSE LAND IT IS

Here is the part of the how-to guide that isn't about compasses.

You can check the solstice. You can map the seeps. You can read the dating war until your eyes cross. All of that is open to you, freely, and we put the sources in the back so you can do it without us.

But there is a layer of this place that is **not yours to take just because you climbed the hill.**

When Mara Tallchief read the mound for us — read it as a thing that *works*, that *did* and maybe *does* a job, sited where the strange ground and the water and the longest sunset all meet — she gave us a piece of it and kept a piece of it. On purpose. With her hand flat on the same slope Jakobus had touched, she told us exactly as much as she meant to and not one syllable more, and when Frik — God love him, the man cannot hold a true thing in his mouth — started to blurt the next inference, the obvious one, the one that would've looked great on a placard, he stopped himself. First time we ever saw him do it. He shut his jaw on a fact because the fact wasn't his to give away.

That's the lesson the heritage people had to learn the hard way, and it's the one we'll leave you with at the trailhead.

Go. Stand on the rim of the crater on the longest evening of the year and watch the sun fall into the serpent's mouth. Bring your compass and your skepticism and your wonder, all three, all at once. Trace the water. Read the controversy. Decide for yourself how old it is, and then have the courage to say *I don't know*, because the people with the badges don't know either, and saying so is not weakness, it's accuracy.

But understand that the deepest reading — the *what is it for*, the living meaning that comes down through the people whose ancestors knew this ground — is not a coin in a slot. It is offered, or it is withheld, by the ones it belongs to. You don't earn it with a hike.

The fish, who has been quiet for an unusually long stretch, has one last thing, and for once he isn't heckling.

Wonder is for everyone. The sunset, the springs, the open question, the right to stand on a hill and feel the horizon bend — all of that is yours, no permission needed, go.

But not everything is for everyone to know.

Walk up the ridge. Look where the snake is looking.

And know when to stop asking.

Chapter 20 — The One Hole: The Unclosed Age

The visitor center had a folding table by the window, and on the folding table somebody from the foundation had laid out a timeline. Laminated. Handsome. It started at the left with a little icon of a spear point and ended at the right with a little icon of a smartphone, and somewhere in the middle, in confident sans-serif, a single date sat in a box of its own: **1070 CE**.

Frik stood in front of it with a paper cup of machine coffee going cold in his hand and read the date out loud twice, the second time with a hitch in it, a small swallowed bark he didn't fight.

"That's a guess wearing a tie," he said.

Eric Sandoval, to his credit, did not flinch. He'd printed the thing himself; you could see him deciding whether to defend it. "It's the published date," he said. "Lepper, Frolking, the Cincinnati radiocarbon work. Ninety-six. Peer-reviewed. I didn't make it up."

"No," Frik agreed. "You didn't make it up. You just put it in a box."

Outside the window the ridge held the morning the way it always did, the coils green and indifferent under a sky already going white at the edges. Cicadas warming up. Somewhere down the trail a fourth-grade class was being counted, twice, by a teacher who did not trust her own first count.

Here is the box, then. Open it slowly. It deserves slowly.

In 1996, a team led by Robert Fletcher and Terry Cameron, with Bradley Lepper and others, went back into trenches that had been cut into the Serpent's body and pulled charcoal from the fill — bits of burned wood that had ended up *inside* the construction. They ran it through accelerator mass spectrometry at the University of Cincinnati. The numbers came back clustered around 1070 CE, give or take seventy years. (Fletcher, Cameron, Lepper, Wymer, and Bowen, *Serpent Mound: A Fort Ancient Icon?*, published in 1996.)

That date does something enormous. It yanks the Serpent out of the deep past and sets it down in the same window as Cahokia's great mounds across the Mississippi, the same century as the Norman conquest of England, the same handful of decades when a supernova or a comet may have lit the sky and — the argument runs — given a people a reason to build a great snake reaching for the heavens. The Fort Ancient people lived here then. They left pottery, hearths, a village. The math is tidy. The story is *good*. Sandoval was not wrong to love it.

But.

Before 1996, the consensus had been Adena. Older. Much older. Frederic Ward Putnam dug here in the 1880s, saved the mound from the plow, and read the artifacts and the form of the thing as the work of the Adena culture — the people who raised the conical burial mounds standing a few hundred yards from the Serpent's tail, the people whose work fills the dirt of the Ohio Valley from roughly 800 BCE to 100 CE. By that reading the snake is around two thousand years old, maybe twenty-three centuries. (William Romain and others have continued to argue the Adena case in the peer-reviewed and gray literature; the morphological and contextual arguments never went away.)

And here is the thing the laminated timeline could not hold:

Both camps have charcoal.

Re-analysis of older samples, and newer cores taken in the 2010s, kept turning up dates that pointed back toward the Adena window — material from the right depths, the right contexts, that simply does not agree with 1070. The 1996 team's defenders say those older carbons are *earlier use of the site* — somebody camped here, burned wood here, lived here long before the snake was raised, and that

old charcoal got scooped into the fill or sat in the soil beneath it. Plausible. Genuinely plausible.

The other camp says: or the snake is older, and the 1070 charcoal is from a *repair*, a refurbishment, a re-deposition during a later occupation — somebody coming back to a sacred place and tending it, re-piling the body, leaving their newer wood in the old form. Also plausible. Genuinely plausible.

So you have one mound, two charcoals, two cultures, and a thousand-year gap between the answers — and as of 2024, in the actual peer-reviewed literature, the case is **not closed**. Both sides are published. Both sides are credentialed. Both sides have material in the ground. Nobody has a sample that kills the other guy.

“It’s the cleanest mess I’ve ever seen,” Frik said, and meant it as praise.

Lens had the timeline in the corner of a frame, the laminate throwing a window of glare across **1070 CE** so the date sat in a little bar of white light, half-erased by the morning. She didn’t say what she was doing. She just held it there, the date drowning in its own gloss, and waited for the cicadas to crest before she let the shutter go.

The fourth-graders came through then, herded, sticky, magnificently uninterested. One of them — a kid in a dinosaur shirt, of course it was a dinosaur shirt — stopped in front of the table, sounded out the box, and asked the teacher: “Is it that old or older?”

“Older,” said the teacher, who had clearly toured the gift shop’s brochure.

“It says ten-seventy.”

“That’s old.”

“Is it the *oldest*?”

And the teacher, God love her, said the truest thing anyone had said in that building all week: “I think they’re still arguing about it.” Then she counted the children again and moved them along.

Frik watched them go. His shoulder jumped, twice, a tic he let ride. When he spoke it was quieter than usual, which from Frik was its own

kind of alarm.

“That’s the whole book,” he said. “That kid just did the whole book.”

The thing the box does — the thing the brochure does, the *World Heritage Experience* does — is it answers the wrong question first. *When*. Sandoval needed a *when* because a *when* goes on a plaque, a *when* anchors a date for the gala, a *when* lets you tell a visitor in ninety seconds why they drove two hours down a county road to look at a hill shaped like a snake. A *when* is *marketable*. You cannot sell a *maybe* to a board.

Mara found them at the table around noon. She’d been on the ridge since dawn with the radar cart; she had the sunburn-and-mosquito look of someone who’d spent the morning being out-stubborned by ground. She looked at the timeline for a long moment. She did not touch it.

“You’re going to want me to fix that,” she said to Sandoval. Not a question.

“I want you to *confirm* it,” Sandoval said. “If the data supports it. That’s all. Your name on it. The Foundation isn’t trying to —”

“I know what the Foundation’s trying to do.” She said it without heat. “You want one number so the building can have a story. I understand the building needs a story.” She tapped the edge of the table, near the box, not on it. “Here’s the trouble. I can’t give you that number and still be telling the truth. And the part of this that’s mine to keep is the truth.”

Frik, who had spent his whole life being unable to keep a fact in his mouth, watched a woman decline to give a man the answer he wanted, and *keep* the decline — hold it, calm, no triumph in it, no apology either — and something in him went still with respect.

“I could give you 1070,” Mara went on. “I could give you 320 BCE. There are real scientists who’d back me on either one and not be wrong. That’s not a failure of the science.” She looked out the window at the coils. “That’s the science being honest about a thing that’s genuinely hard. You want me to launder the hard part out so the plaque reads clean. I won’t.”

“It’s not that I want it *clean* —” Sandoval started.

“It’s exactly that you want it clean,” Frik said, helpful as a dropped wrench. “You want it clean for the brochure. There’s nothing wrong with wanting it clean. It’s just not *true*, the clean version. The true version’s got two charcoals in it and a thousand-year hole and nobody’s filled the hole. You can sell the hole. People love a hole. The kid in the dinosaur shirt loves the hole.”

Sandoval rubbed his eyes. He looked, for a second, less like an adversary and more like a man who had promised a board a deliverable and was discovering, late, that the deliverable did not exist. “You can’t put ‘still arguing’ on a plaque.”

“Sure you can,” said Mara. “Watch me.”

So let us be cold-eyed about it, the way the chapter promised. Let us be the kind of cold that does not sneer.

What we *have* is real. We have AMS dates from 1996 that point to circa 1070 CE, published, replicable, defended for nearly thirty years by serious people. We have artifacts and mound morphology and the deep Adena context of the surrounding earth that point to something far older, defended by other serious people for far longer than that. We have older radiocarbon from earlier and later work that does not agree with 1070 and has not been made to agree by anything but interpretation — *was it construction, or use, or repair?* — and that question, that exact question, is the unclosed door.

What we do *not* have is the killer sample. The one core, the one charcoal lens locked unambiguously inside the original build, dated tight enough and contexted clean enough that one camp folds. It has not been pulled. As of 2024 it has not been pulled. People keep going up that ridge with carts and augers and grant money, and the ground keeps handing back an argument instead of an answer.

That is not woo. There is no comet you need, no lost race, no skeleton nine feet tall buried under the visitor center gift shop. (There is not. There has never been credible evidence of one. The fish would like that on the record.) You don’t need to reach past anything. The plain, sourced, peer-reviewed fact is enough to keep you up at night: *we built a thing this big and we cannot say within a thousand years when.*

A serpent thirteen hundred feet long. The largest effigy mound on Earth. And the calendar shrugs.

Late in the day, when the fourth-graders were gone and the foundation's drone was back in its case and the light was starting to do the thing the light does here, going gold and long across the coils, Frik went and stood by the timeline one more time. He'd been carrying something all afternoon, a fact, the way he carried all facts — out loud, immediately, helplessly.

He didn't say it.

He looked at the box, at **1070 CE** in its confident type, and he thought of the things he could add. He could say: *and the older carbons*. He could say: *and Putnam, and Romain, and the morphology, and the surrounding Adena dead*. He could lay the whole hole open right there on the laminate, correct the man's brochure word by word, and be entirely, defensibly right.

It was Mara's, though. The age. The keeping of it open. He had finally figured out the difference between a fact that wants saying and a fact that wants *holding* — holding so someone whose ground it actually was could choose when, and whether, and to whom.

So he set the cold coffee down next to the box, and he said nothing, and his shoulder jumped once in the quiet, and Lens, who had been waiting for exactly this, let the shutter go.

We are not going to settle it for you either.

This is the appendix, and an appendix is where a book usually pays its debts and tidies its desk and tells you, finally, what it knows. So here is what we know. We know the Serpent points its head at the place on the horizon where the sun goes down on the longest day of the year — you can stand there next June and watch it do that; Hively and Horn measured it, Romain measured it, the sky obliges. We know it lies on the rim of an ancient meteorite scar in the earth. We know it holds no dead. We know it is the biggest of its kind anywhere.

And we know that we do not know how old it is.

Not “we haven’t bothered.” Not “the experts secretly agree and won’t say.” We mean it the honest way: two bodies of real evidence, two real dates a thousand years apart, no sample yet pulled that ends the argument, the literature open as of the day this went to press. Lepper et al. 1996, on one side. Putnam and the morphologists and the Adena context and the discordant older carbons, on the other. Go read them. We’ll list them. They contradict each other in print, by people far more careful than us, and neither has surrendered.

That’s the hole. We didn’t dig it. It was here.

It is real, and it is checkable, and it is — for now, and maybe for good, and that is allowed — yours.

Chapter 21 — The Why Files Move: Open Case Forever

The van smelled like cold coffee and warm electronics, and somewhere in the back the fish — a betta named Subpoena, in a jar bungeed to the gear shelf — flared his fins at his own reflection and found it wanting.

Frik had the laptop open on his knees, the door rolled back, the ridge gone violet behind him. Lens was packing the long lens away one foam-fitted piece at a time, the way she did everything, like the world might still need her hands free. Down the slope the foundation's trucks were loaded too, polos folded back into duffels, drones in their padded coffins. Eric Sandoval stood by his rental with a clipboard he wasn't reading. He'd stopped reading clipboards two days ago. That was the thing about Eric. He'd come to settle a story and he was leaving with a worse one, by which I mean a truer one, by which I mean none.

"I want to do the thing," Frik said.

"Don't do the thing," Lens said, not looking up.

"I'm doing the thing."

The thing is the recap. The Why Files Move, all five beats laid out cold on the table like a hand of cards, so the reader can see exactly how they were played and decide for themselves whether the dealer was honest. We don't hide the mechanism. That's the whole point. A magician hides the wire. We hand you the wire and dare you to find where it goes.

So.

The Official Story, straight. Here it is, and I mean it with my chest: somebody built a snake. Thirteen hundred feet of it, a quarter mile of piled earth coiled along a ridge in Adams County, head pointed at the place on the horizon where the sun drops on the longest day of the year. Seven coils. An oval at the mouth — call it an egg, call it the sun the snake is swallowing, call it whatever your grandmother called it. The people who built it did not have a backhoe. They had baskets and their backs and an idea so specific it survived two thousand years of weather and one nineteenth-century archaeologist named Putnam who liked it so much he bought it to save it. The official story is that human beings, with human hands, made a thing this large and this exact on purpose. That is the official story and it is *insane* and it is *true* and we should genuinely never get over it. The skeptics are right. The builders were geniuses. Both of those sentences fit in one mouth.

“Okay,” Lens said. “That one’s clean.”

The Potato. This is the part where the easy version turns out to weigh nine hundred pounds. Because the next thing anybody wants to know — the very next thing, every schoolkid on every field trip, every donor in every PowerPoint — is *how old is it*. And the answer, after a hundred and forty years of credentialed people with good equipment and better intentions, is: nobody can close it.

Frik read it off the screen like he was reading a charge sheet, because to Frik a fact you can’t pin is a kind of crime against the world.

“Nineteen ninety-six,” he said. “Cincinnati. Lepper and the crew pull charcoal from under the mound and the carbon comes back around ten-seventy of the Common Era, plus or minus seventy. That’s Fort Ancient. That’s a thousand-year-old snake, give or take a coronation.”

“And the other guys,” Lens said.

“The other guys had it for a *century* before that. Morphology. Artifacts. The whole shape of the thing says Adena, and Adena means old — eight hundred before the Common Era to a hundred after, call the headline three-twenty BCE. So that’s a two-thousand-year-old snake.” He scrolled. “And then it gets *worse*, because some of the older samples, the re-analyses going back to Putnam’s dig, come back old too — but maybe that’s just somebody *standing there* a long time ago. Older fire under younger dirt. Lunch, not labor.”

That's the potato. Not one story breaking. Both stories holding. Two camps, both with degrees on the wall and peer review behind them, both pointing at the same pile of dirt and reading completely different millennia out of it, and the dirt declining to take a side. You bring science. Science brings a knife to a knife fight and somehow nobody bleeds and nobody wins.

Eric had walked up the slope while Frik talked. He stood at the edge of the van light with his folded-back clipboard and listened to a man recite the precise reasons his brochure could never exist.

"You could've left that part out," Eric said. Not angry. Tired in the good way, the way you get after you set something heavy down.

"No," Frik said. "I really couldn't."

It's worth saying — and Mara said it first, days ago, which is why it's hers and I'm only borrowing it — that the dating war is not a *failure*. Everybody treats it like a failure, like a test the site keeps flunking. The site is not flunking. The site is fine. The test is fine. The people are fine. The two answers just both happen to be standing in the room, and our discomfort with that is *our* problem, not the snake's.

The Hole. Here's the one we couldn't fill, and I want you to feel how cold it is before anybody warms their hands at it.

The sun sets on the snake's head. On the solstice. Every year. You can check this. Hively and Horn checked it in '82, Romain checked it, Lepper checked it, and you, reader, can drive to Adams County in June with a level and a compass and check it your own self, and the horizon will do the thing it has always done. That alignment is real. It is not theory. It is geometry, and it is patient, and it does not care which culture you assigned the snake to in your dissertation.

And the hole is this: *neither* known culture left anything else quite like it. Not at this scale. Not in this form. Adena built mounds; they didn't build a quarter-mile effigy with a solar headpoint. Fort Ancient built towns; they didn't, anywhere else, build *this*. So you've got a thing that points at the sky with perfect intention, sitting on the seam between two cultures, and the carbon won't tell you whose hand pulled the trigger, and the form won't match either family album.

Lens snapped the last latch on the camera case. "That's the part that doesn't sleep," she said.

It isn't. You can debunk the giants — there are no giants, there were never any giants, anybody selling you giant skeletons is selling you a parking lot. You can debunk the lost civilization — it's not lost, real people lived here and their descendants are down the road right now deciding whether to come up the ridge or stay home, and either choice is theirs to make. You can clear all of that out, every bit of the fringe, label it and box it and set it by the door. And the hole is *still there* after you've cleaned the room. Right form. Right sun. Wrong certainty. Real, cited, checkable, and open.

We don't reach past it. That's the rule. You do not stand in front of an honest hole and shout *aliens* into it just to hear the echo come back the shape of your own want. You measure it with a cold eye and you let it be the size it actually is. Which is plenty.

The Wink. So I'll name the question and I will not answer it, because answering it isn't my job and never was.

Why a serpent. Why *here* — on the rim of a crater, an actual cryptoexplosion structure, ground that buckled a quarter-billion years before any basket of dirt got carried up the hill, ground that rolls *wrong* under your feet in a way you feel before you understand. Why point the head at the longest day. Who was meant to see it, and who was it for, and what were they being told.

I have a feeling. I'm not telling you my feeling. You'd just adopt it, and then it'd be a fact in your head that was never a fact, and I'd have done to you the exact thing this whole book is trying to teach you to refuse. The wink isn't a withheld answer. The wink is the door left honestly ajar.

Subpoena flared at the laptop glow. The fish has opinions about doors.

And then — because The Why Files Move has a fifth beat, the one that matters, the one Jakobus carries up every ridge like a man carrying a level — **What Is It For.**

Jakobus had been standing apart all evening, the way he does, off his home ground and content to be furniture, letting the night do the talking. He doesn't ask *who*. He doesn't ask *when*. He looks at a made thing the way a locksmith looks at a lock, and he asks the one

question that assumes a maker with a purpose: *what does this thing do.*

He'd asked it at dusk, two days back, with the radar units quiet and Mara crouched over her own maps, and he'd asked it the right way — which is to say he asked it and then he stepped back and gave the answer away before he could be tempted to keep it.

Because the answer was Mara's. It was always going to be Mara's. She'd out-read all of us from the first afternoon, not with better gear — our gear was fine, our gear was excellent, our gear gave us a beautiful inconclusive mess — but with the thing none of us had, which was *standing*. She knew where the water went. She walked the coils and read them down into the ground, where the springs run and the streams go dark under the ridge, and she showed us how the curve of the earthwork lay against the curve of the water, and she did not say *this proves it* because she is too good for *proves*. She said: *look at what it does. It holds the eye to the sun on the one day. It holds the body on the path the water takes. It is a thing you stand inside of to know where you are — in the year, in the land, in the turning.*

A horizon marker. A water map you walk. A key your feet turn.

That's the function. Grounded. Physical. Checkable, in its way — the springs are there, the sightline is there, you can put your boots on both. And it does the thing a real answer is supposed to do, which is the opposite of what the foundation wanted. The foundation wanted an answer that *closed*. Mara's answer *opened*. You tell a child the snake is a way of knowing where you are, and the child looks at the snake and then looks at the sky and then looks at the ground and the wonder gets *bigger*, not smaller. That's how you know it's true the way that matters. False answers shrink the world. This one made it enormous.

And she gave it to us — to all of you — *on her terms*, which included declining to tell us the age, because the age is not hers to settle either, and she would not pretend to a certainty she didn't have just because Eric needed one for the wall text. The hole stays open in her telling too. She just refused to let the hole be the *whole story*. The snake does its work either way. Ten-seventy or three-twenty, the sun still sets on the head. The water still runs where the coils run. The function doesn't need the date. That's the part that undid Eric, I

think. He came for a date and she showed him a thing that worked without one.

So here's where the foundation landed, and I'll say it plain because the man earned it: Eric didn't get his single marketable answer, and he stopped wanting it. The deal they're shaping now keeps the case open inside the visitor center instead of nailing it shut for the brochure. The mystery stays on the placard. Mara keeps the reading. The snake keeps its maybe. That's not a defeat. Nobody got defeated. A man came to certainty and certainty cost more than it was worth and he set it down. You're allowed to change. It's the most underrated plot in the world.

Frik closed the laptop. For once he didn't blurt the last fact, the one he was holding — I saw him hold it, saw the muscle in his jaw do the work — because the last word belonged to Mara and he'd finally learned that a fact you swallow for the right person is its own kind of truth-telling. Lens lowered the camera. Just set it on her knee, lens-cap on, the reader's eye finally allowed to rest. The frame was hers to set and she'd set it, and we were just the people who'd been lucky enough to stand in it.

We pulled out down the back road with the ridge behind us going to black and the cicadas filling in every space we'd left. Somewhere up there the head still pointed at a sunset that had already happened and would happen again, with or without us, with or without a date, with or without a single one of us ever solving a thing.

Here's the road, reader. Here's the whole of it.

You're allowed to say *I don't know*. That's the gift. Not the answer — the right to leave the door open without shame, to stand in the draught between *certain* and *fooled* and call it the best air there is. Somebody built a snake on a crater and aimed it at the sun and we cannot tell you for sure when, or for whom, and that is not a hole in the story. That *is* the story. The wonder was never in the closing. It was in the looking, and the looking doesn't stop because we packed the van.

The case stays open. It stays open forever. Go check the solstice yourself — June, a level, a clear west.

Subpoena flared one more time at the dark glass, found his own reflection still insufficient, and kept looking anyway.

Good fish.



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor